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Introduction to the Religion

What constitutes religion, and how is it defined across different contexts? How do individuals from diverse intellectual traditions, cultural regions, and religious backgrounds interpret its meaning and purpose? Furthermore, when, why, and how did religion originate? What motivates individuals to adhere to religious beliefs and practices? Why has religion remained a significant aspect of human society? This inquiry seeks to explore these and related questions through a structured and analytical approach.

Etymology:

Religion, derived from old French word "**Religiun**" means "Respect for what is sacred" and Latin word "**Religionem**" means "**Reverence for the gods**".

Modern Sense: "**Recognition of, and obedience to a higher unseen power**". Words "Creed", "Cult" and "Faith" are used as synonyms.

In Urdu, the word "**Mazhab** **مذهب**" which is originally an Arabic word means

"A way to go", "**A path to walk**", "A style", "A method" etc.

In Arabic, the word "**Deen** **دين**" is also used to describe a religion which literally means "Retaliation", "Recompense", "Requital", "Commandment", & "**Judgment**" etc., for example, Qur'an says "**مَالِكِ يَوْمِ الدِّينِ**" "The Master of the Day of Judgment".

Word Religion in the holy Qur'an:

The most appropriate of the above-mentioned Arabic words in the sense of religion, is "Deen". Although, Qur'an uses some other words as well in this sense like "**مِلَّة** ... Millah", "**سِرَاط** ... Siraat", "**مِنْهَاج** ... Minhaaj", & "**شِرْعَة** ... Shir'ah", but the word preferred and used most often in the divine guidance i.e. Qur'an and Hadith, it is "Deen **دين**" as it indicates to the requital and the recompense of the deeds in after life. The word "**Mazhab** **مذهب**" has not been used anywhere in divine scripture in the sense of religion as it does not express the exact sense of religion except in Urdu, instead, it is used in Arabic for "Point of view" & "School of thought".

1. Definitions & Concepts:

Religion has been interpreted in diverse ways by individuals across different regions, historical periods, and intellectual traditions. The following presents a selection of perspectives from Western scholars and philosophers, offering a broader and more nuanced understanding of the concept of religion.

Edward Burnett Tylor

1832-1917 (defines in his book "Primitive Culture") "The belief in spiritual being"

David Emile Durkheim

1858-1917 (writes in his book "The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life")

"Unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things"

William James 1842-1910

(Describes in his book "The Varieties of Religious Experiences") "The feelings, acts and experiences of individual men in their solitude, whatever they may consider the divine."

The crux of the western ideas is that the Religion to them is "A relationship to sacred & spiritual things, feelings in solitude & experiences of individuals."

2. Divine Perspective: (Eastern Perspective)

"Religion is a complete code of life set and sent down by the Creator, the Lord (God) through His messengers from time to time to guide His slaves (Mankind & Jinn) to the success in life and afterlife".

Analysis:

An analysis of these various perspectives reveals several key observations. Notably, many Western scholars tend to conceptualize religion primarily as a matter of thought or belief, often minimizing its practical dimensions. This theoretical orientation is reflected in broader Western societal attitudes, where religion is frequently viewed as a private affair, and its involvement in public life—particularly in political and economic institutions—is often resisted. This individualistic interpretation of religion, grounded in the diversity of personal beliefs and spiritual orientations, has become increasingly pronounced in the modern Western context.

In contrast, from a theistic or divine perspective—particularly within the Islamic tradition—religion is inherently practical and comprehensive in scope. **It functions not merely as a system of belief but as a complete way of life, with approximately 90% of its teachings centered on practice.** Furthermore, religion in this context is understood as a collective and socially integrated phenomenon, rather than solely a personal matter. This collective dimension underscores the notion that individual and communal success in worldly life is deeply interconnected.

3. Need for Religion:

Religion is an essential need of mankind as it **gives meanings** to the essence of life, creates objective of existence and establishes the core of mankind. This conversation requires further elaboration on these aspects.

Demand of Nature:

This is mentionable that liberty and freedom have ever been fascinated and desired for human beings and the fact is that man, on account of his natural desire, prefers liberation and emancipation over all kinds of confinements and limitations which are the

core of the religion, besides, on ground reality demonstrates that almost 80-85 % of the world population is affiliated to some religion preferring restrictions and confinement set by the religion over emancipation and freedom which is astonishing for man himself. This enigma is uncomplicated to solve.

In fact, association with some religion is the demand of the innate human nature man has been created with. Nature refers to an essential feature or characteristic of something by which that particular object is recognized and known. In case, if this feature is removed, that particular object remains not the same object any more. For instance, water is recognized and known for its liquidity and flow, if this feature is removed, it might be called as ice but not water any more.

In the same way, man has been created with a proviso to be bound to believe in some unseen super natural power. No matter if man recognizes him or not, because it is experienced more than once and proved that one decides and determines for some task and struggles hard to achieve the goal, one eventually fails despite all his determinations. Besides, suffering from undesired diseases, mishaps, demises and disasters demonstrate even compel man to believe in some other contradictive powerful being existing as dominant and more influential than man himself. Man, on account of his nature, is frightened that this power may cause to harm or destruct him in case if gets angry with man. As an end result, man yields to that power to secure himself from any expected or unexpected failure and mischief and to collect maximum benefits and advantages. It is thus the religion takes birth and it is only the belief in God which can give security to the self and mind, peace to the soul, meaning to the individual and the satisfaction to the human nature.

The Innate Human Nature:

The word 'Innate' refers to build in essential human features. Man has been created with an innate nature that compels him to believe in an unseen super natural power as God. The connection between spirituality and genetics has long been a topic of both fascination and controversy. A famous scientist in his groundbreaking work, *The God Gene: How Faith Is Hardwired into Our Genes*, Dean H. Hamer (2004) introduced the hypothesis that certain aspects of human spirituality might be biologically encoded in our genes. This hypothesis suggests that spiritual experiences, including a person's capacity for transcendence, may have an evolutionary and genetic basis, with the gene VMAT2 (vesicular monoamine transporter 2) at the forefront of this hypothesis.

In *The God Gene*, Hamer proposes that VMAT2, a gene responsible for the transport of neurotransmitters in the brain, may play a critical role in an individual's predisposition toward mystical experiences and spiritual belief. Hamer's work posits that individuals with certain variations of the VMAT2 gene may be more likely to experience self-transcendence — a key trait in spirituality — thus linking biological factors to religious or mystical experiences (Hamer, 2004). This hypothesis is grounded in the neuroscientific understanding of how neurotransmitters such as serotonin, dopamine, and

others influence mood, perception, and emotional states, potentially paving the way for transcendental experiences.

Dr. Andrew Newberg, a neuroscientist in the field of neurotheology, studies the connection between brain activity and spiritual experiences. His research suggests that specific brain regions are activated during mystical or religious states, indicating a neurobiological basis for spirituality. In *How God Changes Your Brain* (2009), Newberg explains how practices like prayer and meditation can alter brain function, enhancing feelings of peace and connection. His findings support Dean H. Hamer's "God gene" hypothesis, suggesting that spirituality may be biologically influenced, as certain brain circuits are more activated in individuals predisposed to spiritual experiences.

Craves of Mind for the Knowledge of Essential Facts:

The human need for a creed primarily derives from men crave to know himself and the universe around him. The need to find answers has always occupied the concern of human philosophies without reaching the definite solutions. Since their creation, people have had the nagging questions "From where?", "To where?" and why?". They are sometimes distracted by the demands of daily life, but they one-day return to these eternal questions.

Man wonders: from where did I and this immeasurable universe come?

Did I come into existence on my own or is there a creator who brought me to existence? Who is he? How am I related to him?

What about this vast land, sky, animal, vegetable, mineral, planets and stars? Why life is possible on Earth. When a man ponders over anything in the surrounding, he finds each and everything in our surrounding is a miracle but we don't perceive it like this because it happens on daily basis.

Did they come into existence on their own or is there some sovereign creator? What is after this life? What is after death? Where do we go after the short journey on this planet Earth? Does the story of life from birth to death have nothing beyond that? Do the virtuous who sacrifice their lives for good and truth meet the same end as the wicked and villainous who sacrifice others for their own desires and pleasure? Does life culminate only in death? Or is there some other life after death in which the virtuous are rewarded and the villainous are punished? And why was mankind brought into existence? Why were people endowed with mind, wisdom, knowledge and volition which distinguish them from all animals? Why does everything in heaven and on earth seem to be in his service? Is there a purpose to his existence? Does he have a mission in life? Or was he brought into existence only to eat as animals do and then expire as animals do? If there is a purpose to existence, what is it? How can this purpose be realized?

These questions have haunted man in every age and demanded answers that satisfy the intellect and soothe the heart. Answers like that are only found in religion or in a pure religious belief. It is religion that primarily teaches man that he came into

existence neither by chance nor on his own but he was created by a great Creator Who is his God, That God made man, fashioned him perfectly, gave him due proportion, breathed soul into him, endowed him with hearing, eyesight, mind and heart and granted him all sorts of blessings starting as an embryo in a mother's womb.

4. History & Background:

Through the history of religions, we come to know that religion has ever been the essential part of human life in every society. The Greek historian Plutarch (46-120 AD) writes, "In history, I have found cities without forts, cities without palaces, cities without schools, but never have I found cities without places of worship". For history of religion, we find archaeological evidences as well; likewise tablets of law by Hammurabi (2300 BC), a king of Babylon lived in Nineveh, the capital of Babylon, almost in the age of Ibrahim (AS). These tablets describe the laws containing some clauses derived from the divine teachings. Moreover, the ancient cemeteries like tombs & pyramids provide the big evidence for religion, because, burial itself, is the teaching of religion taught to mankind through the crows as per the revelation of Qur'an.

But, when and how did it start actually, history is silent and provides no definite answer. But, the divine scriptures like Qur'an & Bible reveal it well that the religion started with the very first person on this earth named Adam (AS).

Universal Features of Religions:

A large number of religions existing in the world are having a massive variety of thoughts and teachings, but some fundamental features are considered as universal and common between all of them, these are following....

Faith & Beliefs: All of the existing religions have the teachings consisting of thoughts called as beliefs. Although, these beliefs vary religion to religion in details, but are common being a theoretical part.

Rituals & Customs: All the religions hold some practical rituals being followed by the followers which later become the identification of that particular religion. This is the second feature common between all of the religions whether they are revealed or non-revealed. But, likewise beliefs, these rituals also vary religion to religion.

Ethics & Morality: All of the religions form their own concepts of good & evil and the curbs of ethical and moral values derived from their own thoughts and rituals. Although, some of the moral values are universal like speaking truth, not telling a lie and not killing the innocent one, but some may vary in various religions. This is very much possible that one value might be considered good in one religion but might not be in the other one.

5. Religion & Human life:

There is no second opinion in the fact that religion has ever been very influential and put a great impact on humanity, their personal as well as their collective life. Man, being follower of a religion, lives a satisfactory life as he thinks that he has established an

awesome relationship with the sacred super natural power that is dominant and holding the authority to benefice or destruct the human life. Besides, man needs psychological peace and spiritual strength occasionally and also needs a mighty and unfailing supporter at times of hardship and crisis. This is religion that holds man's life, hope and courage, when a person loses something or someone he loves, or fails to achieve something, or is stricken by misfortune and illness. The religious faith provides him support, strength, hope, condolence and patience.

Religion also affects the collective life of mankind. In fact, the societies are always established on the basis of religion and form their own civilizations and cultures. All the world's great civilizations are known by their religion like the Buddha civilization, the Hindu culture and civilization and the Muslim civilization are named after their religions. Moreover, the religion controls and governs the relationships between society members and makes every member observe his limits, refrain from trespassing the rights of others and not to overlook the welfare of the community for personal immediate gains.

6. Classification of Religions:

There are almost nine thousand religions including the tribal religions existing in the world. These religions have been classified into two major categories, Revealed & Non-revealed. Revealed refers to the claim by the followers in order to have some divine scripture for human guidance. Judaism, Christianity and Islam are considered as the revealed religions. Rest of the religions have been declared as non-revealed religions as they do not claim to have the divine scripture despite they have some sacred and holy books.

7. Theological Ideas:

The human search for meaning and transcendence has led to the development of a wide spectrum of theological and philosophical perspectives. These perspectives vary in their understanding of the divine, the cosmos, and the relationship between the two. The following outlines six major viewpoints regarding the existence and nature of God and the universe.

Atheism

Atheism is the doctrinal or philosophical position that denies the existence of God or any divine being. It often posits that the universe is self-existent and not contingent upon any supernatural entity for its origin or sustenance. Atheism ranges from explicit rejection of deities (strong atheism) to mere absence of belief in any god (weak atheism). Contemporary atheists often rely on naturalistic explanations of the universe and human existence, favoring empirical evidence over metaphysical speculation.¹

Agnosticism

¹ Martin, M. (2007). *The Cambridge Companion to Atheism*. Cambridge University Press.

Agnosticism is characterized by a position of uncertainty or non-commitment regarding the existence or non-existence of God. Agnostics maintain that the question of divine existence is inherently unknowable or currently unknown, thus refraining from definitive belief or disbelief. The term was first coined by Thomas Huxley in the 19th century to describe his epistemological stance on metaphysical matters.²

Deism

Deism affirms the existence of a Creator who initiated the universe but denies divine revelation and the ongoing intervention of God in worldly affairs. Deists argue that reason and observation of the natural world are sufficient to discern the existence of a supreme being, without reliance on sacred texts or institutional religion. This view was prevalent among Enlightenment thinkers such as Voltaire and Thomas Jefferson.³

Pantheism

Pantheism is the belief that God and the universe are identical, asserting that the divine is immanent in all aspects of the natural world. Rather than viewing God as a personal, transcendent being, pantheists equate divinity with the laws of nature and the cosmos itself. This worldview is found in various philosophical and religious traditions, including certain strands of Hinduism and the writings of Baruch Spinoza.⁴

Monotheism

Monotheism is the belief in the existence of a single, all-powerful, and transcendent God. This worldview forms the theological foundation of the Abrahamic religions—Judaism, Christianity, and Islam—all of which emphasize a personal deity who is both the creator and sustainer of the universe. Monotheism posits that divine revelation is accessible through sacred scriptures and prophetic traditions.⁵

Polytheism

Polytheism denotes belief in multiple deities, each typically associated with specific aspects of nature, human life, or cosmic functions. This system was dominant in ancient civilizations such as Greece, Rome, and Egypt, where gods and goddesses governed various realms like war, love, the sea, and the harvest. Polytheistic traditions often allow for fluid worship and integration of local deities.⁶

² Thrower, J. (1980). **The Alternative Tradition: A Study of Unbelief in the Ancient World**. Mouton Publishers.

³ Israel, J. (2001). **Radical Enlightenment: Philosophy and the Making of Modernity 1650–1750**. Oxford University Press.

⁴ Nadler, S. (2006). **Spinoza's Ethics: An Introduction**. Cambridge University Press.

⁵ Armstrong, K. (1993). **A History of God: The 4,000-Year Quest of Judaism, Christianity and Islam**. Ballantine Books.

⁶ Burkert, W. (1985). **Greek Religion: Archaic and Classical**. Harvard University Press.

Introduction to Islam

Islam (إسلام) is the name of a famous religion amongst the religions of the world. It is the religion of truth containing both thoughts and practices. According to the divine scripture ‘Qur’an’, it is the true religion with Allah the Exalted and the final and complete version of the Divine guidance.

Etymology

The word “Islam (إسلام)” is an Arabic word derived from “Salama (سلم)” which literally means "Peace" and "Safeness". The word “Islam (إسلام)” literally means "Obedience", "Submission" and "Surrender".

Definition & Concept

A complete code of life revealed by Allah (The Creator, the Owner, the Sustainer & the Lord) to His Prophets & Messengers (From Adam AS to the last of His messengers Muhammad a) from time to time to guide His slaves (Mankind & Jinn) for their success in life and afterlife.

Important Note 1:

Islam is unlike other religions as they contain some typical traditions and customs particularly at three occasions i.e. the birth of a child, the marriage and the death of a person, or maximum some rituals are being performed as worships. They do not have systematic and organized structure of worships, family dealings, social dealings, economic system, political and legal affairs based upon their religion.

On the other hand, Islam is a complete code of life and is fully equipped with teachings for every aspect of life. For instance, along with above mentioned disciplines of life, Islam also stresses upon daily routine of life such as eating, drinking, sleeping, dressing, and also commands to perform the necessities of daily life, as per the commandments of Islam.

Secondly, Islam is a divine religion set, chosen and revealed by Allah (The Creator, The Owner and The Lord of all the worlds). It is not a man-made religion. Its teachings are genuinely from The Lord and are beyond doubts. Allah the Almighty has sent its last version of Divine guidance to the last of His Messengers, Prophet Muhammad (a) through one of His angels Jibrael e who is considered as the chief of all of the angels as described by Almighty the Allah. He reveals in the Qur’an;

وَأَنَّهُ لَنَزَّلُ إِلَيْ رَّبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ ۖ تَزَلَّ بِهِ الرُّوحُ الْأَمِينُ ۖ عَلَى قَلْبِكَ لِتَكُونَ مِنَ الْمُنذِرِينَ ۖ بِلِسَانٍ عَرَبِيٍّ مُبِينٍ ۖ

And truly, this is the revelation from the lord of all worlds. The trustworthy spirit (Jibrael) brought it down. Upon your heart, so that you may become one of the warner. In plain Arabic language.⁷

⁷ Quran-26:192-195

The Subject of Islam:

The Subject refers towards the study of some particular thing or object which, as a topic, is discussed under a discipline. For example, human body is discussed under medical science. Therefore, it is the subject of medical science. And machine is the subject of engineering because it is discussed under the discipline of engineering.

In the same way, when Islam is considered as a discipline and the code for life, definitely there should be some subject to be discussed in it too. And the subject for the entire Islamic teachings is the human beings and Jinns being slaves to Allah the Exalted, as He says:

وَمَا خَلَقْتُ الْجِنَّ وَالْإِنْسَ إِلَّا لِيَعْبُدُونِ

*"I did not create mankind and Jinn except for the Purpose that they should worship me."*⁸

Islam reveals the teachings through which human beings may enable themselves to become good slaves to Allah the Almighty.

The Objective of Islam:

The objective behind this revelation of Islam is: To provide complete guidance to mankind and Jinn that leads them to the success in life and afterlife.

A noteworthy point should also be remembered that the actual concept of success, as per the interpretation of divine scripture al-Qur'an, lies down with safe removal from the fire of hell and the entrance into paradise. Allah the Almighty says:

فَمَنْ رُحِّحَ عَنِ النَّارِ وَأُدْخِلَ الْجَنَّةَ فَقَدْ فَازَ وَمَا الْحَيَاةُ الدُّنْيَا إِلَّا مَتَاعُ الْغُرُورِ

*"So, whoever is safely removed from the fire of Hell and admitted to Paradise, he succeeded indeed. And the worldly life is not but the goods of delusion".*⁹

The verse reveals that beyond this actual success, no worldly success is appreciable and reliable especially when this world itself is a mortal and until the man is safely removed from the fire of Hell.

Fore face of Islam:

In a very famous Hadith of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, entitled with Hadith-e-Jibraeel, Prophet Muhammad ﷺ introduced Islam by its face features as a reply to a question asked by Jibreel ؑ. For details, Hazrat Umar ؓ, reports that once Jibraeel ؑ came to see Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in the attire of a man while some of the companions (including reporter) were sitting around him in the holy mosque of Madinah. He asked few questions which were replied by the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ.

⁸ Quran-51:56

⁹ Quran-3:185

8. 1: Islam

Jibrael eked the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ about Islam, to which he replied that it consists of five pillars:

Shahada: Declaration of faith in the oneness of God and the prophet hood of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ.

Salah: Performing the five daily prayers.

Zakat: Giving alms to the poor and needy.

Sawm: Fasting during the month of Ramadan.

Hajj: Pilgrimage to Mecca for those who are able.

9. 2: Iman (Faith):

Jibrael e then asked about Iman (faith), and the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ explained that it involves belief in:

Allah

His angels

His books

His messengers

The Day of Judgment

Predestination (that good and bad are decreed by Allah).

10. 3: Ihsan (Excellence in Worship):

Jibrael e asked about Ihsan, and the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ explained that it is to worship Allah as if you see Him, and even though you do not see Him, you should know that He sees you.¹⁰

It is important to note that the teachings mentioned above represent only a small portion of Islamic teachings, not the entirety of Islam. Just as a person has organs and body parts beyond just the features of the face, Islam encompasses much more than what has been outlined here.

11. The Structure of Islam

Islam

└─ I. Foundations

| └─ 1. Tawheed (Oneness of God)

| └─ 2. Risalah (Prophethood)

¹⁰ Sahih Muslim:93

| └─ 3. Akhirah (Hereafter)

| └─ **II. Religious Structure**

| └─ **A. Beliefs (Iman – 6 Articles)**

- | └─ Believe in oneness of God
- | └─ Believe in the Prophets
- | └─ Believe in Angels
- | └─ Believe in holy Books
- | └─ Believe in the Day of Judgment
- | └─ Believe in the Desitny

| └─ **B. Practices (Ibadah – 5 Pillars)**

- | └─ Shahadah
- | └─ Salah/Prayer
- | └─ Sawm/Fasting
- | └─ Zakah/Obligatory Charity
- | └─ Hajj/Pilgrimage

| └─ **C. Sources of Law/Jurisprudence**

- | | └─ Qur'an
- | | └─ Sunnah
- | | └─ Ijma (Consensus)
- | | └─ Qiyas (Analogy)

| └─ **III. Islamic Systems**

| └─ **A. Social System**

- | | └─ Esteem system of Soul/Human Dignity

- | | └─ Family structure
- | | └─ Marriage & divorce laws
- | | └─ Gender roles
- | | └─ Rights of neighbors, orphans, etc.

| └─ **B. Ethical System**

- | | | — Halal vs Haram
- | | | — Personal integrity
- | | | — Justice ('Adl)
- | | | — Social values
- | | | — Antiquates
- | | | — Accountability before God
- | | — **C. Political System**
- | | | — Shura (Consultation)
- | | | — Caliphate / Imamate concepts
- | | | — Governance under Sharia
- | | | — Justice & law enforcement
- | | — **D. Economic System**
- | | | — Zakat (Wealth purification)
- | | | — Prohibition of Riba (Interest)
- | | | — Islamic banking & finance
- | | | — Principles of fair trade & charity

Why Islam?

The authenticity of Islam is often highlighted by the experiences of converts in Europe, the UK, and the USA, who find its teachings deeply compelling and transformative. Many converts are drawn to Islam's clear monotheism, the emphasis on personal responsibility, and the sense of belonging to a global community. The Qur'an's timeless and unaltered preservation, coupled with the simplicity and coherence of its message, offers a sense of authenticity that resonates with individuals seeking spiritual fulfillment and clarity in a complex world. Converts often speak of the inner peace they find in Islam's structured way of life, its emphasis on justice, and its comprehensive moral guidance, all of which stand in contrast to the perceived emptiness or disillusionment in other aspects of contemporary life. The growing number of conversions in these regions reflects Islam's enduring authenticity and relevance, as individuals from diverse backgrounds embrace its message of faith, unity, and purpose.

Islam's growth and appeal can be understood through several aspects that highlight its unique approach to spirituality, ethics, and societal structure, from an objective standpoint. Here are five factors that explain why many people choose to convert to Islam and find it compelling:

12. Monotheism (Tawhid) and Simplicity of God:

Islam's core belief in the absolute oneness of God (Tawhid) offers a simplified and clear understanding of divinity. In comparison to some other religious systems that involve complex theological frameworks or multiple deities, Islam's strict monotheism is straightforward, emphasizing the singularity and indivisibility of God. This simplicity can be an appealing factor for those seeking a direct, unambiguous concept of God. Converts, including notable figures like Cat Stevens (Yusuf Islam), have mentioned that the clear, monotheistic nature of Islam resonated deeply with them, especially in contrast to other religious concepts they had encountered.

13. Holistic Approach to Life:

Islam provides a comprehensive way of life that extends beyond spirituality to include social, ethical, and legal guidelines. This approach covers all aspects of human existence, such as family life, business ethics, community service, and moral behavior. This holistic structure appeals to those seeking order, meaning, and purpose in their lives. Converts, such as Lauren Booth, a British journalist who converted to Islam, have spoken about how Islam's all-encompassing framework gave them a sense of direction and clarity in everyday decisions, including family and work-related matters.

14. Universal Message for Humanity:

Islam is viewed as a universal message, not restricted to any particular culture or geographic region. It presents itself as a final, complete revelation for all humanity. This inclusiveness has made it appealing to a diverse range of individuals across the globe. Islam's emphasis on social justice, equality, and global brotherhood speaks to those looking for a faith that unites people beyond borders. Kristiane Backer, a German television personality who converted to Islam, has described how the universal nature of Islam, which emphasizes common values and shared human experience, was a key factor in her decision to embrace the faith.

15. Emphasis on Justice, Equality, and Social Welfare:

Islam's emphasis on justice and equality has been a central tenet of its appeal. The religion advocates for fair treatment of all individuals, irrespective of their social status, race, or ethnicity. The principle of charity (Zakat), which mandates Muslims to give a portion of their wealth to those in need, supports social welfare and addresses issues of inequality. In many conversion stories, individuals mention the appeal of Islam's social justice teachings. For instance, Muhammad Asad, a prominent convert and scholar, embraced Islam because of its ethical teachings and the religion's focus on addressing social inequalities and promoting the welfare of society.

16. The Qur'an as a Timeless Source of Knowledge:

The Qur'an is regarded by Muslims as the literal and unaltered word of God, preserved over time in its original form. For many converts, the intellectual and spiritual depth of the Qur'an is a compelling factor. Its linguistic beauty, combined with its

teachings on ethics, law, and spirituality, has been highlighted by converts as a source of profound wisdom. Dr. Garry Miller, Dr. Lawrence Brown, Yusuf Estes and many other converted scholars have advocated this fact.

Khadija Patel, a journalist and convert to Islam, has spoken about how the Qur'an's intellectual depth and its capacity to address both individual and societal concerns provided a powerful reason for her conversion.

These factors show how Islam's unique spiritual, ethical, and societal aspects appeal to a broad audience. The conversion stories of individuals from different backgrounds illustrate how these principles resonate with those seeking a clearer, more structured path in life, offering a balanced approach to personal, social, and spiritual fulfillment. In the end, it is also important to understand the status of Islam in the eyesight of Allah, the Lord of all the worlds. According to the divine scripture Qur'an, the concept of the finality of Islam contains following two points;

Finality of Islam

Islam (The final version, revealed upon Prophet Muhammad a) is the only religion with Allah the Almighty in true sense.

إِنَّ الدِّينَ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ الْإِسْلَامُ

"Truly, the religion with Allah is Islam".¹¹

Also one should not die without believing and following Islam. As Allah has warned clearly in the Qur'an stating;

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ حَتَّى تَقَارِئُوا وَلَا تَمُوتُوا إِلَّا وَأَنْتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ

"O you, who believe, be afraid of Allah, as He deserves to be feared, and let not yourself die save as Muslims."¹²

The concept of success in true sense i.e. the success in afterlife totally depends upon following this final version of Islam, and there is no other possible way or key to success. No other religion is acceptable to Allah, the Lord and the Master of the Day of Judgment. Allah has announced it in the Qur'an saying,

وَمَنْ يَلْتَمِمْ غَيْرَ الْإِسْلَامِ دِينًا فَلَنْ يُقْبَلَ مِنْهُ وَهُوَ فِي الْآخِرَةِ مِنَ الْخَاسِرِينَ

"And whoever seeks a religion other than Islam, It will never be accepted from him, and he, in the hereafter, will be among the losers".¹³

¹¹ Quran-3:19

¹² Quran-3:102

¹³ Quran-3:85

Also, dying without having faith in this final version of Islam will cause the definite & eternal punishment in Hell. Allah the Almighty states;

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَمَاتُوا وَهُمْ كُفَّارٌ فَلَنْ يُقْبَلَ مِنْ أَحَدِهِمْ مِلءُ الْأَرْضِ ذَهَبًا وَلَوْ افْتَدَى بِهِ أُولَئِكَ لَهُمْ عَذَابٌ أَلِيمٌ وَمَا لَهُمْ مِنْ نَاصِرِينَ

*“Those who disbelieve and die as disbelievers, an earth-full of gold even shall never be accepted from any of them, even if one were to offer it as ransom. They are the ones for whom there is a painful punishment, and for them there are no helpers.”*¹⁴

It has been categorically communicated in a hadith in following words: Abu Huraira رضي الله عنه narrated that the Messenger of Allah ﷺ said;

*“I swear by the one who holds the life of Muhammad, any of the Jew or Christian from among the people who comes to know about me, and then dies without having faith in what I have been sent with (Islam), he will definitely be among the hell members”.*¹⁵

¹⁴ Quran-3:91

¹⁵ Sahih Muslim:386

The Belief System of Islam

Definition of Belief (Iman) in Islam

The Arabic word for belief is "Iman", derived from the root 'a-m-n (أ-م-ن), which conveys the sense of security, affirmation, and trust. Linguistically, Iman means to affirm something as true and to feel secure in it.

Technical Definition (Islamic Terminology):

In Islamic theology, Iman refers to the firm conviction and acceptance of the truth of what was revealed by Allah through His Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. It is a comprehensive concept that encompasses belief in the heart, affirmation by the tongue, and actions by the limbs.

"Iman is to believe with the heart, confess with the tongue, and act with the limbs."

Belief in Islam is not limited to intellectual assent but is manifested through practice, character, and commitment.

17. The Importance of Belief in Islam

Belief is the foundation of a Muslim's identity and the first requirement for entering Islam. Without belief, acts of worship or righteous deeds are not accepted by Allah. The Qur'an emphasizes belief as the first pillar of righteousness and the gateway to salvation.

"Indeed, those who have believed and done righteous deeds — they will have the Gardens of Paradise as a lodging." ¹⁶

The Fundamental Beliefs in Islam (Articles of Faith)

The essential beliefs of Islam are known as the Six Articles of Faith (Arkan al-Iman). These are derived from the Qur'an and authentic hadith, especially the famous Hadith of Jibrīl (Gabriel)

Interrelation between Belief and Practice

In Islam, belief is not merely theoretical. It must be accompanied by righteous action. The Qur'an often couples "belief and good deeds" emphasizing the dynamic relationship between faith and practice.

Articles of Faith in Islam

- 1) Iman bi-Tawhid: Belief in the Oneness of Allah
- 2) Iman bil-Mala'ikah: Belief in Angels

¹⁶ Qur'an, 18-107

- 3) Iman bil-Kutub: Belief in the Books
- 4) Iman bir-Rusul: Belief in the Prophets
- 5) Iman bil-Yawm al-Akhira: Belief in the Last Day
- 6) Iman bil-Qadar: Belief in Divine Decree

Recommended Readings for Further Study:

- The Fundamentals of Tawheed, by Dr. Bilal Philips
- Islamic Belief System, by Jamal al-Din Zarabozo
- Selected chapters from Sahih Muslim and Sahih Bukhari on Iman

Iman bil-Tawhid (Belief in the Oneness of God)

Tawhid means attributing Oneness to Allah the Almighty and describing Him as being One and Unique, with no partner or peer in His Essence and Attributes.

Tawhid is the most sensitive and significant creed in the sight of Allah the Almighty. The foundation of Islam is based on this creed. Until and unless we don't have deep cognition of this creed our faith is at stake. We can never achieve the essence of Iman without comprehension of this belief. Without recognizing Him, we will never be able to develop a relationship with him.

We should strive to learn this fundamental concept of Monotheism. We should have our reasons and logic based on the Qur'an and Hadith to strengthen our belief in the existence of Allah the Almighty. We should develop a personal connection with Allah the exalted. When we will recognize Him in the true sense only then we will be able to follow Him in true letter and spirit. As mentioned in the Qur'an:

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى اللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ الْعُلَمَاءُ ۗ

*Those who truly fear Allah, among His servants, who know Allah.*¹⁷

Tawhid is the primary and core subject of the Qur'an. There is a hadith that mentions that Surah Ikhlas is one-third of the Qur'an.¹⁸ Surah Ikhlas has been given this status because of the theme mentioned in it. It solely elucidates the concept of Tawhid.

قُلْ هُوَ اللَّهُ أَحَدٌ ۝ اللَّهُ الصَّمَدُ ۝ لَمْ يَلِدْ وَلَمْ يُولَدْ ۝ لَمْ يَلِدْ وَلَمْ يُولَدْ ۝ وَلَمْ يَكُنْ لَهُ كُفُوًا أَحَدٌ ۝

¹⁷ Qur'an:5-8

¹⁸ Sahih al-Bukhari:5013

*(O Esteemed Messenger!) Proclaim: 'He is Allah, Who is the One. Allah is the Transcendent of all, the Protector and Far-Superior to all. He has not begotten any, nor is He begotten. Nor is there anyone equal to Him.'*¹⁹

Allah the Almighty is the most Unique and Exalted as He is the creator. Nothing can be brought into His comparison. He is the most Supreme Being in the entire world. He alone is the Sustainer of all the Universes and the whole creation. Everything is dependent on Him but He is independent of everyone. His being is the practical manifestation of absolute Oneness.

18. Importance of Tawhid in the Qur'an

Tawhid is the main theme, crux and focal teaching of the Qur'an.

*And We did not send any Messenger before you, but We revealed to him (saying): none has the right to be worshipped but I (Allah), so worship Me (Alone).*²⁰

And at another place in the Qur'an, Allah the Almighty mentioned,

*And verily, We have sent among every Ummah (nation) a Messenger (proclaiming): Worship Allah (Alone), and avoid (or keep away from) Taghut.*²¹

Repeatedly stating the subject of Tawhid in diverse ways and styles and at different places in the Qur'an indicates the emphasis and significance of the belief of Tawhid. Allah the Almighty used the exact statement for other Prophets in the Qur'an regarding Tawhid.

So, till the last messenger, the message of the Oneness of Allah the Almighty was sent to mankind which shows its high importance.

Types of Tawhid

- Rububiyah (Lordship)
- Uluhiyyah (Worship)
- Asmaa Was-Sifaat (Names and Attributes)

19. Rububiyah (Lordship)

This category is based on the fundamental concept that Allah the Almighty alone caused all things to exist when there was nothing. This is known as creation Ex Nihilo (Latin for creation out of nothing) is the doctrine that matter is not eternal but had to be created by some divine creative act.

¹⁹ Qur'an: 112:1-4

²⁰ Qur'an: 21-5

²¹ Qur'an: 16-6

He sustains and maintains creation without any need from it or for it and He is the sole Lord of the universe and its inhabitants without any real challenge to His sovereignty.

In Arabic, the word used to describe this creator sustainer quality is Rububiyah which is derived from the root “Rabb” (Lord). This is proved by Allah the Almighty statement in Surah Al-Fatihah, verse one where He says, “[All] praise is due] to Allah, Lord of the world’s mankind, jinn, and all that exists]”.

According to this category, since God is the only real power in existence, it is He who gave all things the power to move and to change. Everything is dependent on His become and He is the only independent Being. All these facts have been explained in Sura al-Naml in a comprehensive way from 60-65 verse.

20. Uluhiyyah (Worship)

This means having a firm conviction that only Allah is the true and only God worthy of worship. In Arabic, the term ibadah (worship) is associated with obedience, subservience, and submission. It has been defined by some scholars as “complete love accompanied by complete submission”. Thus, worship in all its forms cannot be dedicated to anyone else besides Allah the Almighty. It is important to point out that the concept of worship is all-embracing. Worship transcends the five pillars of Islam and covers all the good things and deeds that please Allah the Almighty. Therefore, things like supplication, reliance, obedience, subservience, and submission would be covered by this definition. All these things should be done solely for the sake of Allah the Almighty.

Evidence of this type of Tawhid is in Allah the Almighty statement “And I Allah did not create the jinn and men except that they should worship Me (alone)”. Surah Zariyat: 56]

‘Kalima’ as an example of Uluhiyyah

- ilah- one who is worshipped, on account of greatness and power is considered worthy to be worshipped.
- La ilaha illallah –There is no ilah other than one great being known by the name Allah the Almighty.
- It means that in the whole of the universe, there is absolutely no being worthy to be worshipped other than Allah the Almighty.
- That is only to Him our heads should bow in submission and adoration.

Our Prayers, charity, dua, tawaf, sajda, etc. are the acts of worship. If we perform them for anyone else other than Allah the Almighty then it is Shirk.

21. Asmaa Was-Sifaat (Names and Attributes)

This category of Tawhid has five main aspects:

- Unity of Allah the Almighty names and attributes to be maintained in the first aspect.
- Allah the Almighty must be referred to according to how He and His Prophet Muhammad ﷺ have described Him instead of explaining His names and attributes by giving them meanings other than their obvious meanings.
- The second aspect involves referring to Allah the Almighty as He has referred to Himself without giving Him any new names or attributes.
- In the third aspect of Tawhid al-Asmaa wasSifaat (الاسماء وصفات) Allah the Almighty is referred to without giving Him the attributes of His creation. For example, it is claimed in the Bible and Torah that Allah the Almighty spent the first six days creating the universe and then slept on the seventh. For this reason, Jews and Christians take either Saturday or Sunday as a day of rest in which work is looked at as a sin.
- The fourth aspect of this category requires that any human should not be given the attributes of Allah the Almighty to His Almighty level. In reality, all the attributes belong to Allah the Almighty in true essence. He has distributed His attributes to the creation for a certain period e.g. a man can be Raheem but not to the level of Allah the Almighty. All the attributes of Allah are incomparable as they are not dependent on anyone but the attributes of the Creator are independent. The attributes of creation have a start and end time but His attributes are free from creation and eternal like Creator. The abilities of creation are limited and confined like them and all the abilities of the Creator are limitless and perpetual.

The Example of Hayy and Qayyum

Al-Hayy (the Ever-Living) and al-Qayyum (the Self-Subsisting) are two of His exclusive and incomparable attributes. They affirm that He alone possesses true and absolute life, a life that is not derived, sustained, or dependent on anything else. He is completely unlike creation: He has no beginning and no end, and His existence is entirely independent, necessary, and non-contingent. Nothing causes Him to exist, and nothing sustains Him.

He is also beyond all limitations of time, for time itself is His creation. Before time came into existence, He already was, without “before” or “after,” without change or progression. His existence does not unfold within time, nor is it affected by it. Thus, He alone is truly eternal, immortal, and everlasting—unceasing in His being, never subject to decay, interruption, or extinction.

Shirk (Associating partners) with Allah is an Unforgivable Sin

“And indeed, it has been revealed to you (O Muhammad), as it was to those before you: If you join others in worship with Allah the Almighty, (then) surely (all) your deeds will be in vain, and you will certainly be among the losers.” Az-Zumar:65]

This was said to Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, that even if you commit shirk with Allah the Almighty then all of your good deeds will be wasted.

“Verily, Allah the Almighty forgives not that partners should be set up with Him, but He forgives what is less than that to whomever He wills...” An-Nisa:8]

These references to verses from the Qur’an show that Shirk is an unforgivable sin. This shows that if someone has committed the sin of shirk and then seeks repentance for it then Allah the Almighty forgives him but if someone dies on the belief of shirk then surely, he will meet the fire in Hell.

22. Why Shirk is an unforgivable sin?

Shirk is to associate someone other than Allah the Almighty in those aspects that are unique to Allah the Almighty and His exclusive right. Shirk is to worship created beings like Allah the Almighty is worshipped, to venerate created beings like Allah the Almighty must be venerated, and to assign a portion of His divinity to someone else.

So, on the Day of Judgment Allah, the Almighty will ask that person who did shirk that as you have done this deed for another person or god other than Me then ask the reward of it from that false God.

In the Bible, it is mentioned that on the Day of Judgment, people will come to Prophet Jesus and ask him O Lord, O Lord, we did charity in Thy name and they will mention their good deeds in Prophet Jesus’s name. While Prophet Jesus will say that getaway you evildoers, I even don’t know you?

In the Qur’an, Allah the Almighty has mentioned that on the Day of Judgment when people come to Prophet Jesus, Allah the Almighty will ask Prophet Jesus, “O Isa, did you tell them to worship you besides Me? Or your mother besides Me?” and Prophet Jesus will say, Allah the Almighty you know what is in my heart, I have never told them to worship me”.

Allah the Almighty has mentioned categorically in the Qur’an that Isa and his mother don’t have the authority to be your beneficiary. The people who are worshipping them will be in severe trouble on the Final Day.

Our intrinsic nature, Fitrah is inclined towards the Oneness of God and all the design of nature shows the glory and Oneness of a single Designer, hence that made the shirk an unforgivable sin as all the proofs of the Oneness of God are present in. So, one has to go against their nature to shirk.

23. Repentance before Death

There is a Sahih Hadith, an old man who came to Prophet Muhammad ﷺ with a stick in his hand as a support for walking, He said to Prophet Muhammad ﷺ what do you say about a person who has committed every sin, big or small, he has not left any of it? Ya

Rasulullah! I am an old man I have done that all. Prophet Muhammad ﷺ said have you said Shahdah? He said yes.

Then Prophet Muhammad ﷺ said, from this moment, you do righteous deeds and don't go back to those sins, Allah the Almighty will forgive you and will turn your bad deeds into good deeds.

That person was shocked and said that even my treachery and the way I hurt other people would be forgiven. Prophet Muhammad ﷺ said, yes even those, and then he lifted his stick and went back with slogans of Allahu Akbar Allahu Akbar. The true repentance changes us and our ways of life. This is the significance of real repentance.

Types of Shirk

The texts of the Qur'an and Sunnah indicate that shirk and the ascribing of rivals to Allah the Almighty sometimes puts a person beyond the pale of Islam and sometimes does not. Hence the scholars divided shirk into two types which they call shirk akbar (major shirk) and shirk asghar (minor shirk).

24. 1. Major Shirk

This means ascribing to someone other than Allah the Almighty something that belongs only to Allah the Almighty, such as Lordship (ruboobiyyah), divinity (uloohiyyah), and the divine names and attributes (al-asma' wa'l-sifaat).

Major Shirk may sometimes take the form of beliefs:

- Such as the belief that there is someone else who creates, gives life and death, reigns, or controls the affairs of the universe along with Allah the Almighty.
- Or the belief that there is someone else who must be obeyed absolutely besides Allah the Almighty, so they follow him in regard as permissible or forbidden whatever he wants, even if that goes against the religion of the Messengers.
- Or they may associate others with Allah the Almighty in love and veneration, by loving a created being as they love Allah the Almighty. This is the kind of shirk that Allah the Almighty does not forgive.
- Or the belief that some know the Unseen as well as Allah the Almighty. It is also shirk to believe that there is someone who bestows mercy in a manner that is befitting only for Allah the Almighty, so he shows mercy as Allah the Almighty does and forgives sins and overlooks the bad deeds of his worshippers.

Particularly in this era, we should have to be very careful regarding the false creeds associated with the shrines in our region. This is prohibited to ask anything in any sense from the shrines. This is against the teachings of the Qur'an and the Sunnah of the Holy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. The scholars of every sect have refuted this misguidance strictly.

Muslims are only bound to follow the direct text of the Qur'an and Hadith. There is no need to be involved in ambiguous and uncertain literature.

25. 2. Minor Shirk

This includes everything that may lead to a major shirk, or which is described in the scripts as being shirk but does not reach the extent of being a major shirk.

This is usually of two types:

- Being emotionally attached to some means which have no basis and for which Allah the Almighty has not given permission, such as hanging up "hands", turquoise beads, amulets, etc. because they offer protection or that they ward off the evil eye. But Allah the Almighty has not made them the means of such protection, either according to Shariah or according to the laws of the universe.
- Venerating some people or things in a way that does not go so far as ascribing lordship to them, such as swearing by something other than Allah the Almighty, or saying, "Were it not for Allah and So and so," etc.
- As the Holy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ has clearly stated:

*What I fear most about you is the Minor Shirk. The Companions of the Prophet asked him, "What is minor shirk, ya Rasullah?" He said, 'Ar-riya-Showing off' Allah will say on the Day of Judgment when He pays the people for their deeds: Go to those for whom you have done Riyadh in the world and see if you would find the reward with them.*²²

It means that people are more afraid of society. They are afraid of people but not of Allah. All their deeds are man-centered not God-centered. Allah the Almighty has mentioned this trait of human beings in the following words.

يَخْشَوْنَ النَّاسَ كَخَشْيَةِ اللَّهِ أَوْ أَشَدَّ خَشْيَةً

*they feared men as they fear Allah or with even] greater fear.*²³

The Concept of Ownership

In regards to Tawhid, Muslims should understand this dogma clearly that everything we have belongs to Allah the Almighty. We are just the caretakers or custodians of all the valuables for a certain period. Ownership in reality belongs to alone Allah the Almighty. That is why suicide has been declared forbidden because even though this life is not ours it belongs to Allah. We were created at the decided time and will die in the same manner decided by Allah the Almighty. Parents, children, money, every relation and entirety we have belongs to Allah alone.

²² Musnad Ahmad bin Hanbal:57

²³ Qur'an:4-77

The following example helps clarify the concept discussed above. After the Holy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the most honored and respected people in Islam are his Companions. Following the conquest of Mecca, when the Muslims were at their greatest numerical strength, they fought the Battle of Hunain under the direct leadership of the Holy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. Despite their large numbers, they faced severe hardship and difficulty in this battle due to a single mistake: they began to attribute the success of their earlier victories to their own strength and efforts rather than to the help and will of Allah.

This subtle sense of self-reliance led to a momentary setback, teaching a profound lesson—that victory does not come from numbers, power, or human capability alone, but solely from Allah. Allah the Almighty reprimanded this attitude and corrected their understanding through His words, as mentioned in the following verse:

Indeed, Allah has given you believer's victory on many battlefields, even at the Battle of Hunain when you took pride in your great numbers, but they proved of no advantage to you. The earth, despite its vastness, seemed to close in on you, and then you turned back in retreat.²⁴ (al-Tawba:5)

²⁴ Qur'an:9-5

Iman bil-Mala'ikah: Belief in the Angels

Belief in the Angels (Mala'ika) is an essential part of the Islamic faith. Their existence, attributes, and responsibilities are frequently mentioned in both the Qur'an and Hadith. Denying their existence is considered Kufr (disbelief), as belief in angels is one of the six articles of faith in Islam.

"The Messenger has believed in what was revealed to him from his Lord, and so have the believers... They believe in Allah, His angels, His books, and His messengers..." (Surah Al-Baqarah 2:285)

26. Nature and Characteristics of Angels

Angels are created from light (nur), as stated in Hadith:

"The angels were created from light..."²⁵

They have intangible bodies, and can assume different forms by Allah's will. Angels are neither male nor female and are free from human needs such as eating, drinking, and reproduction. Their primary purpose is to worship and obey Allah without fail. They never disobey His commands and perform their duties with precision and dedication.

They do not disobey Allah in what He commands them but do what they are commanded.²⁶

They continuously glorify and worship Allah without exhaustion:

They exalt Him night and day and do not slacken.²⁷

It is a grave misconception to consider angels as mere forces of nature without life or form. The Qur'an describes them as real beings with distinct roles.

The Vast Number and Roles of Angels

Angels exist in great numbers across the heavens and the earth, each entrusted with specific duties.

The Four Archangels

Among all the angels, four hold the highest status due to their responsibilities:

27. 1. Jibra'il ﷺ

The angel of revelation. He delivered Allah's messages to the Prophets.

²⁵ Sahih Muslim: 2996

²⁶ Qur'an: 66-6

²⁷ Qur'an: 21:20

*This is indeed the word of a noble messenger. Who is possessed of power and with the Owner of the Throne, secure in position, obeyed there in the heavens and trustworthy.*²⁸

2. Mikail ؑ

Responsible for providing sustenance and controlling the forces of nature, such as rain and vegetation.

28. 3. Israfil ؑ

Entrusted with blowing the Trumpet to signal the end of the world and the Day of Judgment.

29. 4. Izrail ؑ

The Angel of Death, tasked with removing the souls of the deceased, assisted by subordinate angels.

Belief in angels is a fundamental requirement of Islamic faith. Denying their existence or distorting their nature is a serious deviation from Islamic doctrine. The Qur'an and Hadith provide detailed and consistent affirmations of their reality, purpose, and roles.

²⁸ Qur'an: 81:19–21)

Iman bil-Kutub: Belief in the Books

Belief in the divinely revealed scriptures is a fundamental article of faith in Islam. It is among the six pillars of Iman (faith), and rejecting any of these scriptures — in their original, unaltered forms — is considered disbelief. Allah the Almighty has sent these books to various prophets over the course of history as a means to guide humanity toward righteousness, justice, and monotheism.

The Messenger has believed in what was revealed to him from his Lord, and [so have] the believers. All of them have believed in Allah, His angels, His books, and His messengers ²⁹

These books were sent to different communities based on their needs and conditions. While each book had its purpose, they all carried the central message of Tawhid and guided people toward ethical and spiritual living.

30. The Tawrah

The Tawrah was revealed to Prophet Musa ﷺ for the guidance of the Children of Israel. It contained commandments, legal rulings, and spiritual teachings intended to regulate both personal conduct and community affairs.

Indeed, We sent down the Torah, in which was guidance and light. The prophets who submitted [to Allah] judged by it for the Jews... ³⁰

The Tawrah provided a comprehensive legal and moral code, and it emphasized justice, accountability, and social reform. However, over time, many parts of it were distorted or lost, and interpretations became influenced by human intervention.

31. The Zabur (Psalms)

The Zabur was revealed to the Prophet Dawud ﷺ. Unlike the Tawrah, the Zabur focused less on law and more on praise, worship, and spiritual wisdom.

And to David We gave the Zabur. ³¹

It contained psalms and songs of praise glorifying Allah and expressing deep spiritual devotion. The Zabur served as a source of personal inspiration, particularly in times of hardship or moral reflection. It is considered a sacred text filled with heartfelt prayers and moral teachings, though the original text has not survived in its unaltered form.

32. The Injeel (Gospel)

The Injeel was revealed to Prophet ‘Isa ﷺ. It confirmed the teachings of the Tawrah while also bringing forth new spiritual insights centered on mercy, compassion, and love.

²⁹ Qur’an: 2:285

³⁰ Qur’an: 2:285

³¹ Qur’an: 4:163

"And We sent, following in their footsteps, Jesus, the son of Mary, confirming that which came before him in the Torah; and We gave him the Gospel, in which was guidance and light."³²

The original Injeel was a divine revelation from Allah, not the same as the four Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John) written later by human authors. The true Injeel emphasized monotheism and the continuity of divine guidance, but it too was later altered and lost in its original form.

33. The Qur'an: Final and Eternal Revelation

The Qur'an, revealed to Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, is the final and complete revelation from Allah. It serves as a confirmation of the previous scriptures and a correction of distortions made to them.

He has revealed to you the Book in truth, confirming what was before it. And He revealed the Torah and the Gospel before as guidance for mankind, and He revealed the Criterion (the Qur'an)."³³

The Qur'an is the only scripture that has remained unchanged since its revelation over 1,400 years ago. Allah Himself guarantees its protection:

Indeed, it is We who sent down the Reminder (the Qur'an), and indeed, We will be its Guardian."³⁴

It is not only a spiritual guide but also a comprehensive manual for life, covering personal ethics, family life, social justice, governance, and human rights. It is also filled with prophecies and scientific phenomena that continue to be validated, further confirming its divine source.

Theological Significance of Belief in All Books

Believing in all the divine books means acknowledging their divine origin and respecting their role in the history of revelation. It does not mean following the previous scriptures as they exist today but believing that:

- Allah revealed these books in their original forms.
- Each served a specific community at a particular time.
- All conveyed the same essential message of monotheism and submission to Allah.

³² Qur'an: 5:46

³³ Qur'an: 3:3

³⁴ Qur'an: 15:9

- The Qur'an abrogates and supersedes previous revelations, serving as the final criterion.

Belief in the revealed books is a key component of a Muslim's faith. It fosters an understanding of the continuity of divine guidance and shows that Islam is not a new religion but the final phase in the long history of prophetic messages. While earlier scriptures were sent to specific peoples and were subject to change, the Qur'an remains timeless, universal, and fully preserved.

As the last and final revelation, the Qur'an consolidates the teachings of all previous books and provides a complete way of life for all of humanity. Through it, the guidance of Allah remains alive, accessible, and protected until the end of time.

Iman bir-Rusul (Belief in the Prophets)

The Role and Nature of Prophethood (Nubuwwah) in Islam is a core concept in Islamic belief. It refers to the divine system by which Allah guides humanity through chosen individuals—Prophets (Nabi) and Messengers (Rasul). These Prophets serve as a vital link between Allah and mankind. They are not ordinary people; they are selected by Allah to deliver His message, teach His laws, and guide people towards what is right and away from what is wrong.

34. The Mission and Function of Prophets

Prophets are specially chosen by Allah to lead people towards truth and righteousness. Their mission is to:

- Teach people about Allah's oneness (Tawhid).
- Deliver divine laws (Shariah).
- Warn people against evil and disbelief.
- Give glad tidings of Paradise to the believers and warn of Hell for the disbelievers.

*[We sent] messengers as bringers of good tidings and warners so that mankind will have no argument against Allah after the messengers.*³⁵

35. The Infallibility (Ismah) of the Prophets

The Prophets are protected by Allah from major and minor sins. This divine protection (Ismah) ensures that they serve as perfect role models for humanity. They still have free will, but Allah keeps them away from error in matters of religion and morality.

*Indeed, in the Messenger of Allah you have an excellent example for whoever has hope in Allah and the Last Day and remembers Allah often.*³⁶

If a Prophet makes a mistake, it is not out of sin or rebellion, but due to a human misunderstanding or misjudgment, and Allah guides them directly.

For example, the story of Prophet Adam ﷺ eating from the tree is seen not as a sinful act, but as a moment of forgetfulness:

*And We had already taken a promise from Adam before, but he forgot; and We found not in him determination [to disobey].*³⁷

³⁵ Qur'an: 4:165

³⁶ Qur'an: 33:21

³⁷ Qur'an: 20:115

36. The Miracles

The Prophets are given miracles by Allah as a proof of their truthfulness. These miracles break the laws of nature and cannot be performed by humans. They serve as signs (Ayat) to convince people of the divine origin of the Prophet's message. Examples include:

Prophet Ibrahim ؑ: The fire became cool and safe when he was thrown into it.

*We said, 'O fire, be coolness and safety upon Abraham.'*³⁸

The Prophet Musa ؑ: The sea split for him and his people.

*Then We inspired to Moses, 'Strike the sea with your staff,' and it parted, and each portion was like a great towering mountain.*³⁹

Same is the case with every Prophet.

Finality of Prophethood (Khatm an-Nubuwwah)

The belief that Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is the final Prophet is central to Islamic theology. No Prophet or Messenger will come after him.

مَا كَانَ مُحَمَّدٌ أَبَا أَحَدٍ مِنْ رِجَالِكُمْ وَلَكِنْ رَسُولَ اللَّهِ وَخَاتَمَ النَّبِيِّينَ ۚ

*Muhammad is not the father of any man among you, but he is the Messenger of Allah and the Seal of the Prophets.*⁴⁰

The title “Seal of the Prophets” (خاتم النبيين) has been unanimously understood by the Muslim community throughout history to signify the finality of Prophet hood. It affirms that Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is the last in the line of prophets and that the institution of Prophet hood has conclusively ended with him. No prophet will come after him, and no new divine mission or prophetic authority remains to be introduced.

Accordingly, any claim to Prophet hood after Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is regarded as false and invalid, as it directly contradicts this fundamental and well-established belief. Such a claim is not merely an interpretive difference but a rejection of a core principle of Islamic faith, which has been clearly stated in the Qur'an, affirmed by the teachings of the Prophet ﷺ himself, and upheld by the consensus of the Muslim ummah across generations.

37. Hadith Evidence for his Finality

Numerous authentic hadiths confirm this creed categorically:

³⁸ Qur'an: 21:69

³⁹ Qur'an: 26:63

⁴⁰ (Surah Al-Ahzab 33:40)

Hadith # 1

*There will arise thirty great liars in my Ummah, each of them claiming to be a Prophet. But I am the last of the Prophets, there is no Prophet after me.*⁴¹

Hadith # 2

*The example of me and the Prophets before me is like a man who built a beautiful house... but one brick was missing. I am that last brick, and I am the last of the Prophets.*⁴²

Hadith # 3

*You (Ali) are to me as Harun was to Musa, except that there is no Prophet after me.*⁴³

⁴¹ Sunan Abu Dawood, Sahih: 4252

⁴² Sahih al-Bukhari: 3535

⁴³ Sahih Muslim: 2404

Iman bil-Yawm al-Akhira: Belief in the Day of Judgement

In Islam, the Day of Judgment (Yawm al-Qiyamah) is the final and most important event in the life of every human being. It is the day when Allah will resurrect all of creation, judge them for their beliefs and deeds, and determine their eternal fate—either Paradise or Hell. Belief in the Day of Judgment is one of the six pillars of faith (Iman) and serves as a constant reminder of personal accountability and the temporary nature of worldly life. The Qur'an emphasizes its certainty:

"Indeed, the Hour is coming—there is no doubt about it—and Allah will resurrect those in the graves."

(Surah Al-Hajj 22:7)

This belief inspires Muslims to live righteous, meaningful lives, striving for good deeds, repentance, and justice, knowing that every action will be weighed and every soul will face its ultimate reward or punishment.

38. The Phase of Death and Barzakh

In Islam, death marks the beginning of the soul's journey to the afterlife. It is the moment when the soul separates from the body. After death, the soul is placed in a specific state or station and remains connected—at varying degrees—to the body or its remains in the grave. This period is known as Barzakh, a realm between the physical world and the Day of Judgment.

During Barzakh, the soul can experience comfort or punishment, depending on its deeds in this world.

And behind them is a barrier (Barzakh) until the Day they are resurrected.

(Surah Al-Mu'minun 23:100)

The events of Barzakh are metaphysical—they cannot be detected by human senses. A helpful comparison is the experience of a dream, where one may see and feel things that others around them cannot observe.

The Prophet ﷺ said:

When a believer is buried, two angels come and ask... If he answers correctly, his grave is expanded and filled with light. If not, the grave is tight and filled with fire. (Musnad Ahmad)

The pain of the punishment is so severe that the dead scream, but only animals can hear them.

He hears the beat of their sandals as they leave, and then he is questioned...

(Sahih al-Bukhari)

39. Phases of the Day of Judgment (Yawm al-Qiyamah)

The Day of Judgment is a promised reality. It begins with the blowing of the Trumpet by the angel Israfil, which will cause all life to cease.

And the Trumpet will be blown, and all who are in the heavens and the earth will fall dead, except whom Allah wills.

(Surah Az-Zumar 39:68)

After forty years, Israfil will blow the Trumpet again, and all the dead will be resurrected.

The main purpose of this day is to:

- Reward the righteous
- Punish the wicked

40. The Great Intercession (Ash-Shafa‘ah al-‘Uzma)

After a long and unbearable wait, people will go to various Prophets seeking someone to intercede with Allah to start the reckoning. Each Prophet will decline until they reach Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, who will say: I am for it (the intercession).⁴⁴ He will intercede, and the Day of Judgment will begin.

41. Stages of the Reckoning (Hisab)

1. Distribution of Deeds

Every person will be given a Book of Deeds:

The righteous will receive it in their right hand.

The wicked will receive it in their left hand or from behind their back.

Then as for he who is given his record in his right hand, he will be judged with an easy account... But as for he who is given his record behind his back, he will cry out for destruction.

(Surah Al-Inshiqaq 84:7–12)

2. Weighing of Deeds (Mizan)

A scale will be set up to weigh good and bad deeds.

And We shall set up the scales of justice for the Day of Resurrection, so that no soul is treated unjustly in anything.

(Surah Al-Anbiya 21:47)

⁴⁴ Jami‘ at-Tirmidhi

Those whose good deeds are heavier will succeed.

3. Witnesses

Angels, who recorded the deeds, will testify.

The Prophets will testify against or for their nations.

Even a person's body parts will bear witness.

"That Day, their tongues, hands, and feet will testify against them about what they used to do."

(Surah An-Nur 24:24)

42. Paradise (Jannah) and Hell (Jahannam)

Both Paradise and Hell are real, eternal places.

The journey of the soul, from death to resurrection, and ultimately to either Paradise or Hell, is central to Islamic belief. The stages—Barzakh, Qiyamah, Reckoning, and the final destination—remind us of our responsibility in this life. Through sincere faith and righteous action, one can hope for Allah's mercy and eternal success in the Hereafter.

Iman bil-Qadar: Belief in Divine Decree

The belief in Qadr (divine destiny) and Qadha (divine execution or decree) is one of the six pillars of faith in Islam. It means that everything in the universe—whether good or bad—happens according to Allah’s perfect knowledge and will.

43. Qadr – Divine Destiny

Qadr refers to Allah’s eternal knowledge and plan for all creation. Before the universe was created, Allah already knew and recorded everything that would happen, including all events and actions.

Indeed, We have created all things with Qadr (predestination).

(Surah Al-Qamar 54:49)

Allah has set a measure for everything.

(Surah At-Talaq 65:3)

This shows that nothing happens by accident—everything is within Allah’s divine wisdom and decree.

44. Qadha – Divine Execution

Qadha is the actual creation and execution of Allah’s plan. It means Allah brings about everything in the world according to what He had already destined. Although our actions are in the knowledge of Allah, still it doesn’t impact on our free will. We choose our actions, but Allah already knows what we will choose and has created the results based on His ultimate knowledge.

The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ said:

Everyone will find easy that for which he was created.

(Sahih al-Bukhari)

This Hadith shows that while Allah knows our future, we still choose our path freely.

45. Dua (Supplication) and Destiny

Some may wonder: If everything is already written, what is the use of making dua (prayer)? The Islam teaches that dua is powerful and can change one’s conditional destiny. While some aspects of destiny are fixed and cannot change (definite destiny), others are conditional and can change based on a person’s actions, especially sincere prayer and repentance.

The Prophet ﷺ said:

Nothing repels destiny except dua, and nothing increases lifespan except righteousness.

(Sunan At-Tirmidhi, Hasan)

So, making dua is not against belief in destiny—it is part of Allah’s plan. He has already decreed that some outcomes will occur only if we ask.

Introduction to the Worship System in Islam

Worship (‘ibadah) occupies a central role in Islam, encompassing both formal rituals and broader acts of devotion that align with the ethical and spiritual objectives of the faith. Rooted in the Qur’an and the teachings of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the Islamic concept of worship is not confined to ritual performance but extends to all aspects of life lived in accordance with divine guidance.

At its core, Islamic worship is designed to cultivate a continuous awareness of Almighty Allah (taqwa), foster spiritual discipline, and promote communal unity. The formal structure of worship is most clearly articulated through the Five Pillars of Islam—Shahadah (declaration of faith), Salah (prayer), Zakah (almsgiving), Sawm (fasting during Ramadan), and Hajj (pilgrimage to Mecca). These pillars serve as foundational acts of devotion that define Muslim identity and express submission to Almighty Allah.

Beyond these obligatory acts, Islam encourages voluntary forms of worship (nawafil), ethical conduct, and social responsibility as integral expressions of faith. This holistic approach reflects the Islamic view that worship is not merely ritualistic but is intended to transform the believer’s relationship with Almighty Allah, self, and society.

This chapter of the course will examine the theological foundations, practical applications, and spiritual significance of the Islamic worship system. It will also explore how these acts of devotion have shaped Muslim life, both individually and collectively, across different historical and cultural contexts.

46. The Shahadah (Declaration of Faith)

The Shahadah is the foundational pillar of Islam and the essential entry point into the faith. It is a concise yet profound declaration that affirms the central theological tenet of Islam: monotheism (tawhid). The Shahadah states:

أشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وأشهد أن محمداً رسول الله

"I bear witness that there is no Almighty Allah but Allah, and I bear witness that Muhammad is the Messenger of Allah."

This declaration serves both as a creed and an act of worship, encapsulating the essence of Islamic belief and identity.

Theological Significance

The Shahadah is not merely a verbal statement; it is a comprehensive affirmation of:

Divine Unity (Tawhid): Recognizing that Allah is the sole Creator, Sustainer, and Ruler of the universe, and that no entity shares in His divinity or attributes.

Prophet hood (Risalah): Acknowledging Muhammad (peace be upon him) as the final messenger in a long line of prophets, who conveyed Almighty Allah's final revelation (the Qur'an) to humanity.

This two-part testimony forms the basis of Islamic theology ('aqadah) and shapes a Muslim's worldview, ethics, and purpose in life.

Spiritual and Personal Commitment

The act of declaring the Shahdah signifies more than intellectual agreement—it is a conscious submission to Almighty Allah's will. It implies: Acceptance of Almighty Allah's guidance as revealed in the Qur'an and Sunnah. Commitment to living according to Islamic principles. Entrance into the global Muslim community (ummah).

In this sense, the Shahdah is both a personal covenant with Almighty Allah and a public affirmation of faith.

Ritual and Legal Role

Conversion to Islam: Uttering the Shahdah sincerely, with understanding and belief, is the sole requirement for one to become a Muslim.

Daily Worship: The Shahdah is an integral part of the daily prayers, recited multiple times throughout the day.

Social and Legal Recognition: In Islamic jurisprudence (fiqh), a person's status as a Muslim is formally recognized through the articulation of the Shahdah.

Implications for Worship and Life

By professing the Shahadah, a Muslim declares that all aspects of life—ritual, ethical, social, political—should be oriented toward the worship and obedience of Allah. This includes:

Rejection of idolatry and any form of associating partners with Almighty Allah (shirk).

Upholding the prophetic example (Sunnah) in personal and communal life.

Striving for sincerity in all actions, as true worship is rooted in the inner conviction of Almighty Allah's oneness.

The Shahadah is more than the first of the Five Pillars; it is the core of Islamic consciousness. It defines what it means to be Muslim and serves as the foundation upon which all other forms of worship and religious duties are built. In this sense, the entire

worship system of Islam can be seen as an elaboration of the truths affirmed in the Shahadah.

47. Salah (Ritual Prayer)

Prayer is the second and most visible of the Five Pillars of Islam, representing the daily, structured worship that Muslims are obligated to perform. It serves as a direct link between the individual and Almighty Allah, reinforcing spiritual discipline, humility, and devotion. Unlike other forms of worship, salah is tightly regulated in its form, timing, and conditions, and is considered the most essential outward expression of faith.

Namaz is a Persian word that literally means “to bow”. In Arabic, prayer is called “Salat” which literally means “to pray”. The word “salat” is used for prayer in the Qur'an and Hadith.

Importance of the Prayer

The prayer is the fundamental element of the religion of Islam. After believing in Allah and His Messenger, the most important part is the prayer.

The Obligation of Salat

Salat was made obligatory on the occasion of the Ascension. The prayer is a form of worship of Allah, which is not permissible to miss for a Muslim under any circumstances and it was made obligatory for every Muslim man and woman to pay it at fixed times.

A Comprehensive Worship:

The prayer is the part of the religion of Islam which includes many acts of worship, Such as remembrance of Allah, recitation of the Qur'an, standing or Qiyaam, bowing or Ruku. Prostration, Supplication, Glorification and Takbeer, etc. In this way, the prayer encompasses many acts of worship.

The Plurality of Emphasis:

Among the Islamic rituals of worship, the prayer is a form of worship that is often urged to be performed. It has been emphasized in hundreds of hadiths.

Theological Foundations

Ṣalāh is rooted in divine command, primarily derived from the Qur'an and the Sunnah of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him). The Qur'an states:

"Indeed, prayer has been decreed upon the believers a decree of specified times."
(Qur'an, 4:103)

Prayer is viewed not merely as a ritual, but as a **spiritual ascent (mi' rāj)** for the believer, echoing the Prophet's own ascension to the heavens, where the command for ṣalāh was revealed.

Obligatory and Voluntary Prayers

Muslims are required to perform five daily prayers at specific times:

Arabic Name	English Name	Time
Fajr	Dawn Prayer	Before sunrise
Zuhr	Noon Prayer	After the sun passes its zenith
‘Aṣr	Afternoon Prayer	Late afternoon
Maghrib	Sunset Prayer	Immediately after sunset
‘Ishā’	Night Prayer	After twilight disappears

Each prayer consists of a series of physical movements and recitations called rak‘āt (units), which include standing (qiyām), bowing (rukū‘), and prostration (sujūd), symbolizing submission to Almighty Allah.

In addition to the obligatory prayers, there are numerous **voluntary (nafl)** and **supererogatory (sunnah)** prayers, such as **tahajjud** (late night prayer) and **duhā** (mid-morning prayer), which were regularly observed by the Prophet.

Conditions and Requirements

Before performing ṣalāh, Muslims must fulfill specific conditions:

- **Purification (ṭahārah):** Ritual cleanliness through **wuḍū’** (ablution) or **ghusl** (full-body purification) if required.
- **Proper attire:** Covering the *‘awrah* (modesty requirements).
- **Clean space:** The place of prayer must be free from impurities.
- **Facing the Qiblah:** All prayers are directed toward the **Ka‘bah** in Mecca.

Prayer is invalid without these prerequisites, highlighting the ritual's spiritual seriousness and attention to discipline.

Social and Spiritual Dimensions

Salah serves both an individual and communal function:

Spiritually, it fosters remembrance of Almighty Allah (*dhikr*), inner peace, and a moral compass.

Socially, it reinforces unity, equality (as all stand shoulder to shoulder regardless of status), and a shared sense of religious identity.

Regular prayer is also seen as a means of ethical purification, as highlighted in the Qur’an:

“Indeed, prayer prohibits immorality and wrongdoing.”
(Qur’an, 29:45)

The Difference between Islam and Disbelief

The basis of differentiation between Muslims and non-Muslims is the prayer. The Prophet a said:

The difference between worship and disbelief is the abandonment of prayer.

(Sunan Abu Dawood-4678)

The Prayer is Obligatory in All Circumstances:

Zakat and Hajj are obligatory on the wealthy. Leave has been granted to travelers and sick people for fast. However, the prayer is obligatory upon every Muslim: Allah says

Verily, Prayer is obligatory for Muslims in accordance with the fixed timings.

Last Advice of the Holy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ:

The importance of prayer can be estimated from the last advice the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ gave:

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ used to say, during the illness that would be his last: The prayer; and those whom your right hands possess. And he kept on saying it until his tongue could no longer utter any words.

The first account on Day of Judgment

The first thing a slave will be called to account from his deeds on the Day of Resurrection will be his salah. So, if it is correct then he will succeed and earn deliverance, but if it is corrupted then he will fail and lose.

Prayer refrains from Sins

“Surely, prayer prohibits indecency and impiety.”

The prayer plays an important role in making a person punctual. When a person makes the performance of prayer strictly obligatory upon himself, then the rest of his life, day and night, is organized.

Prayer also teaches equality. The ruler and the subjugated, the rich and the poor all stand together in the line of the prayer. Rather, whoever comes first is closest to the Imam. All discriminations disappear.

Prayer creates feelings of brotherhood and compassion within Muslims. Which plays an important and rich role in social development.

Therefore, Allah the Almighty has kept many secrets and symbols in the prayer. It is a complete and rich source of individual and collective reform of Muslims.

Offering the prayer is an act of worship, but there is a whole system of character building and Islamic formation of the society in it.

You will be able to receive all the benefits of Namaz when you are aware of the significance and translation of the Namaz.

48. Zakah (Almsgiving)

Zakah is the third pillar of Islam and represents the compulsory act of almsgiving, mandated as a means to purify wealth and assist those in need. It is both a form of worship and a social obligation, designed to redistribute resources within the Muslim community and promote economic justice.

Theological and Scriptural Basis

Zakah is enjoined by Almighty Allah repeatedly in the Qur'an, often alongside ṣalāh, emphasizing its integral role in Islam:

“And establish prayer and give Zakah and obey the Messenger - that you may receive mercy.”

(Qur'an, 24:56)

The term *Zakah* literally means “purification” and “growth,” reflecting the belief that giving Zakah purifies the giver's wealth and soul while fostering communal prosperity.

Definition and Purpose

Zakah is an obligatory almsgiving calculated as a fixed percentage of certain types of wealth held for a full lunar year. Its primary purposes are:

- **Spiritual purification** of the giver from greed and selfishness.
- **Economic redistribution** to reduce poverty and inequality.
- **Social solidarity** by strengthening the bonds within the Muslim community.

Zakah thus functions as a bridge between personal piety and social ethics.

Conditions and Eligibility

Zakah is due only if certain conditions are met:

- **Nisāb**: The minimum amount of wealth a Muslim must possess before Zakah becomes obligatory. This threshold varies depending on the type of asset (e.g., gold, silver, cash, livestock, agricultural produce).
- **Ownership for one lunar year (ḥawl)**: Wealth must be in possession continuously for one lunar year.
- **Type of wealth**: Includes cash, savings, trade goods, agricultural produce, livestock, and certain forms of investments.

If these conditions are met, Zakah is calculated at specific rates, generally **2.5% (1/40)** on monetary wealth, while agricultural produce and livestock have different prescribed rates.

Recipients of Zakah

The Qur'an specifies eight categories of eligible recipients, known as the **asnaf**:

"Zakah expenditures are only for the poor and the needy, and those employed to collect [Zakah], and to attract hearts [to Islam], and for freeing slaves, and for those in debt, and for the cause of Allah, and for the stranded traveler..."
(*Qur'an*, 9:60)

These categories include:

1. The poor (*fuqarā'*)
2. The needy (*masākīn*)
3. Those employed to collect Zakah (*āmilīn 'alayhā*)
4. Those whose hearts are to be reconciled (*mu'allafatu qulūbuhum*)
5. Ransom of captives or slaves (*fīrāq al-riqāb*)
6. Those in debt (*ghārimīn*)
7. In the cause of Allah (*fī sabīlillāh*)
8. The wayfarer (*ibn al-sabīl*)

Implementation and Jurisprudence

The administration of Zakah has historically been both a personal responsibility and a state function. In classical Islamic governance, Zakah collection and distribution were managed by appointed officials to ensure fairness and efficiency.

Different Islamic legal schools (*madhāhib*) provide detailed rulings on:

- Types of wealth subject to Zakah.
- Calculation methods.
- Exemptions and penalties for non-payment.

The consensus underscores Zakah's mandatory nature and its significance as a pillar of Islam.

Contemporary Relevance

Today, Zakah remains a vital tool for poverty alleviation in many Muslim-majority countries. Its principles inspire modern Islamic finance and charitable organizations, which seek to operationalize Zakah in contemporary economic contexts. Zakah also represents an ethical ideal, reminding Muslims that wealth is a trust from Almighty Allah to be used responsibly for the benefit of the entire community.

49. Fasting

Fasting is a Persian word. In Arabic, it is called 'Al |um'. The literal meaning of which is "to stop" in the term Sharia. It means to refrain from eating and drinking from dawn to sunset and abstain from sensual desires. That is why it has been given the name '|um.'

Fasting became obligatory on 10 Shaban 2 Hijr, a year and a half after the Hijrah to Medina.

Fasting, is the fourth pillar of Islam and represents a profound act of worship characterized by abstention from food, drink, and other specific physical needs from dawn until sunset. It is a spiritually disciplined practice designed to foster self-control, empathy, and closeness to Almighty Allah.

Theological Foundations

Fasting in Islam is primarily ordained in the Qur'an during the month of **Ramadhān**, the ninth month of the Islamic lunar calendar:

“O you who have believed, decreed upon you is fasting as it was decreed upon those before you that you may become righteous.”
(*Qur'an*, 2:183)

This verse highlights fasting not merely as physical abstention but as a means to develop taqwa.

Obligatory Nature and Timing

Fasting during the entire month of Ramadan is obligatory for every adult Muslim who is physically and mentally capable. The fast begins at **fajr** (dawn) and ends at **maghrib** (sunset).

The month of Ramadhān holds special significance because it is the month in which the Qur'an was first revealed to the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), making it a time of intensified worship and reflection.

Fasting was obligatory for every Ummah

O believers! Fasting is prescribed for you as it was prescribed for the people before you so that you may become pious.

Leaving fast is a great Sin

“Whoever breaks the fast-during Ramadan without an allowance or illness, then if he fasted for all time, his fasting would not make up for it.”

Aim of Fasting

The Prophet ﷺ said, “Whoever does not give up forged speech and evil actions, Allah is not in need of his leaving his food and drink (i.e. Allah will not accept his fasting.)”

Benefits and Effects of Fasting:

1. It is a month of training to avoid evil and do well.

2. Fasting makes one accustomed to hardship.
3. It creates a sense of people's sufferings and problems.
4. Fasting teaches punctuality.
5. Fasting makes a person spiritually strong, and it is the spiritual strength that brings a person closer to Allah the Almighty.
6. Fasting also helps to improve your health.

50. Hajj (Pilgrimage)

The literal meaning of Hajj is “to intend to visit a place”. In the terms of Shari'ah, attending the Kaaba and performing Hajj rituals on the specific days of Zul-Hijjah is called Hajj. Hajj is the fifth pillar of Islam. It became obligatory in 9 AH.

Hajj, the fifth and final pillar of Islam, is a compulsory religious pilgrimage to the holy city of **Makkah** that every Muslim who is physically and financially able must undertake at least once in their lifetime. It is a profound act of worship embodying unity, submission, and renewal of faith.

Theological Foundations

The obligation of Hajj is clearly stated in the Qur'an:

“And [due] to Allah from the people is a pilgrimage to the House— for whoever is able to find thereto a way.”
(*Qur'an*, 3:97)

Hajj traces its origins to the Prophet Ibrāhīm AS and his family, who are seen as the founders of the sacred rituals associated with Makkah and the Ka'bah. It symbolizes the worship of the one Almighty Allah and the unity of Muslims worldwide.

Timing and Duration

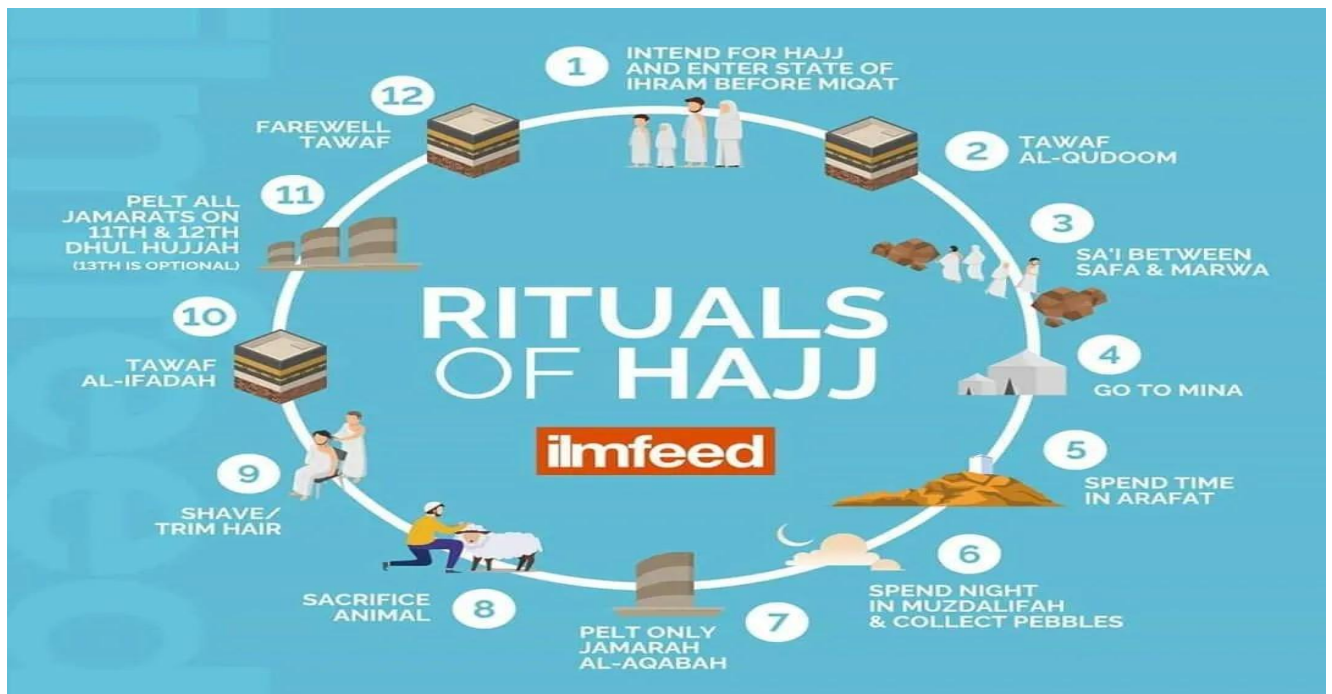
Hajj takes place annually during the Islamic month of **Dhu al-Hijjah**, specifically from the 8th to the 12th (sometimes extending to the 13th). The rituals are performed over these days in a fixed sequence.

The pilgrimage coincides with the **Day of Arafah** (9th of Dhu al-Hijjah), the climax of Hajj, considered the day of forgiveness and mercy.

Rituals of Hajj

The rites of Hajj are deeply symbolic and involve specific acts prescribed by Islamic law (*Sharī'ah*). Key rituals include:

- **Ihrām:** Entering a sacred state of ritual purity and intention, marked by wearing simple, white garments (two unstitched sheets for men; modest dress for women) and abstaining from certain actions such as cutting hair or nails, and engaging in quarrels.
- **Tawāf:** Circumambulating the Ka‘bah seven times in a counterclockwise direction, demonstrating the unity of believers around Almighty Allah.
- **Sa‘y:** Walking seven times between the hills of Safā and Marwah, commemorating Hagar’s search for water for her son Ishmael.
- **Standing at Arafah (Wuquf):** Spending the afternoon at the plain of Arafah in prayer and reflection, considered the essential pillar of Ḥajj.
- **Muzdalifah:** Collecting pebbles and spending the night under the open sky.
- **Ramy al-Jamarāt:** Throwing stones at three pillars representing the devil, symbolizing the rejection of temptation.
- **Eid al-Adha sacrifice:** Commemorating Abraham’s willingness to sacrifice his son by slaughtering an animal (usually a sheep or goat).
- **Shaving or trimming hair:** Signifying renewal and the conclusion of the state of ihrām.
- **Final Tawāf al-Ifādah:** Another circumambulation of the Ka‘bah symbolizing the completion of the pilgrimage rites.



Spiritual and Social Dimensions

Ḥajj is a powerful spiritual journey that embodies:

- **Equality and unity:** Millions of Muslims, regardless of nationality, ethnicity, or social status, gather in the same simple attire to perform identical rituals.

- **Renewal of faith:** It serves as a reminder of submission to Almighty Allah and the transient nature of worldly life.
- **Collective identity:** The pilgrimage fosters a strong sense of belonging to the global Muslim *ummah* (community).

Conditions and Eligibility

Hajj is obligatory only for Muslims who meet specific conditions:

- **Islamic faith:** Only Muslims may perform Hajj.
- **Maturity and sanity:** Adults who are of sound mind.
- **Physical and financial ability:** One must be physically fit and financially capable of undertaking the journey without hardship to themselves or their dependents.

If a Muslim cannot perform Hajj due to valid reasons such as illness or financial constraints, the obligation is waived or deferred.

Types of Pilgrimage

Apart from the major Hajj (*Hajj al-Tamattu`*), there are minor forms of pilgrimage called 'Umrah, which can be performed at any time of the year but does not fulfill the obligation of Hajj. Sometimes, pilgrims combine both in a single journey, this called Hajj e Qiran.

Historical and Jurisprudential Perspectives

The rituals of Hajj have been preserved since the time of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), with minor variations recognized among Islamic legal schools regarding certain details.

Over centuries, the Hajj has also been a site of political, cultural, and religious significance, influencing Islamic civilization and identity.

Introduction to Islamic Jurisprudence (Usul al-Fiqh)

Definition and Meaning

Islamic Jurisprudence, known as *Fiqh*, refers to the human understanding and interpretation of the divine law (*Shari'ah*). While *Shari'ah* is the divine law revealed by Allah in the Qur'an and Sunnah, *Fiqh* is the science of deriving legal rulings from these sources. The term *Usul al-Fiqh* (principles of jurisprudence) refers to the methodology and principles used by scholars to extract rulings.

Sources of Islamic Law

1. Primary Sources

The Qur'an – The divine revelation, ultimate authority.

Sunnah (Hadith) – Sayings, actions, and approvals of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ.

2. Secondary Sources

Ijma (Consensus) – Agreement of qualified scholars on a ruling.

Qiyas (Analogical Reasoning) – Extending rulings of established cases to new issues by analogy.

Objectives of Islamic Law (Maqasid al-Shari'ah)

The overarching aim of Shari'ah is to secure benefit and prevent harm. Classical scholars identified five essential objectives (*daruriyyat*):

- Protection of Faith (*Din*)
- Protection of Life (*Nafs*)
- Protection of Intellect (*'Aql*)
- Protection of Lineage (*Nasl*)
- Protection of Property (*Mal*)

Significance of Islamic Jurisprudence in Today's World

Islamic Jurisprudence (Fiqh and Usul al-Fiqh) holds great relevance in the modern era as it provides a framework for Muslims to live according to divine guidance while addressing contemporary challenges. Its flexibility allows for adaptation through *ijtihad* (independent reasoning) while staying rooted in the Qur'an and Sunnah.

Comprehensive Guidance – Covers every aspect of human life, from worship to social, economic, and political matters.

Ethical Finance – Provides alternatives like Murabaha and Mudarabah instead of interest-based banking.

Medical Ethics – Guides decisions on organ donation, IVF, and life-saving treatments in line with preserving life.

Justice & Rights – Promotes fairness, honesty, and fulfilling contracts in personal and professional life.

Social Adaptability – Recognises cultural practices ('urf) while maintaining Shari'ah essentials, e.g., marriage customs.

Global Relevance – Supports Muslims in minority contexts through fiqh al-aqalliyyat (halal food, prayers, wills, etc.).

The Qur'an

Literal meaning

The word “Qur'an” means “that which is recited; or that which is dictated in memory form.”

Terminological meaning

The Qur'an is the divine Word of Allah, revealed as a sacred Book to the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ through the Angel Jibreel (Gabriel) over a period of approximately 23 years.

The word Qur'an has been entitled by Allah the Almighty. This word has been used approximately 70 times in the Qur'an. No other name of any sacred book has been mentioned in the text of that book.

The authenticity of the Qur'an is based on the proclamation of Holy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. He was the only who can bear the burden of revelation. Whoever testifies his Prophethood only he believes in the authenticity of the Qur'an.

Yusuf Estes on the Timeless Appeal of the Qur'an to All People

Yusuf Estes, a prominent Muslim scholar and former Christian missionary priest, embraced Islam after extensive study of its sources. In his well-known work *Why Do Priests and Preachers Accept Islam?*, he outlines the intellectual and spiritual factors that lead many non-Muslims to recognize the Qur'an as a unique and divinely preserved scripture. His observations can be summarized with scholarly elaboration as follows:

Only One Version - Arabic:

There are no different versions of the Qur'an in the Arabic language, only different translations and of course, none of these would be considered to hold the value and authenticity of the original Arabic Recitation. The Qur'an is divided up into 30 equal parts, called “Juz” (parts) in the Arabic language. These are learned by Muslims from their very early beginnings as children.

Memorized by Millions - Entirely:

The important thing to keep in mind about the Qur'an is the memorization and transmission of the actual “Recitation” just as it came to Muhammad, peace be upon him, from the Angel Gabriel and was learned and memorized by his companions and they in turn, passed it down to their followers and continued in this way until we see today, over 10,000,000 (ten million) Muslims who have committed the entire Qur'an to memory. This is not a small feat. After all, how many other generations, in the original language, without a single change in even one sentence?

Each Muslim has Qur'an memorized:

All Muslims have memorized a portion of the Qur'an in the Arabic language, as this is an important part of their daily prayers. Many Muslims have memorized large portions of the Qur'an from one tenth to one half to all of the entire Qur'an, and all in the original Arabic language. It should be noted, there are over one and a half billion (1,500,000,000) Muslims worldwide and only about 10% are Arab, all the rest are learning the Qur'an in Arabic as a second language.

God Speaks in First Person to Mankind in the Qur'an:

The Qur'an contains clear statements from Allah the Almighty and it is Him speaking to all of us in the first person. He tells of us our own creation, the creation of all that is the universe and what has happened to those before us and what is to become of us if we do not take heed of the warnings clearly spelled out in His Revelation. He speaks also to Muhammad, peace be upon him, to show that Muhammad, peace be upon him, is not making this up himself and even chastises Muhammad, peace be upon him, for making human assumptions rather than waiting for revelation in matters (ie.; surah At-Tahreem and surah Abasa).

The Qur'an mentions itself:

The Qur'an refers to itself as "The Qur'an" (The Recitation) and mentions that it is to all mankind and jinn (another creation of Allah, similar to humans in that they could make choices as to whether or not they would obey Allah's Commandments, and they existed before humans).

The Qur'an describes Allah's nature exactly:

The Qur'an is clear on who God is and who He is not. There is no room left for doubt after reading the Qur'an in the Arabic language: Allah is One. He is the only, Creator, Sustainer and Owner of the Universe. He has no partners. He has no relatives; wives, children or offspring. He is like His creation and He does not need it for His existence, while all the time the creation is totally dependent on Him. His attributes are clearly spelled out as the epitome of each and every one. He is for instance, the All-Knowing; the All-Hearing, the All-Seeing the All-Forgiving; the All-Loving; the All-Merciful; the Only One God. There is never a contradiction to this found anywhere in the Qur'an.

The Qur'an challenges readers:

The Qur'an makes the clear challenge, that if you are in doubt about it - then bring a book like it. Also, to bring ten chapters like it and then finally, to bring one single chapter like it. 1400 years - and no one has been able to duplicate its beauty, recitation, miracles and ease of memorization. Another challenge for the unbelievers to consider;

"If this (Quran) were from other than Allah, you would find within it many contradictions."

And yet, another challenge offered by Allah the Almighty in the Qur'an is for the unbelievers to look around for evidences. Allah says He will show them His signs within themselves and on the farthest horizons.

Scientific Miracles in the Qur'an:

The scientific miracles of the Qur'an could not have been understood at that time, yet today we take for granted the many things included in the revelation of the Qur'an. It is the only book that passes the scientific test of modern age. The Qur'an does not require confirmation from science yet it is a miracle for all the times. This era is known as the era of science. The facts of nature that has been explored by the science have already been mentioned in the Qur'an. Only the Creator of this world could have told these facts 14 centuries ago. Dr. Maurice Bucallie a famous scientist converted to Islam has mentioned this fact in his book. The Qur'an is the only book that speaks in language of science. Some of the miraculous facts have been mentioned as follows:

- The formation of embryo with minute details in the womb of the mother.
- Deep seas partitions; waters that do not mix.
- Clouds and how they make rain and how lightning is caused by ice crystals.
- Formation of the earth's mountains deep underground.
- Orbits of planets and stars and moons and even the mention of space travel (surah 55:33).
- Everything has been created from water.
- The literal meaning of Munir.
- The expanding Universe.
- Big Bang and Big Crunch

Authenticity of the Qur'an and the Bible – Comparative Analysis

Criteria to Verify Authenticity of Any Sacred Book

- **Genuineness** – Was the book given and supervised by the founder of the religion?
Is the language original?
- **Authenticity** – Has the text remained free from contradictions, conflicts, and alterations?
- **Integrity** – Has anything been added or removed after the founder's time?

2. Compilation of the Bible

- Admitted by Christian scholars that the Bible is **not purely divine revelation**.
- Luke acted as a historian, arranging material on his own judgment.
- No evidence that it was compiled under divine instruction.

3. Language of the Bible

- Original language of Jesus: **Aramaic**.
- Bible written later in Hebrew, Greek, and Latin – not in Jesus' original language.
- Today no complete Hebrew or Greek manuscripts exist.
- First English Bible: 1525–1611, presented as “original” not as translation.
- Multiple versions exist (e.g., **King James Version**, others).

4. Language of the Qur'an

- Revealed directly in **Arabic**, Prophet Muhammad's own language.
- Still a living, widely spoken language.
- Qur'an always preserved in Arabic alongside translations.
- Written under the Prophet's direct supervision by scribes.
- Recited and verified by the Prophet himself, eliminating errors.
- No versions or variations exist worldwide.

5. Preservation of the Qur'an

- Completed and arranged during Prophet Muhammad's lifetime.
- Revised annually with Angel Jibreel; last Ramadan, revised twice.
- Thousands of companions memorized it (*huffaz*).
- Compilation under Abu Bakr (verified by multiple witnesses).

- Standardization under Uthman – one Qurayshi dialect for unity.
- Oldest manuscripts preserved (e.g., Birmingham Qur'an, Topkapi Museum).
- Carbon dating confirms manuscripts from the Prophet's era.

6. Authenticity of the Bible – Scholarly Views

- **Dr. Graham Scroggie (Moody Bible Institute):** Bible compiled by humans.
- **Kenneth Cragg:** Gospels shaped by editing, condensation, and church influence.
- **Cambridge History of the Bible:** New Testament compiled from writings for other purposes; external evidence is weak or unreliable.
- Estimated **30,000–50,000 errors/variations** in the Bible.
- Presence of contradictions and scientific inaccuracies.

7. Authenticity of the Qur'an

- Only one version of the Qur'an worldwide.
- No differences in wording or alphabet.
- Memorization across centuries ensures accuracy.
- Widely regarded as **the most authentic book on earth**.

Unique Preservation of the Qur'an

- The Qur'an stands apart from other scriptures due to its **dual preservation**:
 1. **Oral Transmission** – From the Prophet's companions to successive generations, millions have memorized the Qur'an (*huffaz*), ensuring an unbroken chain of recitation.
 2. **Written Record** – Standardized under Caliph Uthman within two decades of the Prophet's passing, distributed across the Muslim world, and verified by existing manuscripts.

Famous Surviving Early Manuscripts of the Qur'an

1. Topkapi Manuscript (Istanbul, Turkey)

- Preserved in the **Topkapi Palace Museum** in Istanbul.
- Traditionally attributed to one of the *Uthmanic codices*, standardized during the caliphate of Uthman ibn Affan (r. 644–656 CE).
- Written in early **Kufic script**, characterized by angular letters and minimal diacritical marks.

- Considered one of the most complete and carefully preserved Qur’anic manuscripts from the early Islamic centuries.

2. Samarkand Manuscript (Tashkent, Uzbekistan)

- Housed in the **Hast-Imam Library** in Tashkent.
- Traditionally believed to have belonged to Caliph Uthman and brought to Central Asia in the early Islamic conquests.
- Famous for its very large parchment leaves written in Kufic script.
- Though **incomplete**, it remains one of the most celebrated Qur’anic manuscripts and a symbol of early Islamic heritage.

3. Birmingham Qur’an Manuscript (United Kingdom)

- Preserved at the **University of Birmingham’s Cadbury Research Library**.
- Radiocarbon analysis dates the parchment to **568–645 CE**, overlapping with the Prophet Muhammad’s lifetime (570–632 CE).
- Written in **Hijazi script**, one of the earliest Arabic scripts with slanted letters and simple ornamentation.
- Its dating makes it among the **earliest known Qur’anic fragments**, confirming the Qur’an’s preservation from its earliest period.

4. Sana’a Manuscript (Yemen)

- Discovered in **1972** in the Great Mosque of Sana’a during restoration works.
- Includes a **palimpsest**, meaning an earlier text was erased and overwritten, yet both layers have been studied by scholars.
- The upper text matches the standardized Uthmanic Qur’an, while the lower text shows minor orthographic variations without affecting meaning.
- This discovery highlights the **remarkable textual consistency** of the Qur’an across centuries.

5. Mushaf al-Madina and Other Early Fragments

- Numerous early fragments are preserved worldwide, including in the:
 - **Bibliothèque Nationale de France (Paris)**
 - **British Library (London)**
 - **Dar al-Makhtutat (Sana’a, Yemen)**
- These manuscripts, written in early Kufic and Hijazi scripts, testify to the **rapid and widespread transmission** of the Qur’an in the first century of Islam.

The esteemed status of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ:

In the light of the Qur'an and Hadith

Allah, the Almighty, is the Creator and Sustainer of all worlds. Throughout every era, He has guided humanity by sending His messengers and revealing divine scriptures. The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is the final Messenger, and the Qur'an is the last and preserved revelation, intended to guide all of humanity until the end of time.

While all the Prophets hold a revered and honored position in Islam, Prophet Muhammad ﷺ stands as their leader and holds a unique status among them. Allah, in His infinite wisdom, has granted him unparalleled ranks and distinctions. It is through him that the blessings of Allah reach us. Obedience to the Prophet ﷺ is, in essence, obedience to Allah, and disobedience to him is regarded as disobedience to Allah.

The love and obedience of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is a divine obligation. Understanding his esteemed status through the lens of the Qur'an and Hadith enables us to nurture sincere love for him. Without such love, it becomes difficult to truly love Allah and uphold His commands. This reflection on the unique rank of the Prophet ﷺ serves to deepen our admiration and strengthen our connection to his noble example. The status of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in the Qur'an:

قُلْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ تُحِبُّونَ اللَّهَ فَاتَّبِعُونِي يُحْبِبْكُمُ اللَّهُ وَيَغْفِرْ لَكُمْ ذُنُوبَكُمْ ۗ وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ

Say, [O Muhammad], "If you should love Allah, then follow me, [so] Allah will love you and forgive you your sins. And Allah is Forgiving and Merciful." ⁴⁵

فَلَا وَرَبِّكَ لَا يُؤْمِنُونَ حَتَّىٰ يُحَكِّمُوكَ فِي مَا شَجَرَ بَيْنَهُمْ ثُمَّ لَا يَجِدُوا فِي أَنفُسِهِمْ حَرَجًا مِّمَّا قَضَيْتَ وَيُسَلِّمُوا تَسْلِيمًا

But no, by your Lord, they will not [truly] believe until they make you, [O Muhammad], judge concerning that over which they dispute among themselves and then find within themselves no discomfort from what you have judged and submit in [full, willing] submission. ⁴⁶

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تَقْذِفُوا إِلَيْهِ أَيْدِي اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ ۚ إِنَّ اللَّهَ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ ۚ يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تَرْفَعُوا أَصْوَاتَكُمْ فَوْقَ صَوْتِ النَّبِيِّ وَلَا تَجْهَرُوا لَهُ بِالْقَوْلِ كَجَهْرِ بَعْضِكُمْ لِبَعْضٍ أَن تَحْبَطَ أَعْمَالُكُمْ وَأَنتُمْ لَا تَشْعُرُونَ

O you who have believed, do not put [yourselves] before Allah and His Messenger but fear Allah. Indeed, Allah is Hearing and Knowing. O you who have believed, do not raise your voices above the voice of the Prophet or be loud to him in speech like the loudness of some of you to others, lest your deeds become worthless while you perceive not. ⁴⁷

⁴⁵ Qur'an: 3-31

⁴⁶ Qur'an:4-65

⁴⁷ Qur'an:49-1&2

The Eminence of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ as Illuminated by Hadith

We will not be able to attain the essence of Iman until and unless we love Holy Prophet ﷺ more than every relation of our life. As we cannot learn anything without effort and sacrifice, similarly his love also can't be induced automatically we have to learn and strive for his love. That is why Holy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ said:

By Him in Whose Hands my life is, none of you will have faith till he loves me more than his father and his children. ⁴⁸

All the Prophets will show the way of Muhammad ﷺ on the Day of Judgment.

It is stated in a hadith of Bukhari that on the Day of Judgment when all the people will go to Adam ؑ then Nouh ؑ then Ibrahim ؑ then Musa ؑ then Isa ؑ but all of them will say we are afraid today that what will happen with us. Today only one man can intercede in the court of Allah the Almighty. Go to Prophet Muhammad ﷺ.

The Holy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ said;

The people will come to me, and I will prostrate myself underneath Allah's Throne. Then I will be addressed: O Muhammad ﷺ! Raise your head; intercede, for your intercession will be accepted, and ask (for anything) for you will be given. ⁴⁹

This hadith shows the esteemed status of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in the court of Allah. When everyone will be afraid of Allah the Almighty Only Prophet Muhammad ﷺ will be allowed to speak with Allah directly. Allah the Almighty will not only listen to him but also accept his intercession. Prophet Muhammad ﷺ will not ask for his forgiveness; he will ask for the forgiveness of humanity.

⁴⁸ Sahih Bukhari:14

⁴⁹ (Sahih al-Bukhari # 3340)

Introduction of Hadith: it's components

And significance in Islamic Literature

Literal Meaning of the Hadith

The literal meaning of Arabic word hadith is “an item of news”, “conversation”, “a tale”, “a story”, “a report”, (this report can be historical or legendary, true or false whether relating to present or past). The secondary meaning of the hadith as adjective is “new” which opposed to qadim (old).

Technical meaning of the Hadith

The speech, acts, approval or moral conduct of the Prophet a is called hadith.

The Sunna (Prophetic Tradition)

Literal Meaning

“In its literal meaning the word sunna stands for the “well known path” or the “well-trodden path” which is followed again and again.”

Ibn Manzur writes the meaning of Sunna as: Sunna means tariqah, dastur.

Technical Definition

The speech, act approval or moral value or good conduct which belongs to the Prophet (upon whom be peace and greetings) is called Sunna. No matter if this speech, act, approval or the conduct is of the after or before the announcement of the Prophet Muhammad's (a) prophecy.

Components of the Prophetic Tradition

There are mainly two components of Hadith/Sunna.

Isnad (Chain of narrators) – This is the chain of narrators through which the Hadith is narrated.

Matan (Content) – This is the main text of the Hadith, or the narrated speech of the Prophet Muhammad (a).

Isnad means the name of persons mentioned before the text. It is the most significant part of the Deen. As the authenticity of hadith's text is totally dependent on these names. It will be easy to understand this concept with the help of an example.

حَدَّثَنَا الْحُمَيْدِيُّ عَبْدُ اللَّهِ بْنُ الزُّبَيْرِ، قَالَ: حَدَّثَنَا سُفْيَانُ، قَالَ: حَدَّثَنَا يَحْيَى بْنُ سَعِيدٍ الْأَنْصَارِيُّ، قَالَ: أَخْبَرَنِي مُحَمَّدُ بْنُ إِبْرَاهِيمَ التَّمِيمِيُّ، أَنَّهُ سَمِعَ عَلْقَمَةَ بْنَ وَقَّاصٍ اللَّيْثِيَّ، يَقُولُ: سَمِعْتُ عُمَرَ بْنَ الْخَطَّابِ رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُ عَلَى الْمِنْبَرِ، قَالَ: سَمِعْتُ رَسُولَ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ، يَقُولُ

This part is called isnad and the aforementioned is called the text.

Significance of Hadith in the light of Qur'an

The verses in which Allah declares that the sayings of the Prophet ﷺ carry the same authority as His own commands:

وَمَا يَنْطِقُ عَنِ الْهَوَىٰ - إِنْ هُوَ إِلَّا وَحْيٌ يُوحَىٰ

*And he does not speak out from his own desire, His speech is nothing but a revelation, which is sent to him.*⁵⁰

مَنْ يُطِيعِ الرَّسُولَ فَقَدْ أَطَاعَ اللَّهَ

*Whoever obeys the Messenger a obeys (but) Allah indeed.*⁵¹

These are not enough Allah has conditioned his love for the Muslims with the obedience of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ.

It is important to note that when the Qur'an commands obedience to Allah and His Messenger, it points to two sources of guidance: The Qur'an itself and the Hadith of the Prophet ﷺ. it signifies that Muslims are to follow both the revelations of Allah contained in the Qur'an and the teachings, guidance, and practices of the Prophet ﷺ preserved in the Hadith. Together, these two sources form the complete framework for Islamic guidance, providing direction in belief, worship, and daily conduct.

وَمَنْ يَعْصِ اللَّهَ وَرَسُولَهُ وَيَتَعَدَّ حُدُودَهُ يُدْخِلْهُ تَارًا خَالِدًا فِيهَا وَلَهُ عَذَابٌ مُهِينٌ

“But whoever disobeys Allah and His Messenger and exceeds His limits, He will admit him to Hell wherein shall he dwell forever; and there is a humiliating torment for him.”

Significance of Hadith in the light of Prophetic Traditions

“al-Miqdam bin Ma'dkarib reported the Apostle of Allah as saying:

*“Beware! I have been given the Qur'an and something like it, yet the time is coming when a man replace on his couch will say: Keep the Qur'an: what you find into be is permissible treat as permissible, and what you find in it to be prohibited treat as prohibited, Beware! The domestic ass, beats of prey with fangs, a find belonging to a confederate, unless its owner does not want it, are not permissible, but if they do not, he has right to mulct them to an amount equivalent to his entertain.”*⁵²

In this tradition the Prophet has commanded about the matters which are not mentioned in the Qur'an. He commanded them on his own legal authority. In another hadith the significance of hadith has been stated in the following words:

⁵⁰ Qur'an: 53:3-4

⁵¹ Qur'an: 4:80

⁵² Sunan Abu Dawud, # 4604

“Does any of you, while reclining on his couch, imagine that Allah has prohibited only what is to be found in the Qur’an? By Allah, I have preached, commanded and prohibited many matters as numerous as what is found in the Qur’an, or more numerous”.⁵³

The Forms of Representative Sovereignty of the Prophet Muhammad (a)

According to the Qur’an and Sunna the ultimate sovereignty has been vested in the Prophet as:

i) Interpretative Authority (حيثيت تشریعی)

The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ interpreted the verses of the Holy Qur’an for the believers. The Qur’an states about the interpretative capacity of the Holy Prophet a:

وَأَنْزَلْنَا إِلَيْكَ الذِّكْرَ لِتُبَيِّنَ لِلنَّاسِ مَا نُزِّلَ إِلَيْهِمْ وَلَعَلَّهُمْ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ

“(They too were sent) with clear proofs and the Books. And, (O Glorious Messenger,) We have revealed to you the Glorious Reminder (the Qur’an) so that you may explain clearly to people (the message and the commandments) that have been sent down to them and that they may meditate.”

The Qur’an commands to pray the Salah approximately 700 times but doesn’t explain that how? When? And for how many times in a day. All these details are found in Prophetic traditions.

صَلُّوا كَمَا رَأَيْتُمُونِي أُصَلِّي

pray as you have seen me pray.⁵⁴

The Qur’an commands to pray the Salah but doesn’t explain that how? When? And for how many times in a day. These details are found in Prophetic traditions.

Same is the case in regard of months of Hajj, The specification of punishment of fornication. Similarly, Prophet Muhammad ﷺ explained the times of fast’s term to his companions. It was the duty of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ to explain the verses of the Qur’an.

ii) Legislative Authority (حيثيت تشريعی)

Allah the Almighty has given the status of Legislation to Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. He has the manifestative authority of Allah in this world. It will be easy to understand this concept in the light of following references.

وَمَا آتَاكُمُ الرَّسُولُ فَخُذُوهُ وَمَا نَهَاكُمْ عَنْهُ فَانْتَهُوا ۚ

⁵³ Sunan Abu Dawud # 3050

⁵⁴ Sahih al-Bukhari # 605

*And whatever the Messenger has given you take; and what he has forbidden you-refrain from.*⁵⁵

Whatever he says or allows becomes the integral part of Islamic law. We can find its examples in many traditions.

*The Messenger of Allah said: "Wearing silk and gold has been made unlawful for the males of my Ummah and lawful for its females."*⁵⁶

We find another example during the address of farewell pilgrimage. When all the Companions knew the answers of the questions but they remain silent. This was the reverence of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ as all of them were aware of Prophetic status.

*The Prophet ﷺ then asked, "Which month is this?" We said, "Allah and his Apostle know better." He kept silent so long that we thought that he would call it by a name other than its real name. He said, "Isn't it the month of Dhul-Hijja?" We said, "Yes." He said, "Which town is this?" We said, "Allah and His Apostle know better." He kept silent so long that we thought that he would call it by a name other than its real name. He said, "Isn't it the town (of Mecca)?" We replied, "Yes." He said, "What day is today?" We replied, "Allah and His Apostle know better." He kept silent so long that we thought that he would call it by a name other than its real name. He said, "Isn't it the day of Nahr?" We replied, "Yes." He then said, "Your blood, properties and honor are as sacred to one another as this day of yours in this town of yours in this month of yours."*⁵⁷

⁵⁵ Sura 59 verse #7.

⁵⁶ Tirmidhi # 1730

⁵⁷ Sahih al-Bukhari # 5550

Classification of Hadith

There are different types of hadith according to its content, transmitters, and authenticity. Few important types are given below:

Classification of Hadith by Nature

Hadith-i-Qudsi meaning “Divine”. These were narrated directly from Allah by the Prophet Muhammad (a), who then passed it on to his Companions.

Hadith-i-Nabawi

The Hadith directly narrated from the Prophet Muhammad (a) by His Companions.

Classification of Hadith by accuracy

The narrators hold an important position in the narration of Hadith. The accuracy of Hadith greatly depends on truthfulness, trustworthiness and reliability of the narrators. On the basis of authenticity and accuracy the scholars have divided ahadith into following four categories.

Sahih (Sound)

The sound hadith is a hadith, the isnad of which coheres continuously through the transmission of one upright and accurate person from another up to its point of termination.

- A hadith in which five conditions of authenticity are found called sahih:
- Its chain of transmission should be connected, that is, every narrator should have taken it directly from the immediate narrator.
- Every narrator should be just, he should avoid major sins, he should not insist on minor sins, he should be of good nature and moral character.
- He should have perfect discipline; he should preserve the Hadith through writing or memorization and pass it on.
- That Hadith should not be rare.
- The narrator should not have passed bad comments against his predecessors.

Hasan (Fair)

Fair is the hadith, the source of which is known and the transmitters of which are famous. Or A hadith whose narrators are “slightly more restrained” than the narrators of a Sahih Hadith, the rest of the conditions are the same.

Da’if (Weak)

Linguistically, Da’if means “weak”, while technically it refers to a narration below the standard of Hasan. This is a Hadith in which any one or more of the five conditions of Sahih have not been met.

Mawdu (Fabricated)

A hadith whose narrator has at some point lied about the hadith, every narration of such a narrator is called a fabrication. If the defect in the narrator is that he is known to lie on the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, his Ahadith are classified as Mawdu. Technically, a Mawdu

narration is not a Hadith at all, but a lie attributed to The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. It is referred to as a Hadith figuratively.

History and compilation of Hadith

Era of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ

Companions of the Prophet sought guidance directly from him and made efforts to memorize and learn Hadith.

The Prophet encouraged writing down his teachings and frequently repeated his words for clarity.

Notable instances include:

‘Abdullah bin Amr wrote down everything he heard from the Prophet, despite initial opposition from the Quraysh.

The Prophet instructed companions to write for those who requested it, such as Abu Shah.

Companions memorized Hadith and created written manuscripts, such as:

Sahifa Ali

Sahifa Sadiqa by Abdullah Ibn Amr

Sahifa Amr bin Hazam

Compilation of Hadith in Companions' Era

- Companions learned Hadith through memorization, recording, and practice.
- Official Teachings: During Hazrat Umar's caliphate, senior scholars were appointed to teach the Qur'an and Sunnah.
- Hadith Circles: Prominent Companions established circles to narrate and teach Hadith to successors, leading to various written manuscripts.

Era of the Successors (Tabi'in)

- As Islam spread, the narration of Hadith increased, prompting the need to combat fabricated Hadith.
- Caliph Umar ibn Abdul-Aziz initiated the compilation of authentic Hadith.
- Scholars began documenting the biographies of Hadith narrators to ensure authenticity.

Era of the Followers (Taba Tabi'in)

- This period marked a significant surge in Hadith compilation, characterized as a golden period.
- Important Hadith books were compiled, focusing on authentic transmission and the character of narrators.
- Notable compilations include:

- Sahih al-Bukhari by Imam Bukhari
- Sahih Muslim by Imam Muslim
- Other significant texts by Abu Dawud, Tirmidhi, Nisa'i, and Ibn Maja.

Conclusion

The compilation of Hadith began during the life of Prophet Muhammad, who instructed his companions to preserve his teachings.

This meticulous effort by Companions, Successors, and Followers has led to a rich collection of Hadith literature that remains significant today.

Social System of Islam

The Islamic social system is a comprehensive framework derived from Quran and Sunnah (the teachings and practices of the Prophet Muhammad a). It emphasizes divine guidance to establish a balanced and equitable society built on principles of justice, equality, and community welfare.

An Islamic society is the society whose members have faith in Islam, apply its laws in their lives, abide by its moral standards of love, brotherhood, equality, mercy, and trust, performing religious duties and abstaining from all evil and unlawful activities.

In a true Islamic society, drinking alcohol, practicing usury, dressing immodestly, deceiving each other, giving or taking bribes, injustice, violating other's rights, are all avoided and prohibited.

Even when the society is so-called Muslim but people in it discard Islam and commit unlawful acts publicly without the slightest feeling of shame, and no power or authority exists to deter them, this society cannot be considered as an Islamic one. What matters is the lifestyle and system they adopt, not the name they call it.

Structure of Islamic Social System:

The social system in Islam is founded on maintaining good morals, ties and relationships which draw Muslims close together and organize their lives.

The foundations:

- 1- Equality
- 2- Equity/ Justice
- 3- Brotherhood
- 4- Unity
- 5- Loyalty among the faithful
- 6- Sympathy and mutual kindness
- 7- Social Welfare and Co-operation
- 8- Promoting Good and Preventing Evil
- 9- Education and Knowledge
- 10- Sacrifice
- 11- Tolerance

12- Duties and Responsibilities

13- Rights

Equality:

Equality is a fundamental value in the Islamic social system. Every individual, regardless of race, gender or social status, is entitled to fair treatment and equal rights. According to Islam, all human beings have been originated from one couple Adam and Eve, and this couple was created by Almighty Allah.

Allah, the Most Glorified, says:

"O men! Fear your Lord who created you from a single soul (Adam), and from it created its match (Eve), and spread many men and women from the two." (An-Nisaa, 4:1)

He also says:

"O mankind! We have created you from a male and a female, and made you into races and tribes, so that you may identify one another". (Al-Hujuraat Ayah 49:13)

The progeny of this couple were initially a single group of people with one religion and same language. But, with the passage of time, their number gradually increased and they spread all over the earth and as a natural result, their languages, dresses, life style and thinking varied and widely differed. But Islam describes that all human beings have equal rights of living and freedom as they are the offspring of one couple. There is no concept of VIP culture in a Muslim society.

Prophet (a) said in his address at Hajj:

"O people! Surely, your lord is one and your father is one. Beware! there is no supremacy for any Arabian over Ajami (Non Arabian) nor for any Ajami over an Arabian, neither for white over black nor for black over white except with piety". (Musnad Ahmad)

Equity and Justice:

The Islamic Social system establishes justice and equality for all people, regardless of their background. Islam rejects social hierarchies and prejudices based on race, colour, or origin, emphasizing that the most honoured person in the sight of God is the most righteous one.

Allah, the Most Glorified, says:

"And maintain justice, surely Allah loves those who maintain justice". (Al-Hujurat 49: 9)

Allah also states:

"O you who believe! Be steadfast for (obeying the commands of) Allah as witnesses for justice, malice against a people should not make you avoid justice, make justice as it is nearer to piety (Taqwa), and fear Allah, indeed, Allah is all-aware of what you do". (Al-Ma'idah 5: 8)

Brotherhood:

In an Islamic Society, all the Muslims, regardless of their life styles, casts, colours, geographies and languages, are brothers and they must behave with each other like brothers. They should treat each other in a way that no one should be the cause to hurt or annoy anyone in the society. A Muslim should neither oppress or tyrannize his Muslim brother nor let others do so. A strong sense of community, unity, and mutual affection should bind all Muslims into a single body, encouraging cooperation and support for one another.

Allah, the Most Glorified, says:

"All the believers are but brothers, so seek reconciliation between two of your brothers, and fear Allah, so that you may be blessed with mercy". (Al-Hujurat, 49:10)

Prophet (a) said:

"Every Muslim is a brother to another Muslim, neither does wrong to him nor handovers him (to one who may do wrong to him), whoever is in the need of his brother, Allah will be in his need" (Bukhari)

Unity and Collectiveness:

Unity and collectiveness is also one of the basics of Islamic social system and is very much emphasized. Islam drives its followers to get as united as bricks in a wall, or different parts in a body.

Qur'an refers to the end result of weakness and disgrace in the world in case of Muslims get divided into various sectors religiously, geographically, linguistically or even politically.

As per Qur'an, it is a great sin & fault departing from the collectiveness of the believers and those who follow some separate sector or path have been seriously threatened with the fire of hell by Allah the Exalted.

Allah, the Most Glorified, says:

"And hold fast, all of you together, to the cord of Allah, and be not divided". (Aali-Imraan 4:103)

Allah further says:

"And obey Allah and His messenger, and do not dispute with each other, lest you should lose courage, and your prowess would evaporate, and be patient, surely Allah is with the patients". (Al-Anfaal 8:46)

Prophet (a) said:

"Indeed, the believer to believer is like a solid structure, each part strengthens the other, and he interlaced his fingers." (Bukhari)

Loyalty among the faithful:

Empathy, love, and loyalty are encouraged among people, creating a harmonious and caring society.

Allah, the Most Glorified, says:

"And the believing men and believing women are allies of each other....." (At-Taubah 9:71)

Sympathy, Condolence and mutual kindness:

According to Islamic teachings, every member in an Islamic society must have the sympathetic feelings for all other members. This is emphasized to be kind, compassionate and sympathetic to each other. Harshness and tyranny is strictly condemned in Islam particularly against Muslim.

Islam refers to show condolence for the Muslims who suffer from any disease, loss or any misfortune. It is considered as a great good deed and is rewardable as well in Islam. Islam declares it as a right of relatives and neighbours too.

Allah, the Compassionate, says:

"And those who spend (for Allah's sake) in prosperity and in adversity, and those who control anger and forgive people, and Allah loves those who are good in their deeds". (Aali-Imran 3:134)

Prophet (a) said:

"Surely, Allah is kind and likes the kindness". (Muslim)

He further said:

"Be merciful upon those on earth, the One in the sky (Allah) will be merciful upon you". (Abu Dawood)

Social Welfare and Co-operation:

In the Islamic social system, cooperation is a fundamental aspect, guided by the principle of collaborating on righteousness and piety, but not on sin and aggression.

Justice is also a key tenet, with Allah commanding believers to uphold these values in all interactions.

In every aspect of life, the members of an Islamic society should cooperate wholeheartedly with each other. For example, building mosques and schools, helping the needy, fighting oppression, establishing economic, social and cultural associations, all are forms of co-operation within the society.

The welfare of the community is a core principle, with acts of charity like Zakat (obligatory alms-giving) and Sadaqah (voluntary charity) ensuring a safety net for the less privileged. This promotes mutual support and discourages extreme wealth disparity.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

“....and cooperate (with each other) for righteousness and cooperate not in sin and enmity, and be afraid of Allah...” (Al-Ma'idah 5:2)

Promoting Good and Preventing Evil:

In an Islamic Society, a collective responsibility is placed on the Muslim community to encourage virtuous conduct and discourage wrongdoing. This principle ensures the moral health of society.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

“You are the best nation ever raised for (the betterment of) mankind, you enjoin the good and forbid the evil and you believe in Allah....” (Aali-Imran 3:110)

Allah, the Almighty, further says:

“And let there be (arising) a group of people from among you inviting towards the good, enjoining the good and forbidding the evil, and it is these who will be the successful.” (Aali-Imran 3:104)

Prophet (a) said:

“By the one who holds my soul, you must enjoin the good and forbid the evil. Or, Allah may send torment from Him, then you may call Him, but He may not answer you.” (Musnad Ahmad)

Education and Knowledge:

In an Islamic Society, the pursuit of knowledge is highly emphasized, encompassing both religious and worldly education. Learning is considered a lifelong obligation and is highly valued reflecting an intellectual curiosity to be fostered within the Muslim community.

As Islam is a religion of practice, sharia provides comprehensive guidelines for all aspects of life, including social, economic, political, and personal conduct. It is derived from Quran, Sunnah, Ijma (consensus), and Qiyas (analogical reasoning).

Allah, the All Knowing, says:

“Say, “are those who know equal to those who do not know?” (Az-Zumar 39:9)

Allah, the Exalted, Says:

“.... Allah will raise those in ranks who have believed among you and those who were given knowledge....” (Al-Mujadalah 58:11)

Sacrifice:

Islam teaches its followers to not to be selfish, greedy or egocentric, instead, Islam encourages the sacrifice and preferring others over yourself. This is also a well appreciated good deed in Islam as it leads the society to its best.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

“.... And (they) give preference (to others) over themselves, even though they are in privation, and whoever is protected from the stinginess of his soul, it is those who will be the successful”. (Al-Hashr 59: 9)

Tolerance and Forgiveness:

Tolerance is also an important teaching of Islam in order to establishing a peaceful Muslim society. Islam categorically explains the duties and the rights to the society members, and emphasises the believers to not to cause any mischief in the society, particularly discourages any harsh step in case of not receiving the due right. Instead, Islam urges for the patience and forgiveness to avoid the disturbance in the harmony and the peace.

As per Islamic teachings, withdrawing from a right to avoid the mischief is greatly appreciated that leads to ultimate reward from the Lord.

Prophet (a) said:

“Whoever withdraws from the dispute even though he is right, a house is built for him in the middle of paradise”. (Musnad Ahmad)

Moreover, forgiving the people for their mistakes is also an Islamic teaching that provides a solid foundation for maintaining peace and harmony in the society. Islam emphasises upon it and appreciates it.

Allah, the Most Merciful, says:

“.... And whoever pardons and makes reconciliation, his reward is undertaken by Allah ...” (Ash-Shura 42:40)

Allah, the Almighty, says:

"And whoever observes patience and forgives, it is, of course, one of the courageous conducts." (Ash-Shura 42:43)

Hence, this is not obligatory in Islam to forgive all of the mistakes even the crimes of an offender; it may cause the villainies and the lawlessness in the society. Instead, it is conditional and in some cases the punishment is also recommended to discourage the villainous people and bully peace breakers.

Along with the promotion of forgiveness, the even retaliation (Qisas) especially in offences of murder or grievous hurts is also encouraged in Qur'an.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

"There is life for you in Qisas O people of wisdom, so that you may be secured". (Al-Baqarah 2:179)

Duties and Responsibilities:

Duty and the responsibility is also the part of the basics of Islamic teachings towards a society. Islam insists upon its followers to be dutiful and responsible towards their units. These duties have been assigned by the Lord and are clearly classified to every individual.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

"And give the relative his right and the needy and the wayfarer, and do not spend wastefully". (Bani Isra'il 17:26)

Rights:

Every individual, in a Muslim society, deserves the due rights on the basis of equality and no one is allowed to deprive him from any of his rights. These rights have been categorically described by Allah the Exalted and his Prophet (a) in details.

Allah, the Most Glorified, says:

"So give to the kinsman his right, and to the needy and the wayfarer. That is better for those who seek Allah's pleasure, and it is they who will be successful". (Ar-Rum 30:38)

Family structure and Marriage

The family is regarded as the fundamental unit of society and is a central focus of Islamic teachings. Marriage is promoted as the basis for forming a family, while modesty (Haya) and dignity in relationships are highly emphasized.

The family is considered the cornerstone of society in Islam. It is the primary institution for nurturing and educating individuals in moral and social values.

A family is a collective mass of some persons like father, mother, husband, wife and children. According to Islam, every single person must be committed to perform his duties towards his family whether he/she is a father/mother or husband/wife or a child.

In a family, every person deserves some rights and he/she is also assigned some duties. To become a good Muslim, every individual should perform his duty gladly which is in fact the right of other family members.

Family members and their rights:

Rights of husband.

Rights of wife.

Rights of parents.

Rights of children.

Rights of brothers and sisters.

Marriage is a sacred institution and a legal contract (Nikah) in Islam. It is highly encouraged and seen as a means to foster love, companionship, and procreation. For all family members, Islam has defined roles and responsibilities, promoting harmony and stability within the household.

Rights and Duties of Spouse:

Both spouses have specific rights and duties. The husband is responsible for the financial maintenance (Nafaqah) of the family, while the wife's primary role is to manage the household and raise children, though she is also entitled to work and pursue personal interests.

The husband's rights over his wife.

The rights of the husband over his wife are among the greatest rights; indeed, his rights over her are greater than her rights over him.

Allah, the All Wise, says:

"... And they (women) have rights (over husbands) same as (husbands have rights) over them as per what is reasonable, but men have a degree (authority) over them" (Al-Baqarah 2:228)

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

"If I were to command anyone to prostrate to anyone other than Allah, I would have commanded women to prostrate to their husbands. By the One in Whose hand is the soul of Muhammad, no woman can fulfil her duty towards Allah until she fulfils her duty

towards her husband. If he asks her (for intimacy) even if she is on her camel saddle, she should not refuse.” (Ibn-e- Majah, Classed as Sahih by Albani)

Prophet ﷺ also said:

“If I were to instruct anyone to prostrate to anyone, I would have instructed women to prostrate to their husbands, because of the rights that Allah has given them (husbands) over them (Wives).” (Abu Dawood, classed as Sahih by Albani)

The wives should also remember that pleasing the husband is a way to Jannah.

The Prophet ﷺ said:

- *“If a woman prays her five (daily prayers), fasts her month (Ramadaan), guards her chastity and obeys her husband, it will be said to her: ‘Enter Paradise from whichever of the gates of Paradise you wish.’” (Ibn Habbaan, Classes as Sahih by Albani)*
- *“Any woman who dies when her husband is pleased with her, will enter Paradise.” (al-Tirmidhi, classed as hasan).*
- *Al-Husayn ibn Muhsin that his paternal aunt came to the Prophet ﷺ for something and he dealt with her need, then the Prophet ﷺ said: “Do you have a husband?” She said, “Yes.” He said: “How are you with him?” She said, “I do not neglect any of his rights except those I am unable to fulfil.” He ﷺ said: “Look at how you are with him, for he is your paradise and your hell” (Musnad Ahmad)*

The husband’s rights include:

1- The obligation of obedience

Allah has made the man as Qawwaam (protector and maintainer) of the woman by commanding, directing and taking care of her, just as guardians take care of their charges, by virtue of the physical and mental faculties that Allah has given only to men and the financial obligations that He has enjoined upon them.

Allah, the Almighty, says:

“Men are the protectors and maintainers of women, because Allah has made one of them to excel the other, and because they spend (to support them) from their means. Therefore, the righteous women are obedient (to Allah and their husbands), and guard that which Allah has ordered them to guard (their chastity and their husbands property) in the absence of their husbands.” [al-Nisaa’ 4:34]

2- Making herself available to her husband

One of the rights that the husband has over his wife is that he should be able to enjoy her (physically). If he marries a woman and she is able to have intercourse, she is obliged to submit herself to him according to the contract, if he asks her.

If a wife refuses to respond to her husband's request for intercourse, she has done something haraam and has committed a major sin, unless she has a valid shar'ei excuse such as menses, obligatory fasting, sickness, etc.

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

"When a man calls his wife to his bed and she refuses, and he goes to sleep angry with her, the angels will curse her until morning." (Bukhaari, 3065; Muslim, 1436)

The Husband should also respond to the call for intercourse by his wife. It is not permissible for a man to forsake his wife and harm her, except in the case of Nushooz (rebellion) and disobedience. But he is not sinful if he does not lie with her without intending to harm her. The curse mentioned in the hadeeth is specific for a wife.

Prophet ﷺ advised a companion who was fasting a lot and not having enough intercourse with his wife, he ﷺ said, "Do not do that! Observe the fast sometimes and also leave them (the fast) at other times; stand up for the prayer at night and also sleep at night. Your body has a right over you, your eyes have a right over you and your wife has a right over you" (Bukhari

3- Not allowing anyone entering home without permission

One of the rights of husband has over his wife is that she should not permit anyone entry in the home whom he dislikes.

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

"It is not permitted for a woman to fast when her husband is present without his permission, or to admit anyone into his house without his permission. And whatever she spends (in charity) of his wealth without his consent" (Bukhaari, 4899; Muslim, 1026)

This also includes the relatives of the wife, if the husband does not like them then she has to oblige. She can try and convince him to allow the relatives so that she can meet them (Mahrams only), but she has to obey the order without arguing on husband's decision. He is answerable for his actions, the wife will be rewarded for patience, but if the wife fights and let her relatives in without the consent of her husband then she is disobeying and is answerable to Allah for her wrongdoing.

4- Respect and honour

It is a common thing to see women gathering and complaining about their husbands, this is something which is prohibited and very dangerous to indulge in.

“The Messenger of Allah ﷺ went out to the prayer-ground for the (prayer of) Adhaa or Fitr, and he passed by the women and said, “O women! Give in charity, for I have been shown that you shall be the majority of the people of the Fire.” So they asked, ‘Why is that, O Messenger of Allaah?’ He replied, ‘You curse frequently and are ungrateful to your husbands.’” (Bukhari)

Just like it is a right of a wife that the husband does not talk ill of her in front of others, the wife also is obliged to protect the honour of her husband and not be the source of people disrespecting him.

A point to note, when the sisters complain about their husbands to their family members, they naturally develop an ill feeling against him and he loses respect in their eyes, you being the wife will forgive him later, but your relatives do not let go. This can have really bad repercussions: fights between families, husband and wives fighting with regards to their respective families, husband forbidding the wife from meeting her relatives, the wife disobeying the husband are just a few examples of the problems this can cause.

5- Not going out of the house without husband’s permission

One of the rights of the husband over his wife is that she should not go out of the house except with his permission.

6- Discipline.

The husband has the right to discipline his wife if she disobeys him in something good, not if she disobeys him in something sinful, because Allah has enjoined disciplining women by forsaking them in bed and by hitting them, when they do not obey.

Allah, the Almighty, says:

- *“As to those women on whose part you see ill-conduct, admonish them (first), (next) refuse to share their beds, (and last) beat them (lightly, if it is useful)” [al-Nisaa’ 4:34]*
- *“O you who believe! Protect yourselves and your families against a Fire (Hell) whose fuel is men and stones” (At-Tahreem 66:6)*

7- The wife serving her husband.

First of all by carrying out what is required in his house, such as bringing up and educating the children, preparing the meals and the beds and so on.

Here is an example of how Asmaa' bint Abi Bakr (RA) served her husband. She said,

“Zubayr married me and he did not have any property or slaves or anything upon the earth except for a camel which drew water from the well and his horse. So I used to feed his horse, draw the water, stitch his water bucket, and prepare the dough, but I was not proficient in baking bread – so ladies from the Ansaar who were my neighbours and were honourable used to bake the bread for me. I also used to carry the date-stones upon my head, from the land given to Zubayr by Allah’s Messenger ﷺ and it was about two miles away. One day when I was coming with the date-stones on my head, I met Allah’s Messenger ﷺ and a group of the Ansaar were with him. So he called me and said, ‘Ikh, ikh.’ In order to carry me behind him upon the camel. But I felt shy to proceed along with the men, and I thought of Zubayr and his sense of jealousy, and he was one of the most jealous of the people. So Allah’s Messenger ﷺ saw my shyness and so passed on. So I came to Zubayr and said, ‘Allah’s Messenger ﷺ met me while I was carrying the date stones upon my head and with him were a group of his Companions. He caused his riding camel to kneel, but I felt shy and remembered your sense of jealousy.’ So he said, ‘By Allah your having to carry the date-stones is harder upon me than that you should ride along with him.’” She said, “Then later on Abu Bakr sent me a servant to look after the horse, so it was as if he had set me free.”

8- Submitting herself to him

Once the conditions of the marriage-contract have been fulfilled and it is valid, then the woman is obliged to submit herself to her husband and allow him to enjoy her (physically), because once the contract is completed, he is allowed in return to enjoy her, and the wife is entitled to the compensation in the shape of Mahr.

9- Beautifying herself for him

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ was asked,

“Which of the women is the best?” He ﷺ replied, “The one who gives him pleasure when he looks; obeys him when he orders; and does not go against his wishes with regard to herself or her wealth by doing that which he dislikes. “ (An-Nasaa’i)

The rights of Wife over her Husband

The wife has also been given the due rights over husband. These rights include financial rights like right of Mahr (dowry), spending and accommodation, and also some non-financial rights, such as fair division between co-wives, being treated in a decent and reasonable manner, and not being treated in a harmful way by her husband.

The men need to realise that the one of the main reasons of Muslim women becoming part of the present day fitna of “Feminism” is a result of Muslim men abusing the rights given to women by Allah. We need to be more mindful of giving the rights to our women and in return get what we deserve.

FINANCIAL RIGHTS:

1: The Mahr (dowry).

This is the money to which the wife is entitled from her husband when the marriage contract is completed or when the marriage is consummated. It is a right which the man is obliged to pay to the woman.

Allah, the All Wise, says:

“And give to the women (whom you marry) their Mahr (obligatory bridal-money given by the husband to his wife at the time of marriage) with a good heart” (An-Nisaa’ 4:4)

The prescription of the Mahr demonstrates the seriousness and importance of the marriage-contract, and is a token of respect and honour to the woman.

2: Spending

The scholars of Islam are agreed that it is obligatory for husbands to spend on their wives, on the condition that the wife make herself available to her husband. If she refuses him or rebels, then she is not entitled to that spending.

The reason why it is obligatory to spend on her is that the woman is available only to her husband, because of the marriage contract, and she is not

allowed to leave the marital home except with his permission. So, he has to spend on her and provide for her, and this is in return for her making herself available to him for his pleasure.

What is meant by spending is providing what the wife needs of food, dress and accommodation. She has the right to these things even if she is rich.

Allah, the Most Glorified, says:

“... but the father of the child shall bear the cost of the mother’s food and clothing on a reasonable basis” (Al-Baqarah 2:233)

“... Let the rich man spend according to his means; and the man whose resources are restricted, let him spend according to what Allah has given him” (At-Talaaq 65:7)

The Prophet ﷺ replied to Hind bint Utbah (the wife of Abu Sufyan) when she said *"Abu Sufyan is a miserly man and I need to take some money out of his wealth."* The Prophet ﷺ said, *"Take reasonably what is sufficient for you and your children"* (Bukhari)

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

“Fear Allah concerning women! Verily you have taken them on the security of Allah, and intercourse with them has been made lawful unto you by words of Allah. You too have rights over them, and that they should not allow anyone to sit on your bed (i.e., not let them into the house) whom you do not like. But if they do that, you can chastise them but not severely. Their rights upon you are that you should provide them with food and clothing in a fitting manner” (Narrated by Muslim, 1218)

3: Accommodation

This is also one of the wife’s rights, which means that her husband should provide for her an accommodation according to his means and ability.

Allah, the Almighty, says:

“Lodge them (the divorced women) where you dwell, according to your means” (At-Talaaq 65:6)

Important Note:

Living with brother in law (alone) is not allowed:

The Prophet (a) warned against the husband's relatives who are not Mahrams to the wife entering upon her.

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

“Beware of entering upon women.” A man from among the Ansaar said: *“O Messenger of Allah! what about the brother-in-law?”* he ﷺ said: *“The brother-in-law is death.”* (Bukhari, 4934; Muslim, 2172).

NON-FINANCIAL RIGHTS

4 : Kind treatment:

The husband must have a good attitude towards his wife and be kind to her, and offer her everything that may soften her heart towards him.

Allah, the Exalted, says:

“and live with them honourably” (An-Nisaa' 4:19)

and

“... And they (women) have rights (over husbands) same as (husbands have rights) over them as per what is reasonable, but men have a degree (authority) over them” (Al-Baqarah 2:228)

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

“Be kind to women.” (Bukhari, 3153; Muslim, 1468).

He ﷺ also said:

“The best of you are those who are the best to their wives, and I am the best of you to my wives.” (Tirmidhi, 3895; Ibn-e-Majah, 1977; classed as Sahih by Albani).

He ﷺ also said:

“You never spend anything but you will be rewarded for it, even the morsel of food that you lift to your wife's mouth.” (Bukhari, 6352; Muslim, 1628).

5: Not Harming wife:

This is one of the basic principles of Islam that harming others is impermissible even in the case of strangers, how can one be allowed to harming one's wife.

Allah, the Most Merciful, says:

“Men are the protectors and maintainers of women ” (An-Nisaa 4:34)

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ ruled:

“There should be no harming nor reciprocating harm.” (Ibn-e-Maajah 2340)

Psychologically harming her is also impermissible same as the physical harming. Husband's should make sure that she is not harmed or abused with constant rejection, reviling, despising her for some small habits that he dislikes or allowing his relatives to oppress her by any mean.

The Messenger of Allah ﷺ said:

“A believing man does not despise a believing woman. If he finds something in her character that he dislikes, he will be pleased by something else.” (Muslim 1469).

Followings are also the types of harms to her:

- Overburdening her with work despite she is obliged to take care of the house is not appreciated. Husband should be reasonable and supportive to her in every way possible even by physically helping her. The Prophet ﷺ used to help in the house chores, and if the husband can afford to hire a maid, he should do so.
- Forcing her to contribute financially to run the household is not permissible if the husband can manage it. But in case of need, she should willingly contribute financially and her contribution is considered as Sadaqah and she will be rewarded by Allah for it as mentioned by the Messenger of Allah (a).
- Forcing her to serve husband's male relatives who are non-Mahram to her is prohibited indeed.

- Comparing her to other women and praising other women in front of her.
- Letting people know her secrets and weaknesses, the spouses are the Covers to each other and they should protect each other from external harm.
- Dismissing or not acknowledging her physical difficulties and pain that comes with pregnancy and motherhood.
- Complaining about one's wife to others especially family members and sharing marital problems and disagreements which should be only between the husband and wife. The problems should be disclosed to a third person only if there is a need for them to be involved and counsel the couple, not as a way of venting out, as this causes the wife losing respect in front of others.
- Belittling, insulting and making fun of the wife in front of others especially children. If you want your children to be obedient and respectful, you have to be a living example and teach them respect by actions and not by mere words.

6: Satisfy her physical needs:

This is also needed to mentioned here the importance of this right of a woman over her husband. It is something that keeps the relation happy and healthy and saves her from the fitnah. So, husbands should be mindful of giving this right to her knowing very well that if she is satisfied, she will surely make it more pleasurable for him.

7: Fair treatment of co-wives:

One of the rights that a wife secures over her husband is that she and her co-wives should be treated equally, if the husband has other wives, with regard to nights spent with them, spending and clothing.

Parents children relationships

In Islam, the parent-child relationship is built on mutual obligations and reciprocal commitments, with distinct and high-ranking responsibilities for both parties. Parents are commanded to raise their children with love, kindness, and proper guidance, while

children are obligated to show utmost respect, gratitude, and care for their parents, especially as they grow older.

Duties of parents toward their children

Parents are entrusted by Allah to nurture and guide their children, who are considered as blessing and a trust (Amanah). These responsibilities are a means for parents to earn immense rewards in this life and the afterlife.

Before and after birth

- **Providing a respectable life:** Islam guarantees a child's right to a good life, including financial security for their food, clothing, housing, and education. Infanticide, a practice common in pre-Islamic Arabia, is strictly forbidden.
- **Giving a good name:** Parents should choose a good, pleasant name for their child, as a name is believed to have a psychological effect on a person.
- **Showing love and affection:** Parents are instructed to shower their children with love, kindness, and mercy. The Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) was known for his immense kindness toward children and would kiss and embrace them.
- **Treating children equally:** Parents must be just and fair in their treatment of all their children, including in matters of gift-giving. Favouritism is strongly discouraged as it can lead to resentment and harm.

Upbringing and education

- **Nurturing their character:** A key duty is to provide a proper upbringing (Tarbiyah) and instil good manners (Adaab). This includes promoting good behaviour through kindness and patience, with punishment as a last resort.
- **Prioritizing religious education:** Parents must raise their children with a deep appreciation and love for Islam. This includes teaching them Islamic principles, worship, and the stories of the prophets.
- **Providing a good environment:** Creating a loving, supportive, and morally sound environment is crucial for a child's healthy emotional and spiritual development.

- **Leading by example:** Children learn by observing their parents. For this reason, parents must be role models by embodying the values they wish to instil in their children.
- **Adapting to their age:** Islamic parenting recognizes three stages of childhood development: play during the first seven years, education during the next seven, and befriending and advising during the final seven years.
- **Protecting them from harm:** Parents have a responsibility to protect their children from physical, emotional, and spiritual harm. This includes shielding them from negative influences and providing for their health needs.

Duties of children toward their parents

The rights of parents are given a very high status in Islam, second only to the worship of God. Showing kindness to parents is considered one of the most virtuous deeds.

Showing respect and gratitude

- **Being obedient:** Children must obey their parents in all matters that do not involve disobedience to Allah. Even if parents are non-believers, they must still be treated with kindness and respect.
- **Showing humility and honour:** The Quran commands children not to speak even a word of contempt (uff) to their parents, particularly as they reach old age. Children are instructed to lower their "wing of humility" out of mercy, speaking to their parents with noble and respectful words.
- **Praying for them:** Children should pray for their parents, asking Allah to have mercy on them, just as they showed mercy to their children when they were small. This is also encouraged after parents pass away.
- **Showing gratitude:** Children are obligated to be grateful to both Allah and their parents for their upbringing.

Providing care and support

- **Providing financial support:** Children must provide for their parents and meet their needs if the parents become elderly, weak, or unable to support themselves.
- **Caring in old age:** As parents age, they may become physically and mentally feeble. It is the children's duty to care for them patiently and with tenderness, just as they were cared for in childhood.
- **Maintaining ties even after death:** The duties of children continue even after their parents' death. This includes praying for them, honoring their promises, and respecting their friends.

The special status of mothers

The mother holds an even higher status than the father, an acknowledgment of the hardship she endures during pregnancy, childbirth, and nursing. The Prophet Muhammad famously reiterated the importance of the mother three times when asked who deserved the most kindness, before mentioning the father. He also stated that "Paradise lies under the feet of mothers".

Status and Role of Women in Islam

The role of women in Islamic society, as defined by the primary sources of the Quran and the Sunnah (the teachings and practices of Prophet Muhammad ﷺ), is one of dignity, responsibility, and spiritual equality. It is a comprehensive role that encompasses spiritual, social, economic, and familial dimensions.

It is crucial to understand that Islamic teachings emerged in 7th-century Arabia, a context where women were often treated as property, female infanticide was common, and women had very few rights. The Quran and the Sunnah revolutionized their status, granting them rights that were unprecedented at the time.

1: Spiritual Equality

The most fundamental principle in Islam is the absolute spiritual equality of men and women before God. Salvation is contingent on faith and righteous deeds, not gender.

Allah, the Almighty, says:

"O mankind, be afraid of your Lord, who created you from one soul and created from it its mate and dispersed from both of them many men and women." (An-Nisaa 4:1).

And says:

"Indeed, and the men who remember Allah often and the women who do so - for them Allah has prepared forgiveness and a great reward." (Al-Ahzab 33:35).

This verse explicitly addresses both men and women in parallel for various acts of virtue.

Allah also says:

"Whoever does righteousness, whether male or female, while he is a believer - We will surely cause him to live a good life, and We will surely give them their reward [in the Hereafter] according to the best of what they used to do." (An-Nahl 16:97).

· Prophet Muhammad ﷺ said:

"Women are the twin halves of men." (Abu Dawood).

This hadith emphasizes their complementary and equal nature in humanity.

2: Social and Educational Rights

Islam grants women the right to education, expression, and participation in social life. Quran repeatedly addresses both *"believing men and believing women,"* giving them direct instruction and acknowledging their agency within the community.

Prophet ﷺ said:

"Seeking knowledge is obligatory upon every Muslim." (Sunan Ibn Majah).

Women during the Prophet's time were active participants of social activities. They prayed in the mosque, asked questions directly to the Prophet ﷺ, gave him allegiance (Bay'ah), and even participated in battles as nurses and water-bearers. A specific example is a woman who complained to the Prophet ﷺ about her husband, and he accepted her complaint and addressed it publicly.

Ayesha bint Abi Bakr, the wife of the Prophet ﷺ, is one of the most important figures in Islamic history. After the Prophet's death, she became a leading scholar and jurist. Men and women alike would come to her to learn about Islam, Hadith, medicine, and poetry. She transmitted over 2,000 hadiths.

3: Economic Rights

In a revolutionary move, Islam gave women independent economic identity, rights that women in the West did not gain until centuries later.

Allah says about the right of inheritance:

"For men is a share of what the parents and close relatives leave, and for women is a share of what the parents and close relatives leave, be it little or much - an obligatory share." (An-Nisaa 4:7).

Allah, the Almighty, says

"And give the women (upon marriage) their (bridal) gifts graciously. But if they give up willingly to you anything of it, then take it in satisfaction and ease." (An-Nisaa 4:4).

The Ayah reveals that a woman's wealth is hers alone. The dowry (Mahr) is a right of the wife, not her guardian.

There is no prohibition on women working, provided the work is permissible if the Islamic guidelines of modesty and veil are maintained. The Quran mentions the shepherding of the daughters of Prophet Shu'ayb (AS) as an example (Al-Qasas 28:23).

Khadijah (RA), the first wife of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, was a highly successful and wealthy merchant. He worked for her before their marriage, and she proposed to him. She remained a powerful businesswoman and his most staunch supporter.

Many other women in the time of the Prophet ﷺ worked in various fields, including medicine, handicrafts, and agriculture.

4: Familial Roles: Rights and Responsibilities

The family is the cornerstone of Islamic society, and women are accorded a position of honour and respect within it.

Allah, the Most Glorified, says about mothers:

"And your Lord has decreed that you not worship except Him, and to parents, good treatment. Whether one or both of them reach old age [while] with you, say not to them Uff, and do not repel them but speak to them a noble word." (Bani-Isra'il 17:23).

The Prophet ﷺ emphasized the mother's right three times over the father's.

Allah says:

"And live with them (women) in kindness." (An-Nisaa 4:19).

Marriage is a solemn covenant, not a sacrament where the woman loses her identity.

The Prophet ﷺ said:

"The best of you are those who are best to their wives, and I am the best of you to my wives." (Tirmidhi).

He ﷺ also said:

"The world is but an enjoyment (quick passing); and the best enjoyment of the world is a pious wife." (Muslim).

5: Modesty and Protection

The Islamic guidelines on modesty (Hijab) and gender interaction are often misunderstood. Their primary purpose in Islamic jurisprudence is to create a respectful, safe, and dignified social environment where women are valued for their intellect and character rather than their physical appearance.

Allah, the All Knowing, says:

"And tell the believing women that they must lower their gazes and guard their private parts, and must not expose their adornment, except that which appears thereof, and must wrap their bosoms with their shawls, and must not expose their adornment, except to their husbands or their fathers or the fathers of their husbands, or to their sons or the sons of their husbands, or to their brothers or the sons of their brothers or the sons of their sisters, or to their women, or to those owned by their right hands, or male attendants having no (sexual) urge, or to the children who are not yet conscious of the shames of women. And let them not stamp their feet in a way that the adornment they conceal is known. And repent to Allah O believers, all of you, so that you may achieve success. (An-Nur 24:31)

Allah, the All Knowing, also says:

"O Prophet, tell your wives and your daughters and the women of the believers to draw down their shawls over themselves. That is more suitable that they will be known and not be abused." (Al-Ahzab 33:59).

These verses link modesty in dress with protection and recognition of one's dignity.

Important Note:

Islam views men and women as equal in worth and spirituality, but often assigns different primary responsibilities based on general physiological and psychological dispositions. For instance, men are given the primary financial responsibility for the family (An-Nisaa 4:34), while women are honoured with the primary role of childbearing and nurturing. This is seen as a complementary division of labour, not a statement of superiority.

While the divine texts establish these rights, the actual social status of women in Muslim-majority societies has varied greatly throughout history and is often influenced by local cultures, traditions, and patriarchal interpretations that may contradict the core teachings of Islam.

In conclusion, the role of women in an ideal Islamic society, as derived from the Quran and Sunnah, is one of the spiritual equality with men, social agency with rights to education, expression, and consultation, economic independence with rights to own, inherit, and manage property, familial honour as daughters, wives, and especially mothers.

The primary sources of Islam laid down a framework that sought to elevate and protect women, granting them a dignified and vital role in building a righteous society.

Neighbours and Community:

The rights of neighbours and the responsibilities towards the community are profoundly emphasized in Islam, considered a fundamental aspect of faith (Iman) itself. The Quran and Hadith provide extensive guidance on this matter, elevating good neighbourly conduct to an act of worship.

Here is a detailed explanation of the rights of neighbours and the community in the light of the Quran and Hadith.

Foundation in the Quran

The Quran does not relegate neighbourly rights to a minor issue; it couples it with the worship of Allah.

Allah, the Almighty, says;

"Worship Allah and associate nothing with Him, and to parents do good, and to relatives, orphans, the needy, the near neighbour, the neighbour farther away, the companion at your side, the traveller, and those whom your right hands possess. Indeed, Allah does not like those who are self-deluding and boastful." (An-Nisaa 4:36)

This verse is crucial because it places kindness to neighbours immediately after the command to worship Allah alone and be good to parents.

It distinguishes between two types of neighbours: the "near neighbour" (which can mean one who is both a relative and a neighbour, or simply the closest physically) and the "neighbour farther away" (other neighbours in the community). This implies that the circle of neighbourly rights is expansive, not limited to those immediately next door.

Good treatment of neighbours is a mark of true faith and righteousness, as mentioned in Surah Al-Baqarah in the description of the pious:

Allah Says:

"But righteousness is [in] one who believes in Allah, the Last Day, the angels, the Book, and the prophets and gives wealth, in spite of love for it, to relatives, orphans, the needy, the traveller, those who ask [for help], and for freeing slaves..." (Al-Baqarah 2:177)

While not explicitly mentioning "neighbour," the categories of "the needy" and "those who ask for help" inherently include those in one's immediate community.

Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) elaborated:

"The best companion in the sight of Allah is the one who is best to his companion, and the best neighbour in the sight of Allah is the one who is best to his neighbour." (Tirmidhi)

He also said:

"By Allah, he is not a believer! By Allah, he is not a believer! By Allah, he is not a believer!" It was asked, "Who, O Messenger of Allah?" He said, "The one whose neighbour does not feel safe from his evil." (Bukhari)

This hadith stresses that harming a neighbour can cast doubt on the very core of a person's faith.

The Prophet (ﷺ) was asked about the extent of a neighbour's rights. He indicated that it includes a large area.

The Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"The rights of a neighbour extend to forty houses." (Musnad Ahmad)

This shows that the Islamic concept of "community" is very broad, encompassing a significant number of households.

Specific Rights and Responsibilities:

The Hadith provides a practical list of what good neighbourliness entails. It is not merely about avoiding harm, but actively doing good as well.

- 1- Physical Harm: The most severely condemned act is causing physical or emotional harm.
- 2- Financial Support: If your neighbour is hungry, you have a duty to feed them. Prophet (ﷺ) said:
"He is not a believer who eats his fill while his neighbour is hungry." (Sahih Ibn Hibban)
- 3- Sharing Gifts: The Prophet (ﷺ) advised his followers to share their cooking pots with their neighbours. He (ﷺ) said:
"O Muslim women! No one should disdain her neighbour's gift, even if it is only a sheep's trotter." (Bukhari)
- 4- Patience with Annoyance: A true good neighbour is one who bears minor annoyances with patience. The Prophet (ﷺ) said that a person will be among the best of people on the Day of Judgment if they possess three qualities, one of which is *"to give gifts to your neighbour even if they cause you harm."*
- 5- Guarding Their Privacy and Honora: This includes not building structures that overlook their private spaces, not gossiping about them, and protecting their honour.

Rights of the Community (Ummah):

The concept of neighbour extends to the broader Muslim community and humanity in general. This is based on the principle of brotherhood/sisterhood (Ukhuwah).

- 1- Brotherhood in Faith: The Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"The parable of the believers in their affection, mercy, and compassion for each other is that of a body. When one limb aches, the whole body reacts with sleeplessness and fever." (Bukhari)

This means the community has a collective responsibility. The hardship of one is the concern of all.

- 2- Enjoining Good and Forbidding Evil:

A key community right and responsibility is to encourage good deeds and forbid wrongdoing in a wise and compassionate manner.

"Let there be among you a group who call to good, enjoin what is right, and forbid what is wrong; it is they who will be successful." (Aali-Imran 3:104)

- 3- Social Support:

The community must establish systems of support (like Zakat and Sadaqah) to ensure that the basic needs of all its members are met, preventing poverty and destitution.

Summary of Key Rights

Based on the Quran and Hadith, the rights of a neighbour and the community can be summarized as follows:

1. The Right to Safety and Security: Your neighbour must feel safe from your words and actions.
2. The Right to Physical Well-being: You must not harm them and should help them if they are in need.
3. The Right to Financial Support: If you have means and they are in need, you are obliged to help.
4. The Right to Privacy and honour: You must respect their privacy and protect their honour.

5. The Right to Kindness and Companionship: Be polite, cheerful, and maintain good relations.
6. The Right to Patience and Forgiveness: Bear minor inconveniences with patience and be quick to forgive.
7. The Right to a Healthy Environment: Do not cause pollution, nuisance, or block their access to light and air.

Caring for the poor, orphans, and the needy

Caring for the poor, orphans, and the needy is a central and repeated commandment in Islam, deeply embedded in both the Quran and the Hadith. It is not just a recommended act of charity but a fundamental pillar of faith and a measure of true righteousness. Here is a detailed explanation based on the Quran and Hadith, categorized for clarity.

Instructions from the Quran

The Quran is replete with verses emphasizing the obligation and importance of caring for the vulnerable.

1: A Core Component of Righteousness

True belief is not just about rituals but is demonstrated through action, especially caring for others.

Allah Says:

"Righteousness is not that you turn your faces toward the east or the west, but (true) righteousness is (in) one who believes in Allah, the Last Day, the angels, the Book, and the prophets and gives wealth, in spite of love for it, to relatives, orphans, the needy, the traveller, those who ask [for help], and for freeing slaves..." (Al-Baqarah 2:177)

This verse defines a righteous person primarily by their belief and their financial commitment to these specified groups.

2: Specific Commandments Regarding Orphans

The Quran gives special attention to orphans, urging kindness, justice, and protection of their wealth.

Allah, the Almighty, says:

"Therefore, do not oppress the orphan." (Ad-Duha 93:9)

He also says:

"Have you seen the one who denies the Recompense? For that is the one who drives away the orphan." (Al-Ma'un 107:1-3)

He further says:

"And give to the orphans their properties, and do not substitute the defective [of your own] for the good [of theirs]. And do not consume their properties into your own. Indeed, that is ever a great sin." (An-Nisa 4:2)

3: Spending on the Needy as a Test of Faith

Wealth is seen as a test from God. Spending in His way is a sign of success and gratitude.

Allah says:

"Never will you attain the good [reward] until you spend [in the way of Allah] from that which you love. And whatever you spend - indeed, Allah is Knowing of it." (Aali-Imran 3:92)

He also says:

"O you who have believed, spend from the good things which you have earned and from that which We have produced for you from the earth. And do not aim toward the defective therefrom, spending [from that] while you would not take it [yourself] except with closed eyes..." (Al-Baqarah 2:267)

4: A Right of the Poor in One's Wealth

Islamic teachings establish that the poor and needy have a recognized right (Haqq) in the wealth of the rich.

Allah says:

"And in their wealth was a right for the petitioner and the deprived." (Adh-Dhariyat 51:19)

He also says:

"And those within whose wealth is a known right. For the petitioner and the deprived." (Al-Ma'arij 70:24-25)

Instructions from the Hadith

The Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) embodied the Quran's teachings, and his sayings and actions provide a practical guide.

1: Severe Warnings Against Neglecting the Needy

The Prophet (ﷺ) issued strong warnings about the consequences of ignoring the plight of the poor.

Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"The person who eats and drinks while his neighbor goes hungry is not a believer." (Bukhari)

He (ﷺ) also said:

"He is not a believer whose stomach is filled while his neighbour goes hungry." (Muslim)

2: The Virtue of Caring for Orphans

The Prophet (ﷺ), who was an orphan himself, promised immense reward for those who care for orphans.

He (ﷺ) Said:

"I and the caretaker of the orphan will be in Paradise like this," and he held his two fingers together (index and middle finger). (Bukhari and Muslim)

3: Charity as a Means of Purification and Increase

Charity is not seen as decreasing wealth but as purifying it and increasing its Barakah (blessing).

Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"Charity does not decrease wealth."(Muslim)

He (ﷺ) also said:

"Wealth never decreases because of Sadaqah (charity)."

4: Even Small Acts of Kindness Count

The emphasis is on sincerity and consistency, not always on the amount.

Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"Protect yourself from the Hellfire, even with half a date [in charity]."(Muslim)

Practical Forms of Care in Islam

The Islamic system provides both individual and communal obligations to address poverty and need.

1: Zakat (Obligatory Alms):

This is one of the Five Pillars of Islam. It is a mandatory 2.5% annual wealth tax on savings, which is distributed to eight categories of people, with the poor (Fuqara), needy (Masakeen), and those employed to administer Zakat being the primary recipients (At-Tauba 9:60).

2: Sadaqah (Voluntary Charity):

This includes any voluntary spending, money, or acts of kindness. Smiling, removing a harmful object from the road, and speaking a good word are all considered Sadaqah.

3: Sadaqah Jariyah (Continuous Charity):

This is an act that continues to benefit people and earn reward for the giver even after their death, such as building a well, a school, or sponsoring a student's education.

4: Kafalah (Sponsoring Orphans):

This involves taking responsibility for an orphan's financial, educational, and emotional well-being without absorbing them into the family lineage (unless adopted under specific Islamic guidelines).

5: Fulfilling Neighbours' Needs:

The rights of a neighbour are so emphasized in Islam that it was almost made an inheritable right.

Rights of Minorities in Islamic Society

The teachings of the Quran and Hadith regarding minorities in an Islamic state are rich, complex, and have been interpreted in various ways throughout history. The foundational principle is one of protected status and tolerance, with specific rights and responsibilities outlined.

Here is a breakdown of the key teachings, starting with the core principles and then moving to specific rulings.

1: Foundational Principles: Justice and Coexistence

The primary framework for dealing with minorities is based on two overarching Quranic principles:

I: "There is no compulsion in religion." (Al-Baqarah 2:256)

This is perhaps the most important verse on the subject. It establishes that force cannot be used to compel people to accept Islam. This implies a fundamental right to religious freedom for non-Muslims living under Muslim rule.

II: Mandate of Justice:

The Quran repeatedly commands Muslims to be just, even towards those they may dislike.

Allah says:

"O you who have believed, be persistently standing firm for Allah, witnesses in justice, and do not let the hatred of a people prevent you from being just. Be just; that is nearer to righteousness." (Al-Maa'idah 5:8)

Allah also says:

"Indeed, Allah commands you to render trusts to whom they are due and when you judge between people to judge with justice." (An-Nisa 4:58)

This command of justice is universal and not limited to Muslims.

2: The Covenant of Protection: Ahl-uz-Zimmah

Non-Muslims who permanently reside in an Islamic state and accept its political authority are given a special status known as Ahl al-Dhimmah (People of the Covenant or Protected People), often simply called Dhimmis. This is a contract between the state and its non-Muslim citizens, granting them protection in exchange for loyalty and a specific tax.

A. Rights and Protections for Minorities

According to Islamic law, the state is obligated to protect the lives, property, and religious rights of Zimmis.

I: Right to Life and Security:

Their lives are considered sacred, just like those of Muslims. The Prophet Muhammad said:

Prophet ﷺ said:

"Whoever kills a non-Muslim citizen (Mu'ahid) will not smell the fragrance of Paradise." (Sahih al-Bukhari)

This is a very strong warning against harming a Dhimmi.

II: Right to Practice Their Religion:

They are allowed to practice their faith freely, including in their own houses of worship. They can follow their own family laws (marriage, divorce, inheritance) in their own religious courts. There are historical examples of churches and synagogues being built and maintained under Islamic rule.

III: Right to Property and Commerce:

They can own property, businesses, and engage in trade. Their wealth is protected, except for the specific tax they pay.

- IV: Community Autonomy: They are generally allowed to manage their own internal community affairs through their religious leaders.

B. Responsibilities and the Jizya Tax

The most discussed aspect of the Zimmi system is the Jizya tax.

What is it? The Jizya is a per-capita, yearly poll tax imposed on able-bodied, free, non-Muslim men of military age.

Purpose: Its primary purpose was twofold:

- I: Symbol of Political Submission: It was a symbol of their acceptance of the political authority of the Islamic state, which in turn guaranteed their protection.
- II: Exemption from Military Service: Since Dhimmis were exempt from compulsory military service (which was obligatory for Muslim citizens), the Jizya was seen as a financial contribution to the state's defence, which protected them.

Conditions: Islamic law sets conditions for the Jizya:

it must be collected without oppression, and the amount should be within the taxpayer's means. The caliph Umar ibn al-Khattab was known for his justice in this matter, considering a person's ability to pay. The Quran mentions the Jizya in the context of warfare, but it was institutionalized as a permanent feature of the state in peacetime:

Allah, the Exalted, says:

"Fight those who do not believe in Allah or in the Last Day and who do not consider unlawful what Allah and His Messenger have made unlawful and who do not adopt the religion of truth from those who were given the Scripture, (fight) until they give the Jizya willingly while they are humbled." (At-Tauba 9:29)

Role of State in Social Welfare

This is a complex and critical topic. It is essential to state at the outset that the group known as the Islamic State (IS, ISIS, or Daesh) is designated as a terrorist

organization by the United Nations and the vast majority of the world's governments and Muslim-majority countries. Its actions are considered by mainstream Islamic scholarship to be a gross distortion of Islamic principles.

Therefore, we must analyse this topic in two parts:

- 1- The Islamic State's claimed role in social welfare, based on its own propaganda.
- 2- The assessment of these claims against the Quran and Hadith, as understood by mainstream Islamic scholarship.

Part 1: The Islamic State's Claimed Role in Social Welfare

During its peak territorial control (2014-2017), ISIS established a proto-state structure it called a "Caliphate." As part of governing this territory, it attempted to provide basic social services to win the loyalty, or at least the acquiescence, of the local population. Their propaganda highlighted these activities to portray themselves as a legitimate governing authority.

Their claimed social welfare functions included:

- 1- Provision of Basic Utilities: Managing water, electricity, and bread supplies.
- 2- Price Controls: Fixing the prices of essential goods to prevent inflation and profiteering.
- 3- Islamic Courts: Establishing courts to resolve civil disputes (based on their extreme interpretation of Sharia).
- 4- Zakat Collection and Distribution: Positioning themselves as the authority to collect and distribute Zakat (obligatory alms), claiming to give it to the eight categories mentioned in the Quran.
- 5- Healthcare: Running hospitals and clinics, though often poorly equipped and staffed by coerced personnel.

Part 2: Assessment with Reference to Quran and Hadith

Mainstream Islamic scholars and institutions argue that ISIS's actions fundamentally violate the core principles of social welfare in Islam, making their entire project illegitimate and their welfare activities a form of coercion and propaganda.

Here is an analysis using the Quran and Hadith:

1- The Primacy of Justice and Mercy (Adl and Rahma)

The foundational principles of Islamic governance are justice (Adl) and mercy (Rahma).

Allah says:

"Indeed, Allah commands justice, good conduct, and giving to relatives and forbids immorality, bad conduct, and oppression. He admonishes you that perhaps you will be reminded." (An-Nahl 16:90)

Prophet ﷺ said:

"The merciful will be shown mercy by the Most Merciful. Be merciful to those on the earth, and the One above the heavens will have mercy upon you." (Tirmidhi)

2- The Purpose of Zakat: Welfare, Not Warfare

The Quran specifies eight categories of people eligible to receive Zakat (Quran 9:60), which include the poor, the needy, and those whose hearts are to be reconciled. The primary goal is social upliftment and compassion.

Allah says:

"Zakat expenditures are only for the poor and for the needy and for those employed to collect [Zakat] and for bringing hearts together [for Islam] and for freeing captives [or slaves] and for those in debt and for the cause of Allah and for the [stranded] traveller - an obligation [imposed] by Allah. And Allah is Knowing and Wise." (At-Tauba 9:60)

3- Prohibition of Coercion and Spreading Corruption

Islam strictly forbids compulsion in religion and condemns those who spread mischief and corruption on earth.

Allah says:

"There shall be no compulsion in [acceptance of] the religion."

(Al-Baqarah 2:256)

Allah also says:

"And do not kill the soul which Allah has forbidden (to be killed) except by (legal) right. This has He instructed you that you may use reason." (Al-An'aam 6:151)

Allah further says:

"And do not commit abuse on the earth, spreading corruption."

(Al-Baqarah 2:60)

4- The Concept of Maslaha (Public Interest)

A key principle in Islamic law is Maslaha, which means acting in the public interest and avoiding harm. The primary objectives of Sharia (Maqasid al-Sharia) are to protect life, religion, intellect, lineage, and property.

Conclusion:

While the Islamic State claimed to establish an Islamic social welfare system, its actions were overwhelmingly in direct opposition to the core values of the Quran and Hadith.

Ethical system of Islam

Moral Teachings in Surah Al-Hujurat: A Comprehensive Guide

Surah Al-Hujurat (The Chapter of the Rooms), the 49th chapter of the Qur'an, offers profound moral teachings aimed at guiding individuals and communities in their interactions with one another. The Surah emphasizes the importance of respect, unity, justice, and moral integrity, offering timeless lessons on social ethics and spirituality. Below, we delve into the key morals mentioned in this Surah, drawing connections with the relevant verses and additional Ahadith to highlight their significance.

3. 1. Respect for Allah and His Messenger ((a))

Verse(s): "O you who have believed, do not raise your voices above the voice of the Prophet or be loud to him in speech, like the loudness of some of you to others, lest your deeds become worthless while you do not perceive." (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:1)

This verse underscores the need to show the utmost respect to the Prophet Muhammad (a), particularly when addressing him. It teaches that our actions and words should reflect our reverence for the Prophet and his role as the final messenger. The significance of this moral is further emphasized in an authentic Hadith, where the Prophet (a) said:

"Whoever shows disrespect to me, it is as though he has shown disrespect to Allah." (Sahih Muslim, Hadith 106)

Another Hadith highlights the importance of humility in the presence of the Prophet (a):

"Do not turn your backs on me, and do not raise your voices above my voice." (Sunan Abu Dawood, Hadith 4852)

This teaches that the respect for the Prophet (a) is a reflection of one's respect for Allah, and any form of arrogance or disrespect will lead to the loss of rewards.

4. 2. Verification before Acting on News

Verse(s): "O you who have believed, if there comes to you a disobedient person with news, investigate, lest you harm a people out of ignorance and become regretful for what you have done." (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:6)

This verse stresses the importance of verifying information before acting on it, particularly when it comes from unreliable sources. In an era where rumors and false information spread quickly, this teaching is of paramount importance. The Prophet (a) also emphasized this point in his Hadith:

"It is enough for a person to be a liar if he narrates everything he hears." (Sahih Muslim, Hadith 5)

Another Hadith further elaborates on the importance of verifying news before believing or sharing it:

"When you hear something, verify it before passing it on. The one who spreads news is like the one who fabricates it." (Sunan Abu Dawood, Hadith 4975)

This highlights the ethical responsibility to seek the truth and not rush into judgment, ensuring that our actions are based on verified facts.

5. 3. Promoting Peace and Justice

Verse(s): "And if two factions among the believers fall into fighting, then make peace between them. But if one of them wrongs the other, then fight against the one that wrongs until it returns to the command of Allah." (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:9)

Surah Al-Hujurat encourages believers to act as mediators and peacemakers when conflict arises. The obligation to bring justice and reconciliation within the Muslim community is emphasized here. The Prophet (a) said:

"Shall I not tell you something that is better than fasting, prayer, and charity? It is bringing peace between people." (Sunan Abu Dawood, Hadith 4919)

The Prophet (a) further emphasized the value of reconciling between believers:

"He who makes peace between people by advising them and bringing them together is not a liar." (Sahih Bukhari, Hadith 2497)

This reflects the significance of peace-building, showing that restoring harmony is among the highest acts of righteousness in Islam.

6. 4. Brotherhood and Unity among Believers

Verse(s): "The believers are but brothers, so make peace between your brothers and fear Allah that you may receive mercy." (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:10)

The Qur'an consistently highlights the idea of brotherhood among Muslims. This verse establishes the idea that all Muslims are part of one collective family, united by faith. The Prophet (a) reaffirmed this concept:

"None of you truly believes until he loves for his brother what he loves for himself." (Sahih Bukhari, Hadith 13 and Sahih Muslim, Hadith 2569)

Another Hadith reinforces the significance of unity:

"A Muslim is the brother of a Muslim. He does not wrong him, nor does he let him down. He does not lie to him, nor does he disregard him." (Sahih Muslim, Hadith 2564)

This profound teaching emphasizes the unity of the Muslim community and the importance of mutual care and respect. It urges us to act in ways that foster brotherhood, including resolving differences and working toward collective well-being.

7. 5. Avoiding Mockery, Insults, and Nicknaming

Verse(s): "O you who have believed, let not a people ridicule [another] people; perhaps they may be better than them... And do not insult one another or call each other by [offensive] nicknames." (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:11)

This verse addresses the harmful effects of mockery and insults. It highlights that ridiculing others is forbidden and that such actions are a means of sowing division. The Prophet (a) also warned against mocking others, saying:

"A believer is not one who mocks, curses, or speaks obscenely." (Sunan Ibn Majah, Hadith 3971)

Another Hadith emphasizes the importance of showing respect:

"It is forbidden for a Muslim to mock or insult another Muslim." (Sunan Abu Dawood, Hadith 4878)

This teaches that dignity should be preserved for every individual, and respect should be shown to all, regardless of their status or background.

8. 6. Avoiding Suspicion, Spying, and Backbiting

Verse(s): "And do not spy or backbite each other. Would one of you like to eat the flesh of his brother when dead? You would detest it..." (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:12)

Backbiting and spying on others are prohibited in Islam because they create distrust and division. The metaphor of eating the flesh of a dead brother is a powerful warning against these behaviors. The Prophet (a) elaborated on this by saying:

"Do you know what backbiting is?" They [the companions] replied, "Allah and His Messenger know best." He said, "It is to mention about your brother that which he dislikes." (Sahih Muslim, Hadith 2589)

Another Hadith further warns against the dangers of backbiting:

"Backbiting is worse than adultery. If someone commits adultery and repents, Allah will forgive him, but the one who backbites will not be forgiven until the one who is wronged forgives him." (Sahih Bukhari, Hadith 6056)

This hadith emphasizes the severity of backbiting and highlights its destructive impact on relationships.

9. 7. Equality and Superiority by Piety Only

Verse(s): “O mankind, indeed We have created you from male and female and made you peoples and tribes that you may know one another. Indeed, the most noble of you in the sight of Allah is the most righteous of you.” (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:13)

This verse emphasizes that no one has superiority over another based on race, ethnicity, or social status, except by their piety. The Prophet (a) echoed this teaching:

"All of you are equal; no one has superiority over another except by piety." (Sunan Ibn Majah, Hadith 4133)

Hazrat Bilal ibn Rabah (RA), was a former slave, yet he was among the closest to the Prophet (a), proving that true dignity comes from faith and righteousness, not worldly status.

10. 8. Faith, Obedience, and Humility

Verse(s): “Say, 'Obey Allah and obey the Messenger, and do not dispute among yourselves, lest you lose courage and your power departs.'” (Surah Al-Hujurat, 49:14)

Belief in Allah and His Messenger (a) requires humility and obedience. Disputing within the community weakens it, and humility is central to the success of any group. The Prophet (a) said:

"No one who has an atom's weight of pride in his heart will enter Paradise." (Sahih Muslim, Hadith 91)

The Prophet (a) also demonstrated this quality of humility in his dealings with his companions, showing that even those with the highest status in Islam must remain humble.

Conclusion

Surah Al-Hujurat offers a profound moral and ethical framework for Muslims, urging them to embody respect, integrity, and unity. Each teaching is a reminder of the moral and ethical responsibilities that individuals have within the community and toward one another. Upholding these principles is not only a means of fostering a harmonious society but also a way to earn the pleasure of Allah. Through these divine teachings, the Qur'an lays down the foundation for a society rooted in mutual respect, trust, and righteousness.

By adhering to these moral principles, the Muslim community can grow in both spiritual and social strength. The Prophet (a)'s guidance, reinforced by these verses and Ahadith, continues to serve as a timeless model for how Muslims should live and interact with others.

Factors lead to decline of the Morals

Several factors contribute to the decline of moral values in society. While it's important to note that these reasons can vary across different cultures and regions, some common factors include:

11. Technology and Media Influence:

The rapid expansion of technology and media exposure can contribute to a decline in moral values, as individuals may be influenced by negative portrayals, unrealistic standards, or desensitization to ethical concerns.

12. Breakdown of Family Structure:

Changes in family dynamics, including an increase in single-parent households or weakened family bonds, can impact the transmission of moral values from one generation to the next.

13. Educational System Challenges:

Educational systems sometimes focus more on academic achievements than on moral and character development. Lack of emphasis on ethics in schools can contribute to the erosion of moral values.

14. Individualism and Consumerism:

Societal emphasis on individual success and materialism can lead to a decline in collective moral responsibility. A focus on personal gain may overshadow the importance of ethical considerations.

15. Religious Decline:

In societies where religious influence diminishes, there may be a corresponding decline in adherence to moral values traditionally associated with religious teachings.

16. Globalization:

While globalization brings cultural exchange and economic growth, it can also introduce conflicting values and cultural relativism, potentially diluting or challenging established moral norms.

17. Social and Economic Inequality:

Widespread disparities in wealth and opportunities can lead to a sense of injustice and diminish the belief in the fairness of societal structures, impacting adherence to moral values.

18. Social media and Online Culture:

The anonymous nature of online interactions and the rapid spread of information through social media can contribute to cyberbullying, misinformation, and a general coarsening of discourse, impacting moral values.

Addressing the decline in moral values often requires a multifaceted approach involving education, community engagement, and efforts to strengthen familial and institutional foundations that promote ethical behavior.

The Political System of Islam

The Islamic political system is not merely a structure of governance but a comprehensive framework derived from divine revelation. Its core principles are designed to establish justice, uphold human dignity, and facilitate a society that lives in accordance with God's will.

Here is a detailed explanation of the key points with references from the Quran and Hadith.

1: Sovereignty Belongs to Allah (حَاكِمِيَّةِ اَعْلٰی)

This is the foundational principle of the Islamic political system. Ultimate authority, the right to legislate, and the source of all laws reside solely with Allah. Human beings, including rulers and states, are not sovereign; they are subject to and executors of divine law.

Allah says:

"Say, 'Indeed, I am on clear proof from my Lord, and you have denied it. I do not have that for which you are impatient. The decision is only for Allah. He relates the truth, and He is the best of deciders.'" (Al-An'aam 6:57)

Allah also says:

"Legislation is not but for Allah. He has commanded that you worship not except Him. That is the correct religion, but most of the people do not know." (Surah Yusuf 12:40)

This verse explicitly uses the term "Al-Hukm" (judgment, command, legislation), establishing that the right to make laws is a divine attribute.

Allah further says:

"And whoever does not judge by what Allah has revealed - then it is those who are the disbelievers." (Al-Ma'idah 5:44)

This strong statement highlights the gravity of replacing divine law with man-made systems.

While the concept is primarily Quranic, the entire practice of the Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) was a living embodiment of this principle. He did not rule by his own personal opinion but by the revelation he received.

2: Vicegerency of Human Beings on Earth (Khilafah)

While sovereignty belongs to Allah, He has honoured humanity by appointing them as His Khalifah (vicegerent or trustee) on earth. This means that authority is a sacred trust (Amanah) bestowed upon humans to manage the affairs of the world according to Allah's commandments. This concept establishes that no individual, family, or class has an inherent, divine right to rule; leadership is a responsibility, not a privilege.

Allah says:

"And (mention, O Muhammad), when your Lord said to the angels, 'Indeed, I will make upon the earth a successive authority (Khalifah).' (Al-Baqarah 2:30)

This verse establishes the very concept of humanity's vicegerency.

Allah also says:

"And it is He who has made you successors (Khala'if) upon the earth and has raised some of you above others in degrees (of rank) to test you through what He has given you." (Al-An'aam 6:165)

Allah further says:

"O David, indeed We have made you a successor (Khalifah) upon the earth, so judge between the people in truth and do not follow (your own) desire, as it will lead you astray from the way of Allah." (Surah Saad 38:26)

This verse was revealed about Prophet David and it directly links the position of Khilafah to the obligation of ruling with justice and truth.

The Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"Every one of you is a shepherd and is responsible for his flock. The leader of the people is a shepherd and is responsible for his subjects..." (Bukhari)

This hadith universalizes the concept of responsibility and trusteeship, from a head of state to a parent in a family.

3: Shura (Mutual Consultation)

Islam mandates the process of Shura (consultation) in managing public affairs. It is a mechanism for collective reasoning and seeking counsel from knowledgeable and representative people. This ensures that decisions are not autocratic but are considered and reflective of the community's welfare, within the boundaries of Shari'ah.

Allah says:

"And those who have responded to their lord and established prayer and whose affair is [determined by] consultation among themselves, and from what We have provided them, they spend." (Ash-Shura 42:38)

This verse praises the believers for making consultation a characteristic of their collective life.

Allah also says:

"So by mercy from Allah, (O Muhammad), you were lenient with them. And if you had been rude (in speech) and harsh in heart, they would have disbanded from about you. So pardon them and ask forgiveness for them and consult them in the matter. And when

you have decided, then rely upon Allah. Indeed, Allah loves those who rely (upon Him)." (Aali-Imran 3:159)

This verse, addressed to the Prophet himself, establishes the importance of consultation even for the highest authority.

According to Hadith, the Prophet (ﷺ) consistently consulted his companions on matters of strategy and public interest, such as at the Battle of Uhud and the Battle of the Trench. While the revelation was the final authority, the process of consultation was vital.

4: Rule of Law Based on Shari'ah

In an Islamic system, everyone, from the common citizen to the head of state, is subject to the same law—the Shari'ah. There is no one above the law. This establishes justice, equality, and protects the rights of all individuals.

Allah says:

"Indeed, Allah commands you to render trusts to whom they are due and when you judge between people to judge with justice..." (An-Nisa 4:58)

This verse establishes the core principles of justice and fulfilling trusts, which are the essence of the rule of law.

Allah also says:

"O you who have believed, be persistently standing firm for Allah, witnesses in justice, and do not let the hatred of a people prevent you from being just. Be just; that is nearer to righteousness..." (Al-Ma'idah 5:8)

According to hadith Reference; The most famous example is the following incident:

A woman from the powerful tribe of Makhzum committed theft. People interceded, asking Usama bin Zayd to plead with the Prophet (ﷺ) to pardon her. The Prophet (ﷺ) stood up and delivered a sermon, saying:

"The people before you were destroyed because when a noble among them stole, they would let him go, but when a weak person among them stole, they would execute the law upon him. By Allah, if Fatimah, the daughter of Muhammad, were to steal, I would cut off her hand." (Bukhari, Muslim).

This is a paramount example of the rule of law being applied equally to all, regardless of social status.

5: Accountability before Allah and People

Every individual in a position of responsibility is accountable, both to the people they serve and, ultimately, to Allah on the Day of Judgment. This dual accountability is a powerful check against the abuse of power.

Allah says:

"To Allah belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on the earth. Whether you show what is within yourselves or conceal it, Allah will bring you to account for it..." (Al-Baqarah 2:284)

The concept of final accountability before Allah is a recurring theme, such as in Surah Az-Zilzal 99:7-8):

"So whoever does an atom's weight of good will see it. And whoever does an atom's weight of evil will see it."

The previously mentioned hadith, "Every one of you is a shepherd and is responsible for his flock..." (Bukhari), explicitly establishes the concept of accountability for those in charge.

The Prophet (ﷺ) also said:

"A ruler who, having control over the affairs of the Muslims, does not strive diligently for their betterment and does not serve them sincerely, will not enter Paradise with them." (Sahih Muslim)

This makes the ruler's sincere service a condition for his own salvation.

He (ﷺ) also said:

"The most beloved person to Allah on the Day of Resurrection and the closest to Him in position is a just leader, and the most hated person to Allah and the farthest from Him is a tyrannical leader." (Tirmizi)

Conclusion

The Islamic political system is a holistic model where:

- Allah's Sovereignty provides the ultimate source of law.
- Human Vicegerency confers the responsibility of governance.
- Shura provides the methodology for decision-making.
- The Rule of Shari'ah ensures justice and equality.
- Accountability acts as the ultimate safeguard against tyranny and corruption.

These principles are interlinked, creating a system whose primary goal is to establish a just and righteous society that fulfils its purpose of worshipping and obeying Allah.

Islamic State, Concept and Objectives

The concept of an "Islamic State" is rooted in the idea of implementing divine sovereignty (حاکمیت) and governing human affairs according to the principles revealed by God (Allah). It is not merely a political entity but a comprehensive system aimed at fostering a society that facilitates the worship of God and upholds justice, welfare, and moral excellence.

1: Definition and Core Characteristics

An Islamic State can be defined as a community-based political entity that derives its sovereignty, constitution, and primary legislation from the divine revelation of the Quran and the Prophetic tradition (Sunnah). Its ultimate goal is to create conditions where Muslims and non-Muslims can live in accordance with divine will.

Core Characteristics:

Sovereignty of God (Hakimiyyah):

The fundamental principle is that ultimate sovereignty and the right to legislate belong to Allah alone.

Allah says:

"The command is for none but Allah. He has commanded that you worship none but Him; that is the straight religion." (Surah Yousuf 12:40)

Allah also says:

"And He shares not His command with anyone." (Al-Kahf 18:26)

This means that no human assembly or individual has the absolute right to make laws that contravene divine guidance.

Governance by Shura (Consultation):

While sovereignty belongs to God, the administration of the state is conducted through consultation, reflecting a form of Islamic democracy.

Allah says:

"And those who have responded to their lord and established prayer and whose affair is (determined by) consultation among themselves, and from what We have provided them, they spend." (Ash-Shura 42:38)

Implementation of Shari'ah Law:

The state is responsible for implementing Islamic law (Shari'ah), which covers all aspects of life, including worship, transactions, family law, and criminal justice.

Allah says:

"And whoever does not judge by what Allah has revealed - then it is those who are the disbelievers." (Al-Ma'idah 5:44)

This verse, and those following it (5:45, 5:47), strongly emphasize the obligation to rule by divine law.

Bay'ah (Pledge of Allegiance):

The leadership is established through a mutual contract between the ruler and the people, where the people pledge obedience in exchange for the ruler's commitment to govern justly according to Shari'ah.

The Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) said:

"He who dies without having pledged allegiance (to a Muslim ruler) dies the death of the Days of Ignorance (Jahiliyyah)." (Sahih Muslim)

2: Purpose: Justice, Welfare, and Moral Governance

The primary objectives of an Islamic State are to establish a just, prosperous, and morally upright society.

Establishing Justice ('Adl):

This is the cornerstone of Islamic governance. Justice is to be administered to all, regardless of faith, ethnicity, or social status.

Allah says:

"Indeed, Allah commands you to render trusts to whom they are due and when you judge between people to judge with justice." (An-Nisa 4:58)

Allah also says:

"O you who have believed, be persistently standing firm for Allah, witnesses in justice, and do not let the hatred of a people prevent you from being just. Be just; that is nearer to righteousness." (Al-Ma'idah 5:8)

Ensuring Public Welfare and Compassion (Rahmah):

The state is a vehicle for mercy and social welfare, responsible for the well-being of all its citizens.

The Prophet (ﷺ) said:

"The similitude of believers in regard to mutual love, affection, and fellow-feeling is that of one body; when any limb aches, the whole body responds with sleeplessness and fever." (Sahih Muslim)

The state must ensure the fulfilment of basic needs:

Food, shelter, clothing, and security for all. The Caliph Abu Bakr (RA) stated in his inaugural address;

"The weak among you shall be strong in my eyes until I secure their rights, and the strong among you shall be weak in my eyes until I take the rights from them."

Promoting Moral, Enjoining Good & Forbidding Evil:

The state has a responsibility to create a social environment that encourages virtue and discourages vice.

Allah says:

"You are the best nation produced (as an example) for mankind. You enjoin what is right and forbid what is wrong and believe in Allah." (Aali-Imran 3:110)

This is not merely a personal duty but an institutional one, implemented through education, social norms, and, where appropriate, state mechanisms, always within the boundaries of wisdom and justice.

3. Difference between Islamic and Secular Political Models

The Islamic political model differs fundamentally from the secular model.

Features of Islamic Model Vs Secular Model

1: Source of Sovereignty

In Islamic model, sovereignty belongs to Allah whose divine revelation is the supreme source of law.

In Secular model, sovereignty belongs to the people, human reason and popular opinion are the supreme sources of law.

2: Source of legislation

In Islamic model, the source of legislation is the revealed Text (Quran & Sunnah). Legislation must conform to divine principles. Human reasoning (Ijtihad) is used within this framework.

In Secular model, Human Reason & majority's opinion are the major sources. Laws are created by parliaments and can be changed by popular vote, with no higher moral reference than the will of the majority.

3: Objective of the State

In Islamic model, objective of the State is to facilitate the worship of God and establish His law on earth, ensuring justice and morality in this life and salvation in the hereafter.

In Secular model, objective of the State is to protect individual rights (especially liberty), promote material prosperity, and maintain public order. It is largely agnostic about the hereafter.

4: View of Human Nature

In Islamic model, the View of Human Nature is that the Humans are born with a natural disposition (Fitrah) to recognize God but are susceptible to weakness. The state helps nurture the Fitrah and restrain base desires.

In Secular model, it varies, but often views humans as rational, autonomous beings whose freedom should be maximized, with the state as a neutral arbiter.

5: Role of Religion

In Islamic model, role of Religion is integral. Religion is the foundation of public and private life. There is no separation between "mosque and state."

In Secular model, it is separated. Religion is largely a private matter and is separated from the functioning of the state and collective interest.

4: Overview of the Early Islamic State of Medina

The first Islamic State was established by the Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) in Medina after the Hijrah (622 CE). It serves as the ideal practical model.

Some key features of Early Islamic State

The Constitution of Medina (Sahifat al-Madinah):

This was a formal written document, often considered the first constitution in history. It established:

- 1- The Muslim community of Muhajirun (Emigrants) and Ansar (Helpers) as a single Ummah (nation), distinct from other tribes.
- 2- A political and legal alliance that included Jewish tribes and other non-Muslims living in Medina. They were granted religious freedom and cultural autonomy in exchange for loyalty and a commitment to collective defence.
- 3- The Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ) as the ultimate political and judicial authority.

A Multi-Religious Society:

The Medina state was not an exclusively Muslim entity. It was a pluralistic society where rights and duties were clearly defined for all citizens, Muslims and non-Muslims alike, under the overarching authority of Islamic law.

Practical Implementation of Principles:

- 1- **Justice:** The Prophet (ﷺ) was famous for his impartial justice. He said, "By Allah, if Fatimah, the daughter of Muhammad, were to steal, I would have her hand cut off." (Bukhari)
- 2- **Welfare:** The system of Zakat (obligatory alms) was institutionalized, creating the world's first formal welfare state to eradicate poverty.

- 3- **Consultation (Shura):** The Prophet (ﷺ) consistently consulted his companions on major affairs, such as the strategy for the Battle of Badr and the Treaty of Hudaibiyyah.

This state in Medina became the blueprint for the subsequent Caliphates (Rightly Guided Caliphs and beyond), demonstrating how Islamic principles could be translated into a functioning, just, and prosperous political reality.

Conclusion

In summary, the Islamic State is conceptualized as a moral and legal entity whose authority is derived from God and whose purpose is to establish divine justice, ensure universal welfare, and promote a virtuous society. It stands in stark contrast to secular models by its submission to a transcendent source of law. The State of Medina remains the historical exemplar, demonstrating the practical application of these ideals in a diverse and complex social setting.

The Rightly Guided Caliphate (Khilafah ar-Raashidah)

The Khilafah ar-Raashidah (The Rightly Guided Caliphate) of the first four caliphs—Abu Bakr, Umar, Uthman, and Ali (may Allah be pleased with them)—is revered in Islamic history as a golden age of leadership based on piety, justice, and consultation. Here is a detailed analysis of it as a role model, highlighting the points you requested.

The Paradigm of Rightly Guided Leadership

The Rashidun Caliphate (632-661 CE) emerged immediately after the death of Prophet Muhammad (ﷺ). It represents a 30-year period where leadership was exercised according to the principles of the Quran and the Prophet's Sunnah, with a profound emphasis on justice, accountability, and public welfare. It serves as a timeless political and ethical model for many Muslims.

1: Historical Background and Legitimacy

- 1- **Context:** The Caliphate began in 632 CE after the Prophet's demise, creating a crisis of succession. The Muslim community in Medina needed a leader to maintain unity and guide the nascent state.
- 2- **Legitimacy Source:** Its legitimacy was derived not from hereditary right or military power, but from consent of the community as per the guidance of Allah and His Prophet.
- 3- **Consent of the Community:** The leaders were chosen by prominent companions (the Sahabah) and pledged allegiance to by the public (Bay'ah).
- 4- **Adherence to Revelation:** The caliphs were bound by the Quran and Sunnah. Their authority was temporal, not prophetic; they were servants of the law, not its makers.
- 5- **Personal Merit (Piety and Competence):** The central criterion for leadership was Taqwa (God-consciousness) and proven capability, not tribal lineage or wealth.

2: Selection of the Khalifa Process

The process evolved, demonstrating a practical model of consultation (Shura).

- 1- **Abu Bakr (632-634):** Elected in the wake of crisis at the Saqifah of Bani Sa'idah. After debate, a majority of companions pledged allegiance to him, recognizing his status as the Prophet's chief companion and his unwavering faith. This established the principle of election by the elite on behalf of the community.
- 2- **Umar ibn al-Khattab (634-644):** Appointed by Abu Bakr on his deathbed. Crucially, this appointment was not unilateral; Abu Bakr consulted prominent companions, and his choice of Umar was then ratified by the public through Bay'ah. This combined nomination with public consent.
- 3- **Uthman ibn Affan (644-656):** Selected by a six-member electoral council (Shura) appointed by Umar. The council had a clear mandate to choose a leader from among themselves through consultation. This is one of the clearest historical examples of institutionalized Shura.
- 4- **Ali ibn Abi Talib (656-661):** Acclaimed by the majority of Muslims in Medina after the assassination of Uthman, in what was essentially a public demand due to his renowned justice and closeness to the Prophet.

3: Administrative Structure and Justice System

The Caliphate evolved from a simple city-state to a complex empire, developing sophisticated structures.

- 1- **Decentralized Administration:** The empire was divided into provinces (Egypt, Syria, Iraq, etc.), each governed by a Waali (governor) appointed by the Caliph.
- 2- **Separation of Treasury:** Bait-ul-Mal (the Public Treasury) was established as a sacred trust. Revenues from Zakat, Jizyah, and Khiraj (land tax) were strictly accounted for and spent on public welfare—salaries, infrastructure, and support for the poor.
- 3- **Independent Judiciary:** The judiciary was separate from the executive. Judges (Qazis) were appointed for their knowledge and integrity and had the power to rule against the state or the Caliph himself, as famously happened with Caliph Umar.

4: Public Welfare, Transparency, and Accountability

This is a cornerstone of the Rashidun model.

- 1- **Welfare State:** The state was responsible for the well-being of all citizens, Muslim and non-Muslim. Pensions were established for the elderly, widows, and orphans. During a famine, Umar ensured food reached every citizen.
- 2- **Radical Transparency:** Caliphs lived simple lives and their finances were open to public scrutiny. Umar was known to explain public spending in detail from the pulpit.

- 3- **Direct Accountability:** Any citizen could question the Caliph in the mosque. There are famous incidents where a common woman corrected Umar during a sermon, and he accepted her correction, saying, "The woman is right and Umar is wrong."

5: Notable Examples of Leadership

- 1- **Abu Bakr's** Inaugural Speech: "Obey me as long as I obey Allah and His Messenger. If I disobey Allah and His Messenger, you have no obligation to obey me." This established the principle of conditional obedience.
- 2- **Umar's** Simplicity: He slept on a simple palm mat, wore patched clothes, and ate simple food, fearing he would be held accountable for the slightest misuse of public funds.
- 3- **Ali's** Equal Justice: He lost a legal case regarding a shield because he lacked witnesses, while his opponent had one. The judge ruled against the Caliph, and Ali accepted the verdict without question.

6: Abu Bakr (RA): Stability and Unity

- 1- **Crisis Manager:** Faced immediate apostasy wars and false prophets. He took a firm, uncompromising stand to preserve the integrity of the Muslim community and faith.
- 2- **Unifier:** His famous declaration, "If they refuse to pay a single camel rope (in Zakat) which they used to pay to the Messenger of Allah, I will fight them for it," underscored his commitment to unity based on established principles.
- 3- **Consolidator:** He initiated the compilation of the Quran into a single manuscript, ensuring its preservation for future generations.

7: Umar (RA): Justice and Governance Reforms

- 1- **The Epitome of Justice:** Known as Al-Farooq (the Criterion between right and wrong). He institutionalized justice, establishing courts and a regular police force.
- 2- **Administrative Innovator:** Founded the Hijri calendar, established the Diwan (a register for state pensions and salaries), and organized a census. He systematized the land revenue system in conquered territories.
- 3- **Conqueror with Principle:** Oversaw the conquest of the Persian Empire and much of the Byzantine Empire, but always ensured that the rights of the conquered peoples were protected under Islamic law.

8: Uthman (RA): Expansion and Economic Development

- 1- **Naval Power:** Established the first Islamic navy.
- 2- **Final Compilation of Quran:** Standardized the Quranic text and destroyed variant copies to prevent dispute, a project of immense historical significance.
- 3- **Economic Prosperity:** His calm and benevolent rule saw massive economic prosperity and expansion of the state. He authorized individuals to purchase and develop unused state lands, stimulating agriculture and commerce.

- 4- **Infrastructure Development:** He expanded the Prophet's Mosque in Medina and secured the city's water supply by purchasing a well for public use.

9: Ali (RA): Civil Justice and Principled Leadership

- 1- **The Scholar-King:** Renowned for his profound knowledge and unwavering principles. His letters to governors, such as the famous letter to Malik al-Ashtar, are masterpieces of Islamic political philosophy, emphasizing justice, compassion, and service to the people.
- 2- **Zero Tolerance for Nepotism:** Immediately recalled and replaced corrupt governors appointed by his predecessor, even if it meant political alienation.
- 3- **Upholding the Rule of Law:** His commitment to justice was absolute, even when it was politically costly. He prioritized principle over political expediency, setting a timeless example of integrity in leadership.

Conclusion

The Khilafah ar-Raashidah stands as a powerful role model not for its territorial expanse, but for its ethical and administrative principles. Its legacy is one of Shura (consultation), Adl (justice), Accountability, and Public Service. It demonstrates that an Islamic state is one where the ruler is a servant of the people and the law, where the treasury is a sacred trust, and where the ultimate goal of governance is to establish justice and enable the people to live dignified lives in accordance with their faith.

Islam, Science & Atheism: Exploring the Intersection of Knowledge, Faith, and the Concept of God

In an era where science has made monumental strides, the question of the existence of God and the relationship between scientific knowledge and religious beliefs has become a major point of debate. The growing belief in **atheism** often arises from a perception that modern scientific discoveries negate the need for a Creator. This article explores the complex relationship between **science**, **Islam**, and **atheism**, providing insight into how scientific knowledge can facilitate, rather than negate, the concept of God.

Science and Religion: Complementary Domains

For centuries, **science** and **religion** were viewed as opposing forces, especially during the conflict between the Church and early scientists like **Galileo**. However, a closer examination reveals that **science** and **religion** are not mutually exclusive but rather serve complementary purposes.

- **Science and "How"**: Science is fundamentally concerned with the **mechanisms** of the universe. It answers questions like "How did the universe evolve?" and "How do biological processes occur?" It explains the workings of nature and the functioning of the human body, from the development of a human fetus to the complex processes governing the universe.
- **Religion and "Who"**: While science answers "how," it does not address the profound question of "Who." **Religion** addresses the **origin** of the universe and life, focusing on the **Creator** behind these processes. The existence of **God** is outside the scope of scientific inquiry but remains central to theological understanding. As science delves into the **laws of nature**, religion contemplates the **purpose** and **origin** of these laws.

In this context, **science** and **religion** operate in different spheres: science explains the processes, while religion provides answers to the origin and purpose behind those processes. The two fields should be viewed as complementary rather than opposing.

The Big Bang and the Early Universe

- **Big Bang Theory**: The universe began as a **singularity** around **13.8 billion years ago** in an event known as the **Big Bang**. The universe expanded rapidly, marking the start of **cosmic inflation**. This period of rapid expansion occurred faster than the speed of light and set the stage for the formation of matter.
- **Formation of Matter**: As inflation slowed, energy converted into **matter** and **light**, forming **protons**, **neutrons**, and **electrons**, the fundamental building blocks of the universe.

- **Scientific Validation:** The Big Bang is no longer just a theory; it is considered an **established fact** due to the observation of **energy spectrums** and the **cosmic microwave background radiation (CMBR)**, discovered in 1965 by **Arno Penzias** and **Robert Wilson**.

The Cosmic Dark Ages and Reionization

- **Cosmic Dark Ages:** After the Big Bang, the universe entered the **cosmic dark ages**, lasting around **200 million years**, when the universe was too opaque for light to travel freely.
- **Reionization:** The formation of the first stars, around **1 billion years after the Big Bang**, released **ultraviolet light**, reionizing hydrogen atoms and making the universe transparent. These stars were incredibly massive, **30 to 300 times the mass of the Sun**, and millions of times brighter, leading to the formation of the **first galaxies**.

The Size and Scope of the Universe

- **Observable Universe:** The observable universe is **enormously vast**, measuring over **46 billion light-years** in any direction, with an estimated **93 billion light-years** in diameter. The universe contains about **100 billion to 2 trillion galaxies**.
- **The Milky Way:** Our galaxy, the **Milky Way**, is estimated to be between **100,000 to 200,000 light-years** across, containing around **200-400 billion stars**. This scale exemplifies the **immensity** and **complexity** of the universe.

Creation Ex Nihilo (Creation Out of Nothing)

- **Singularity:** The universe's origin from a **singularity** (a point with infinite density and zero volume) aligns with the **concept of creation ex nihilo**—creation from nothing. This idea was first proposed by **Edwin Hubble** in 1929, who observed that all galaxies are moving away from each other, indicating that they originated from a **single point**.
- **Cosmic Microwave Background Radiation:** CMBR provides **strong evidence** of the universe's **origin** from a singularity. It is the faint glow left from the Big Bang, spread across 2.5% of the sky, showing fluctuations that later formed galaxies and superclusters.
- **Theology and Science:** The notion of **creation ex nihilo** suggests that the universe was created from **nothing**, raising the question of **how the first matter** came into existence. According to **Stephen Hawking**, the universe emerged from **quantum fluctuations**, but this explanation does not address who **directed** or **guided** these fluctuations.

The Problem of Self-Creation: Who Directed the Laws?

- **Hawking's View:** Stephen Hawking argued in his book *The Grand Design* that the universe created itself from **nothing**, guided by the laws of physics. However, this raises a fundamental question: **Who guided these laws?** The existence of natural laws does not explain the **origins** of the universe or their **purpose**.
- **Clive Staples Lewis' Refutation:** C.S. Lewis refuted the idea that **laws of nature** could create events. He compared the laws to an **instruction manual**—they describe patterns, but do not **initiate** events. **Laws** do not cause events; something **else** must set the events in motion.
- **John Lennox's View:** John Lennox pointed out that the **laws of gravity** and **other natural laws** depend on the prior existence of **matter**, **energy**, and **space**. Therefore, these laws cannot explain the **origin of matter** or how the universe came into being.

Conscious vs. Unconscious Creation

- **Unconscious Creation:** One perspective argues that the universe emerged from an **unconscious entity** that created everything, guided by **physical laws**. However, this idea is challenged by the **intelligent design** evident in the universe's **fine-tuning**.
- **Conscious Creation:** The alternative is that an **intelligent, conscious being** (God) created the universe with purpose and design. **Consciousness**, **design**, and **intelligent guidance** cannot be attributed to an **unconscious entity**.

Fine-Tuning of the Universe: Evidence of Intelligent Design

- **Fine-Tuning of Physical Constants:** Modern physics reveals that the universe is finely tuned to support life. Small variations in **physical constants**—such as the **expansion rate of the universe**, the **speed of light**, or the **strength of gravitational and electromagnetic forces**—would make life impossible. This precise fine-tuning is considered **evidence of intelligent design**.
- **Violation of Thermodynamic Laws:** The **First Law of Thermodynamics** (energy can neither be created nor destroyed) raises questions about the creation of the first **energy** in the Big Bang. Similarly, the **Second Law of Thermodynamics** (entropy always increases) contradicts the **high degree of order** observed in the universe, suggesting external **intervention** or **guidance**.

The Structure of an Atom as Evidence of Creation

- **Atomic Stability:** The stability of an **atom**—despite the conflicting forces of positively charged protons and negatively charged electrons—demonstrates a

highly complex, designed system. The **structure of an atom** is the result of multiple **forces** (electromagnetic, nuclear) and **principles** (Pauli Exclusion Principle, quantum mechanics), which govern its stability.

- **The Impossibility of Random Formation:** The atom's **complexity** cannot be explained by chance or random processes. A slight variation in the forces and principles that govern atomic structure would result in the collapse of the atom, indicating **intentional design**.

Darwinism and Creation: The Challenge of Natural Selection

One of the most widely discussed theories in the modern era is **Darwin's theory of evolution**, which posits that species evolve through **natural selection**. This idea is often seen as a challenge to the notion of a **creator**, suggesting that life on Earth emerged through natural processes without divine intervention.

- **Darwin's Theory:** According to **Darwin**, organisms evolve over time by adapting to their environments through **natural selection**, where the best-suited organisms survive and reproduce. While this theory explains how species **adapt** to their environments, it does not provide an explanation for the **origin of life** or the **first living organism**.
- **Limitations of Darwinism:** Darwinism does not explain the **origin of life** itself. The theory of **natural selection** assumes that life already exists and focuses on how species evolve over time. However, **how life began**, from non-living matter to the first living cell, remains an unresolved question. This gap in Darwin's theory opens the door for the argument of **intelligent design**, which posits that life is the product of a **creator's plan**.
- **The Complexity of DNA:** One of the most compelling arguments against the idea that life arose purely by chance is the **complexity of DNA**. The **structure of DNA** is like a **digital code**, storing detailed information on how to build proteins and cells. The intricate design of DNA suggests that the information encoded in life cannot be the product of **random processes**. Instead, it points toward **intelligent design**.
- **Challenges to Evolution by Chance:** The probability of life forming by **random chance** is so astronomically low that some cosmologists, like **Fred Hoyle**, argue that it is effectively impossible. Hoyle calculated the odds of forming a simple protein through random processes as 1 in **1040,000**—far smaller than the number of particles in the observable universe.

- **The Improbability of Life by Chance:** Even if every event in the history of the universe was devoted to creating the building blocks of life, the odds of forming a functional protein by chance are infinitesimally small. This improbability leads many to believe in **intelligent design** rather than pure **Darwinian evolution**.

Creation vs. Darwinism: The Role of Intelligent Design

The complexity of life on Earth, particularly at the molecular level, challenges the idea that **life** could have arisen purely by random processes.

- **DNA as Evidence of Intelligent Design:** The structure of **DNA** resembles a **computer code**, containing vast amounts of information necessary for building proteins and cells. The **sequence hypothesis** developed by **Francis Crick** and **James Watson** posits that specific sequences of DNA bases function like letters in a written language, conveying instructions for the assembly of proteins. This **information** within DNA suggests that it is the product of **intelligent design** rather than random events.
- **Irreducible Complexity:** Some biological systems, such as the **human eye** or the **cell's molecular machinery**, are so complex that they could not function if any part of the system were missing. This idea of **irreducible complexity** suggests that these systems must have been designed as a whole, rather than evolving through gradual steps.
- **The Improbability of Life's Origin:** The odds of forming a functional protein or a complete living organism by chance alone are so small that it seems more likely that an **intelligent designer** was involved in the creation of life. This view is supported by the fact that complex molecular systems like DNA could not have emerged from random processes, given the vast amount of **specificity** required.

Mathematical Foundation: God as the First Cause

The question of the origin of life and the universe brings us to the **First Cause** argument: everything that exists must have had a cause, and ultimately, there must be an **uncaused cause**—God.

- **Mathematical Recurrence:** A recurrence relation like $a_{n+1} = f(a_n)$ illustrates how every sequence depends on an initial condition. Without the **first term** ($a_0 = 1$), there would be no sequence. Similarly, the universe depends on a **First Cause**—**God**, who initiated everything. This argument is aligned with both **philosophical**

and **mathematical** principles, showing that the universe must have had an uncaused origin.

- **Philosophical Interpretation:** The concept of **God as the First Cause** is rooted in classical philosophical thought. The idea of a **necessary being**—one that exists by necessity and causes everything else to exist—aligns with the concept of God as the **First Cause** of the universe. **God** is the **uncaused cause**, the foundational principle upon which all things depend.
- **The Uniqueness of 1:** In mathematics, **1** represents **unity** and is the **multiplicative identity**. Just as **1** is the foundation for all numbers in mathematics, **God** is the foundation of all existence. The number **1** symbolizes the **oneness** of God, as emphasized in monotheistic traditions.

Conversion of Leading Atheists to Belief in God

Over the years, many prominent scientists and philosophers who were once atheists have converted to belief in God, largely due to the overwhelming complexity and evidence of intelligent design found in **nature** and **DNA**.

- **Antony Flew's Conversion:** **Antony Flew**, one of the most famous atheists of the 20th century, converted to belief in God after examining the scientific evidence for **intelligent design** in **DNA**. Flew admitted that the **complexity of life** and the **precise arrangement** of genetic material pointed to a **designer** rather than random processes. He acknowledged that the complexity of **DNA** could not have arisen by chance.
- **Dr. Maurice Bucaille:** Bucaille, a **French surgeon**, was initially skeptical about the scientific accuracy of the **Qur'an**. However, after examining the **Qur'anic descriptions** of medical and anatomical phenomena, he concluded that the Qur'an could not have been authored by a 7th-century man but must have been divinely inspired. He later converted to Islam and authored a book, *The Bible, The Qur'an, and Science*, which explored the scientific accuracy of the Qur'an.
- **Dr. Gary Miller:** A **Canadian mathematician** and preacher, **Dr. Gary Miller** converted to Islam after studying the Qur'an and its alignment with **scientific knowledge**. Miller found that the Qur'an contained scientific facts that were not known at the time of its revelation, such as the description of **embryology** and **the origin of life** from water.
- **Dr. Lawrence Brown:** **Dr. Lawrence Brown**, an ophthalmologist, became a Muslim after studying the Qur'an and seeing how its teachings on **monotheism** and **prophethood** aligned with his understanding of **truth**. His conversion was

influenced by his search for answers in life, which he found in the **Islamic worldview**.

Islam and Science: Qur'anic Insights and Modern Discoveries

Embryology and the Qur'an

- A group of researchers in **Riyadh, Saudi Arabia** consulted **Dr. Keith Moore**, a renowned **embryologist** from the University of Toronto, to assess the accuracy of the **Qur'anic verses** on embryology. Dr. Moore, an expert in the field, was surprised by the findings and updated his textbooks after discovering that the **Qur'an** accurately described aspects of human development that were unknown until recently.
- **Key Discovery:** One significant finding was the Qur'an's description of the human embryo as a **“leech-like clot”** (**‘alaqah**), which matches the appearance of the embryo in the early stages of development. Dr. Moore found this description true, which led him to include the information in the second edition of his textbook *Before We Are Born*.
- **Further Insights:** Dr. Moore's collaboration in Riyadh and the subsequent changes in his work highlight how **Qur'anic knowledge** preceded modern scientific understanding in the field of **embryology**.

Geology and the Qur'an

- **Professor Marshall Johnson**, a colleague of Dr. Moore and a **geologist** at the University of Toronto, was intrigued by the Qur'an's accuracy regarding **embryology**. He asked Muslims to gather all verses related to **geology** in the Qur'an. The findings were equally surprising, showing that the Qur'an contained accurate statements about geological phenomena that align with modern scientific knowledge.
- **Conclusion:** Both embryology and geology in the Qur'an illustrate that the Qur'an provides scientifically accurate descriptions long before modern research confirmed these facts.

The Female Bee

- **Surah an-Nahl (16:68-69)** mentions that the **female bee** leaves its home to gather food. This fact, though seemingly simple, was **not widely known** at the time the Qur'an was revealed. It wasn't until recent studies that it was discovered that **only female bees** leave the hive to collect nectar, while male bees stay inside.

- **Misconceptions:** In Shakespeare's time, bees were believed to be male, but modern science corrected this misconception. The Qur'an's accuracy on this point, despite common belief at the time, reinforces its **scientific credibility**.

Expanding Universe

- **Discovery of the Expanding Universe:** The concept of an **expanding universe** was first revealed by **Edwin Hubble** in 1929 and confirmed in 1965 by **Arno Penzias and Robert Wilson**, who discovered **cosmic microwave background radiation** (CMBR). This finding earned them the **Nobel Prize** in 1978 and was a major breakthrough in understanding the universe's **expansion**.
- **Qur'anic Reference:** The **Qur'an** mentions the **expansion of the universe** in **Surah Al-Fatir (35:41)**, stating that God is continually expanding the universe. This **scientific fact**, confirmed by modern astronomy, was described in the Qur'an more than **1400 years ago**.

360 Joints in the Human Body

- The discovery of **360 joints** in the human body, a fact recognized by modern science, was mentioned in the **Hadith** of **Sahih Muslim**. This hadith states that **each human being has 360 joints**, a fact that would have been **impossible to know** in the 7th century without **divine guidance**.

The Light of the Moon

- **The Nature of Moonlight:** The Qur'an describes the **moon's light** in **Surah Al-Furqan (25:61)** as **reflected light** rather than emitted light. Modern science confirms that the moon does not generate its own light but **reflects the sunlight**. The Qur'an differentiates between the sun's **shining light** (siraaaj) and the moon's **reflected light** (muneer), which was **scientifically accurate** long before this distinction was understood.

Small Brain in the Heart

The Qur'an discusses the concept of a "**small brain**" in the heart, a notion that aligns with modern discoveries in **Neurocardiology**. Dr. **John Andrew Armour** first introduced the concept of a **complex network of neurons** in the heart, which functions independently of the brain. This discovery, that the heart contains around **40,000 neurons**, validates the Qur'anic mention of the heart's role in human physiology, linking **mind and emotions** to the heart.

The Prophet Muhammad (a) as a Role Model

Importance of Role Models in Personal and Social Development

Role models are essential for guiding individuals in their personal growth and social development. According to social learning theory, people often emulate the behaviors, attitudes, and actions of those they admire. The Prophet Muhammad (a) provides the perfect model of human excellence. His life serves as an ethical compass that teaches individuals how to lead a life of righteousness, mercy, and justice. In Islam, he is regarded as the "**Uswah Hasanah**" (the best example) for all Muslims. As the final prophet, his example encompasses both personal virtue and the broader social ethics required to build a just and moral society.

The Qur'anic Perspective of the Prophet (a) as a Role Model for Mankind

The Qur'an makes it clear that the Prophet Muhammad (a) is the ideal role model for all the mankind. His character, conduct, and moral principles are intended to serve as a source of guidance for anyone who wishes to attain righteousness and spiritual success.

"Indeed, in the Messenger of Allah you have an excellent pattern (uswah hasanah) for anyone whose hope is in Allah and the Last Day and who remembers Allah often."

(Surah Al-Ahzab 33:21)

This verse emphasizes that the Prophet's actions and behavior are a perfect model for anyone who believes in Allah and the Last Day. The concept of "**uswah hasanah**" suggests that his life is a living example for Muslims to follow, providing clarity on how to balance faith, personal conduct, and social responsibility.

The Prophet (a) as a Role Model in Personal Conduct

Truthfulness (As-Sadiq) and Trustworthiness (Al-Amin)

The Prophet Muhammad (a) was known as *As-Sadiq* (The Truthful) and *Al-Amin* (The Trustworthy) even before he was appointed as the Prophet of Islam. These traits were part of his character, and they were instrumental in gaining the trust of the people of Makkah. His honesty and integrity made him a respected figure, even among his enemies. This reputation for truthfulness was essential in establishing his credibility as the final Messenger.

One powerful example of his trustworthiness can be seen when he was entrusted with the keys to the Kaaba by the Quraysh, the very people who later opposed him. His commitment to truthfulness is exemplified in the following hadith:

"When you tell a man something, it is as if you have entrusted him with a trust."

(Sahih Muslim)

His ability to keep trust, even when persecuted, provides an inspiring model of moral strength in the face of adversity.

Humility and Simplicity

Despite his position as the leader of the Muslim community, the Prophet (a) led a life of extreme humility and simplicity. He wore simple clothing, ate basic food, and lived in modest accommodations. His personal life was in stark contrast to the materialism and pride seen in the leadership of many contemporary rulers. For example, Aisha (RA) narrated:

"The Prophet (a) never ate on a table, nor did he sit on a soft couch. His diet was simple, and he lived in the most modest of homes."

(Sahih Muslim)

His humility was not only seen in his lifestyle but also in his interactions with others. He never sought power or wealth for personal gain, and his behavior set an example of how to live simply and without arrogance. The Qur'an reminds the Prophet to be humble:

"And do not turn your cheek in pride toward people, nor walk through the earth exultantly."

(Surah Luqman 31:18)

Patience and Perseverance in Adversity

The Prophet Muhammad (a) faced immense hardship, including the persecution of his followers, the loss of loved ones, and the rejection of his message. Despite this, he exhibited unwavering patience and perseverance. His patience during the years of persecution in Makkah is a remarkable example for Muslims. The Qur'an emphasizes the virtue of patience:

"So be patient, indeed, the promise of Allah is truth."

(Surah Ar-Rum 30:60)

The Battle of Uhud provides another example of his perseverance. After the defeat of the Muslim army, the Prophet (a) encouraged his companions to remain steadfast in faith. He remained hopeful and motivated despite personal losses. His patience, particularly in times of adversity, provides a lesson for Muslims to remain steadfast in their struggles.

Spiritual Devotion and Connection with Allah

The Prophet Muhammad (a) maintained a constant and deep spiritual connection with Allah. His worship and prayer (particularly the night prayer, *tahajjud*) were integral to his life. His deep devotion is evidenced in the following incident:

“The Prophet (a) would stand in prayer for so long that his feet would swell. When Aisha (RA) asked him why, he replied, 'Should I not be a grateful servant?'"
(Sahih Bukhari)

This demonstrates his intense devotion and gratitude toward Allah. The Qur'an commands the Prophet to engage in constant remembrance of Allah:

“And worship your Lord until there comes to you the certainty (death).”
(Surah Al-Hijr 15:99)

His commitment to prayer and remembrance serves as a model of spiritual devotion for all Muslims.

The Prophet (a) as a Role Model in Family Life

Kindness and Justice Toward Spouses

The Prophet Muhammad (a) set a high standard for marital relations, emphasizing kindness, respect, and justice. He treated his wives with love and care, and his marriage to Khadija (RA) was one of the most famous examples of mutual respect and affection. The Prophet (a) said:

"The best of you are those who are the best to their wives."
(Tirmidhi)

He demonstrated this in his personal interactions, helping with household chores, offering emotional support, and listening to their concerns. His fairness in marriage was also evident in how he divided his time and resources equally among his wives.

Compassionate Parenting

The Prophet Muhammad (a) was a loving and compassionate father. He treated his children with tenderness and affection. He was particularly close to his daughters, especially Fatimah (RA), whom he held in great esteem. He would greet her warmly, kiss her, and stand up for her whenever she entered the room. The Prophet's love for his children is seen in his famous statement:

“He is not one of us who does not show mercy to our children.”
(Sahih Muslim)

The Prophet emphasized the importance of showing love and affection to children, ensuring their emotional and moral development.

Maintaining Strong Family Bonds

The Prophet (a) was a proponent of maintaining strong family ties, even in times of difficulty. His treatment of his family members, particularly his daughters, demonstrates

the importance of nurturing family relationships. The Qur'an instructs believers to uphold the rights of their family members:

“And lower to them the wing of humility out of mercy and say, 'My Lord, have mercy upon them as they brought me up [when I was] small.'”

(Surah Al-Isra 17:24)

The Prophet's emphasis on maintaining close and loving family relationships provides a model for Muslims in upholding these ties.

Respect for Women and Emphasis on Mutual Rights

The Prophet Muhammad (a) elevated the status of women in society. Before Islam, women had limited rights in many parts of the world. The Prophet (a) established women's right to inheritance, education, and involvement in societal affairs. His treatment of women, particularly in his family, was exemplary. He said:

"The best of you are those who are the best to their wives."

(Tirmidhi)

His treatment of women reflects a deep respect for their dignity and autonomy, and he emphasized the importance of mutual rights and responsibilities in marriage. In his Farewell Sermon, the Prophet reminded the men:

“Fear Allah concerning women.”

(Muslim)

This statement underscores the ethical treatment of women in both private and public spheres.

The Prophet (a) as a Role Model in Society

Social Justice and Equality

The Prophet Muhammad (a) was a strong advocate for social justice, equality, and the elimination of oppression. His teachings promoted equality among all people, irrespective of race, gender, or social status. During his final sermon, he declared:

“All mankind is from Adam and Eve. An Arab has no superiority over a non-Arab, nor does a non-Arab have any superiority over an Arab.”

(Musnad Ahmad)

This declaration shattered the hierarchical systems of pre-Islamic Arabia and promoted a society based on piety and righteousness, not lineage or social status. The Prophet's life exemplified these principles, and he consistently fought for justice, regardless of a person's background.

Concern for the Poor, Orphans, and Marginalized

The Prophet Muhammad (a) consistently advocated for the marginalized, including the poor, orphans, and the vulnerable members of society. The Qur'an directs the Prophet and the Muslim community to care for these groups:

“And give to the near of kin his due, and to the needy, and to the wayfarer.”

(Surah Al-Isra 17:26)

The Prophet himself was generous, giving away whatever he had to help those in need. He said:

“I and the one who takes care of an orphan will be together in Paradise like this.”

(Bukhari)

His concern for the underprivileged serves as a model for Muslims to prioritize social welfare and justice.

Respect for Diversity and Coexistence with Non-Muslims

The Prophet Muhammad (a) established a society in Madinah that respected diversity and included people of various faiths and backgrounds. The **Constitution of Madinah**, a treaty between Muslims, Jews, and other groups, exemplified his commitment to peaceful coexistence. The Qur'an emphasizes the importance of respecting people of different beliefs:

“To you your religion, and to me my religion.”

(Surah Al-Kafirun 109:6)

The Prophet's interactions with non-Muslims, whether in trade, diplomacy, or day-to-day life, demonstrated his approach to inclusivity and tolerance.

Promotion of Honesty, Integrity, and Public Ethics

The Prophet Muhammad (a) stressed the importance of honesty and integrity in both personal and public life. He forbade bribery, false testimony, and any form of dishonesty. In one of his famous hadiths, he said:

“Whoever deceives us is not one of us.”

(Muslim)

His emphasis on integrity helped build a trustworthy society where truthfulness and transparency were prioritized, laying the groundwork for ethical governance.

Conclusion

The life of Prophet Muhammad (a) offers an exhaustive and unparalleled model for personal, familial, social, and leadership conduct. His teachings transcend the boundaries of time and place, offering guidance that is applicable to contemporary challenges. His

example serves as a beacon for those seeking justice, compassion, and integrity, and his legacy continues to inspire Muslims and non-Muslims alike in their pursuit of moral excellence.